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October 23, 2026

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e-Procurement Notice
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Executive Engineer HPPWD Rampur Division on behalf of Governor of H.P. invites the percentage rate bids, in electronic tendering, system from the eligible class of contractors registered with HPPWD for the works as detailed in the table.

Sr. No.1 :- Name of Work :- C/O road from Dandol to Kashapat Km. 0/000 to 13/280 (SH:- Providing crash barrier at various vulnerable spots).,**Estimated cost:-** 1,94,98,877/-, **Starting Date for downloading Bid:-** 29.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** 3,89,978/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-** 04.11.2026.

Sr. No.2 :- Name of Work :- C/O Lalsa Shandal Bhalidhar road Km. 0/000 to 9/500 (SH:- ROFD in various RDs), **Estimated cost:-** 14,30,000/-, **Starting Date for downloading Bid:-** 29.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** 28,600/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-** 04.11.2026.

Sr. No.3 :- Name of Work :- C/O link road from Hotel Bushahr Regency to Khopari Lalsa Km. 0/000 to 1/050 (SH:- Formation cutting and R/wall at various RDs), **Estimated cost:-** 28,80,000/-, **Starting Date for downloading Bid:-** 29.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** 57,600/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-** 04.11.2026.

Sr. No.4 :- Name of Work :- C/O link road to village Chikri Km. 0/000 to 0/550 (SH:- C/O R/wall & B/wall at various RDs), **Estimated cost:-** 9,85,000/-, **Starting Date for downloading Bid:-** 29.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** 19,700/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-** 04.11.2026.

The bidders are advised to note other *details* of tenders form the department website www.hptenders.gov.in. The undersigned has right to extend or cancel the tender without declaring any reason.

Executive Engineer,
Rampur Division (B&R),
HPPWD, Rampur Bushahr.
On behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh

HP / 4265/26-27 **HIM SUCHNA AVAM JAN SAMPARK**

AP POWER GENERATION CORPORATION Ltd., VS, VIJAYAWADA-520004
(A Govt. of A.P Undertaking)

NIT.No. 1004796

APGENCO invites open tenders for "Supply of 750 KVA(600KW) Diesel Generator set including AMF panel installation, testing and commissioning for stage-III, Dr.NTTPS including mandatory spares" through AP e-procurement. **EVC Rs.1,05,87,000/-**
Schedule available Date & Time: **16.10.2026 - 20:00 Hrs** onwards
Bid submission Closing Date & Time: **02.11.2026-12.00 Hrs**
For other details visit the website: **https://tender.apeprocurement.gov.in**
DIPR 5519PP/CL, Dt: 22-10-2026

J&K Bank
Serving To Empower

Jammu and Kashmir Bank
Estates & Engineering Department,
Corporate Headquarters, Srinagar,
M. A. Road Srinagar, 190 001 J&K

On-Line Tender (e-NIT) for Selection / Engagement of Agency for conducting space Audit at various branches (including onsite ATMS)/ Offices of the bank spread in geographical area across the territory of India

Tender Notice along with Complete Tender document outlining the minimum requirements can be downloaded from and BIDs can be submitted on the Banks' e-Tendering Portal https://jkbank.abcprocure.com w.e.f. October 22, 2026, 16.00 Hrs. Tender Document can also be downloaded from Bank's Official Website https://jkb.bank.in/tenderNotice. Last date for submission of Bids is November 12, 2026, 17.00 Hrs.
e-NIT Ref.No . JKB/E&ED/Space-Audit/2026-1925
Dated: 21-10-2026

Registered office : Corporate Headquarters, M.A.Road, Srinagar 190001, Kashmir, India
CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048 ; **T :** +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 ; **F :** +91 (0)194 248 1928;
E : info@jkbmail.com ; **W :** https://Jkb.bank.in

HIMACHAL PRADESH PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
E-mail ID: eepwd-jawalamukhi@hp.gov.in
INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The **Executive Engineer Jawalamukhi Division HPPWD Jawalamukhi H.P.** on behalf of Governor of H.P. invites the percentage rate bids,in the electronic tendering system from the eligible class of contractors registered with HPPWD for the works as detailed in the table.

Sr. No. 1
Name of Work:-Construction of P.H.C Buliding (Health Institution Level II) at Salihar, Tehsil Khundian, Distt. Kangra (H.P). (SH:- Construction of Main Building including Water Supply & Sanitary Installation, Septic Tank and Rain Water Harvesting System & Site Development). **Estimated Cost (Rs.):-** Rs 1,11,85,315 /-, **Starting date for downloading Bid:-** 21.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** Rs 2,24,000/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-** 27.10.2026 5PM, **Time Limit:-**Nine month.

Sr. No. 2
Name of Work:-Constrcution of Stadium at Govt,, Sen, Sec (Boys) School at Jawalamukhi Tehsil jawalamukhi Distt Kangra (H.P) (SH:- C/O Ground Steps & Under Ground Drain) **Estimated Cost (Rs.):-** Rs 7,54,693/-, **Starting date for downloading Bid:-**21.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** Rs 15,000/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-** 27.10.2026 5PM, **Time Limit:-**One month.

Sr. No. 3
Name of Work:-Upgradation/ Metalling & Tarring of Link Road along with C/O Bridges 2 Nos over Tahal Khad From Dhatti to Kural via Jiara, Matehar, Bhatwal, Jamuli, Rohal Km 0/00 to 7/685 in District Kangra (HP) (SH:- Prepration of Geotechnical Investigation Report of two nos bridges. **Estimated Cost (Rs.):-** Rs 4,67,820/-, **Starting date for downloading Bid:-** 21.10.2026, **Earnest Money:-** Rs 10,000/-, **Deadline for submission of Bid:-**27.10.2026 5PM, **Time Limit:-** One month

The bidders are advised to note other details of tender form the department website .www.hptenders.gov in.
Date of opening of tender 28.10.2026 11. 30 AM

Executive Engineer,
Jawalamukhi Division HP.PWD., Jawalamukhi
Pin No. 176031.
e-mail:- eepwd-jawalamukhi@hp.gov.in
on behalf of Governor of Himachal Pradesh

HP / 4261/26-27 HIM LOK SAMPARK

KALOJI NARAYANA RAO UNIVERSITY OF HEALTH SCIENCES
WARANGAL, TELANGANA

NOTIFICATION FOR REGISTRATION OF CANDIDATES FOR ADMISSION INTO MEDICAL PG DEGREE/DIPLOMA COURSES UNDER MANAGEMENT QUOTA – MQ1, MQ2/NRI & MQ3/INSTITUTIONAL QUOTA FOR THE ACADEMIC YEAR 2026-27

Applications through online are invited from NEET-PG 2026 qualified candidates for admission into Medical PG Degree/Diploma Courses under Management Quota into Medical colleges affiliated to KNRUHS from 22.10.2026 to 30.10.2026.

For detailed notification, refer to **http:// knruhs.telangana.gov.in**

Date: 22.10.2026 **Sd/-**
DIPR R.O. No. : 674-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27, Date: 22-10-2026. **REGISTRAR**

TAMILNADU NEWSPRINT AND PAPERS LIMITED
Kagithapuram - 639 136. Karur Dist. Tamil Nadu.

NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Tender No.	Material Description	Due date
262723 003117	Design, Manufacture, Supply, Supervision of Erection and Commissioning of Wood Dust Firing System for 250 TPD Lime Mud Reburning Rotary Kiln in TNPL Unit II	12.11.2026
262713 004673	Procurement of Cationic Starch (in Jumbo Bags) for Unit-I	05.11.2026
262713 004674	Procurement of Caustic Soda Lye for Unit - I & Unit - II	06.11.2026
262713 004703	Procurement of Fuel Oil for Unit - I & II	05.11.2026

Corrigendum if any will be issued in TNPL Website and NIC Portal only Detailed Terms & Conditions, Tender Fee, EMD etc. are available in tender document at our websites : **www.tnpl.com / www.tenders.tn.gov.in / www.tntenders.gov.in / nicgep/app**

DIPR/3181/Tender/2026 *TNPL - Maker of bagasse based eco-friendly Paper*

BSES
BSES Yamuna Power Limited

BSES Yamuna Power Limited, Delhi
... A joint venture with Govt. of NCT of Delhi

NOTICE INVITING TENDER **Date: 23.10.2026**

E-tenders are invited under the **Two-Bid System (Un-priced & Priced Bid)** for the following works:

NIT No.	Brief Description	EMD Value (₹)	Cost of each Tender Document (non-refundable)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & time of opening
CMC/26-27/BY/CR/PT/RB/AS/JYS/33 [RFx No.: 2200000263]	Scheme No. A) **KW24NF4030,** New 11 kv Feeder at Sstn G5 V Pusta Sonia Vihar and B) **KW25NF4014,** Laying Of 11 kv Feeder from HT Feeder from Sonia Vihar Grid to Chauhanpatti Bus Stand.	2.4 Lakhs	1180/-	12.11.2026 at 15:00 Hrs	12.11.2026 at 15:30 Hrs

For detailed information on the Equipment, Bill of Materials (BOM), Services, Qualifying Requirements, Terms and Conditions, Technical Specifications, and submission of Tender Documents - including any corrigendum - please visit our website at www.bsesdelhi.com → BSES Yamuna Power Ltd → Tenders →Open Tenders, or access our e-tendering portal at **https://srmprdportal.bsesdelhi.com/irj/portal.**

Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd.Off: BSES Yamuna Power Ltd, Shakti Kiran Building, Karkardooma, Delhi-110032 | CIN: U40109DL2001PLC111525
Website: www.bsesdelhi.com TEL: 011-41247111

बिहार सरकार
कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय,
भवन निर्माण विभाग, भवन प्रमंडल, मधुबनी।

राष्ट्रीय / स्पर्द्धा निविदा पद्धति के अनुसार एवं www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in पर

ई0– निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

शुद्धि–पत्र

ई0 निविदा संख्या 24 /BCD MADHUBANI /2026-27, जिसका पी0आर0 सं0– 009410 (BCD) 2026–27 है (**कार्य का नाम** :– Construction of 620 Capacity Atal kala Bhawan in Madhubani District for the year-2026-27 (With electrification work) में अपरिहार्य कारणवश निम्नवत् संशोधन किया जाता है :–

क्र0		पूर्व की तिथि	विस्तारित तिथि	पुनः विस्तारित तिथि
01	निविदा कागजात प्राप्त (डाउनलोड) एवं निविदा (अपलोड) करने की तिथि एवं समय	28 / 08 / 2026 से 21 / 09 / 2026 के 3:00 बजे अप0	28 / 09 / 2026 से 21 / 10 / 2026 के 3:00 बजे अप0	10 / 10 / 2026 से 02 / 11 / 2026 के 3:00 बजे अप0
02	टेकनीकल बीड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	23 / 09 / 2026 के 3:30 बजे अप0।	23 / 10 / 2026 के 3:30 बजे अप0।	04 / 11 / 2026 के 3:30 बजे अप0।
03	वित्तीय बीड खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	तकनीकी बीड निष्पादन के पश्चात्।	तकनीकी बीड निष्पादन के पश्चात्।	तकनीकी बीड निष्पादन के पश्चात्।
04	प्रिबीड मिटिंग की तिथि समय एवं स्थान	दिनांक 11.09.2026 को 12:30 बजे अप0 अधीक्षण अभियंता, भवन अंचल, दरभंगा का कार्यालय एवं दिनांक 14.09.2026 को 12:30 बजे अप0 मुख्य अभियंता, उत्तर उपभाग, भवन निर्माण विभाग, पटना का कार्यालय।	दिनांक 09.10.2026 को 12:30 बजे अप0 अधीक्षण अभियंता, भवन अंचल, दरभंगा का कार्यालय एवं दिनांक 12.10.2026 को 12:30 बजे अप0 मुख्य अभियंता, उत्तर उपभाग, भवन निर्माण विभाग, पटना का कार्यालय।	दिनांक 23.10.2026 को 12:30 बजे अप0 अधीक्षण अभियंता, भवन अंचल, दरभंगा का कार्यालय एवं दिनांक 26.10.2026 को 12:30 बजे अप0 मुख्य अभियंता, उत्तर उपभाग, भवन निर्माण विभाग, पटना का कार्यालय।

5. ई0 निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या– 24 के कंडिका–31 को विलोपित करते हुए पथ निर्माण विभाग, बिहार, पटना का अधिसूचना ज्ञापांक–7461 (S) दिनांक 13.10.2026 सह पठित ज्ञापांक–7462 (S) दिनांक 13.10.2026 एवं अभियंता प्रमुख–सह–अपर आयुक्त–सह–विशेष सचिव, भवन निर्माण विभाग, बिहार, पटना का आदेश ज्ञापांक–भवन / 12– अभि0प्र0 (यो0)–02 विविध–11 / 2026 9803 (भ) पटना, दिनांक 15.10.2026 में निहित शर्त्त इस निविदा में प्रभावी होंगे। परिमाण विपत्र से 10% (दस प्रतिशत) से ज्यादा कम दर उद्धृत रहने वाली निविदायें अमान्य मानी जाएगी।

परिमाण विपत्र के दर से नीचे निविदित दर दिये जाने की स्थिति में अतिरिक्त कार्य प्रतिभू (Additional Performance Guarantee) लेने का निम्नांकित प्रावधान किया जाता है :–

(1) परिमाण विपत्र की दर से 0 से 5 प्रतिशत कम उद्धृत दर वाले निविदा के लिए 0.25 प्रतिशत अतिरिक्त काय प्रतिभू (Additional Performance Guarantee) प्रति एक प्रतिशत उद्धृत दर के लिए अतिरिक्त जमा करना होगा।

(2) परिमाण विपत्र की दर से 5 से 10 प्रतिशत कम उद्धृत दर वाले निविदा के लिए 0.5 प्रतिशत अतिरिक्त कार्य प्रतिभू (Additional Performance Guarantee) प्रति एक प्रतिशत उद्धृत दर के लिए अतिरिक्त जमा करना होगा।

इसे इस हद तक संशोधित समझा जाए। अन्य सभी शर्त्तें पूर्ववत् रहेंगे।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
भवन निर्माण विभाग,
भवन प्रमंडल मधुबनी।

PR- 013963 (B C D) 2026-27

नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT
Lokseva Bhawan, Sachivalaya Marg, Bhubaneswar-751001
PT2-HE-SCH-POLICY-0001-2022/56395/HE., Bhubaneswar, Dated:22.10.2026

Corrigendum-III

NOTICE INVITING RFP FOR SELECTION OF A CONSULTING FIRM/ ENTITY FOR ESTABLISHMENT OF STATE TECHNICAL SUPPORT GROUP (STSG) FOR SUPPORTING IMPLEMENTATION OF PRADHAN MANTRI UCHCHATAR SHIKSHA ABHIYAN (PM-USHA) IN HIGHER EDUCATION DEPARTMENT, GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA.

RFP No. PM-USHA:05/2026 Date: 17.09.2026

Sl. No.	RFP Cl.No.	Page No.	Description as per RFP	Modified vide Corrigendum II, dated 09.10.2026	Now Modified Provisions
1	DATA SHEET (Sl. No.8 & 9)	4	Last Date & Time for receiving of Bid - 05/10/2026 at 5.30 PM	Last Date & Time for receiving of Bid - 26/10/2026 upto 5.30 PM	Last Date & Time for receiving of Bid - 30/10/2026 up to 5:30 PM (Registered Post & Speed Post only)
2		4	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 06/10/2026 at 3:30 PM	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 28/10/2026 at 3:30 PM	Date & Time of Opening of Technical Bid - 31/10/2026 at 3:30 PM

All other terms and conditions of the RFP remain unchanged.

Joint Secretary to Govt. & SPD, RUSA/PM-USHA

11001/382/2627 **OIPR-11001/11001/1/26-27/0075**

बिहार सरकार
उद्योग विभाग (एम0 एस0 एम0 ई0 निदेशालय)

संविदा आधारित नियोजन संबंधी सूचना

उद्योग विभाग, बिहार सरकार द्वारा विश्व बैंक संपोषित एवं MSME मंत्रालय, भारत सरकार द्वारा प्रायोजित केन्द्रीय क्षेत्र योजना "Raising & Accelerating MSME Performance (RAMP)" का संचालन किया जा रहा है इस योजना के सफल क्रियान्वयन के लिए MSME निदेशालय, उद्योग विभाग, Finance and Banking Manager एवं Financial Management Specialist के एक–एक पद पर संविदा आधारित परामर्शियों का नियोजना हेतु आवेदन सील बंद लिफाफा द्वारा हांथो–हाथ / स्पीड पोस्ट / कुरियर के माध्यम से दिनांकः 16.10.2026 से प्रारंभ कर दिनांकः 30.10.2026 को अपराह्न 6:00 तक आमंत्रित करता है (आवेदन जमा करने का समय किसी भी कार्य दिवस के अन्दर पूर्वाहन 9:30 से अपराह्न 6:00 बजे तक)। नियोजन से संबंधित विस्तृत जानकारी उद्योग विभाग के **website:** http://state.bihar.gov.in/industries पर दिए गए लिंक से प्राप्त किया जा सकता है।

आवेदन जमा करने का पताः
To,
The Chief Executive Officer
Udyog Mitra, Department of Industries
First Floor, Atal Path Side, RCS Path, Patna – 800001, Bihar.

निदेशक,
सूक्ष्म, लघु एवं मध्यम उद्यम निदेशालय,
उद्योग विभाग, बिहार, पटना

PR. No. 014155 (Industry) 2026-27

उक्त सूचना **www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar** पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

अपने जीवन साथी के प्रति वफादार रहें,
किसी अनजान स्त्री/पुरूष से असुरक्षित यौन संबंध से बचें।

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE
DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU
0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F),
email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

LOOK OUT NOTICE

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that on 09.10.2026 it was reliably learnt at P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu that one un-known male person was found unconscious near Shiv Mandir, Sector No. 1, Lochan Nursing home, Trikuta Nagar, Jammu was immediately shifted to GMCH Jammu, where after examining, the doctors on duty declared him dead. Since, the death of the deceased occurred in suspicious circumstances and to ascertain the actual cause of death, Inquest proceedings U/S 194 BNSS initiated at P/S Bahu Fort Jammu vide DDR No. 07 dated 09.10.2026 and enquiry thereof started. During enquiry, E/O shifted the dead body of the deceased to Mortuary room of GMCH Jammu for identification.

For identification of said dead body wide publicity is required to be published on daily newspapers for identification / Public in general, having any clue related to the dead body. If any missing report is lodged, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact/Telephone numbers.



Description Roll :-
Age : 40-45 years (Approx.)
Height : 5'06"
Complexion : Wheatish
Clothes : White T-Shirt, Trouser Usher Sky blue

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-
1. DPO, Jammu : 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D : sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu : 0191-2542000
4. SP City South : 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East : 01912474700
6. Landline of P/S Bahu Fort : 0191-2475133

Sr. Superintendent of Police
Jammu

DIP/J- 12830/26

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS KATHUA
E- mail: sspkathua@jkpolice.gov.in Fax/Phone No.: 01922-234010

LOOK OUT NOTICE

On 13-10-2026, one person namely Suresh Kumar S/O Melo Ram R/O Khala, Sandhar Tehsil Basohli District Kathua lodged a written report at P/S Basohli stating therein that on 11-10-2026 his daughter namely Asha Rani, age 18 years went missing from Khala Sandhar. The complainant made best efforts to search his daughter but all in vain. On this, missing report vide DDR No. 13 dated 13-10-2026 has been entered at Police Station Basohli.

During the course of investigation, best efforts were made to locate missing individual, whereas she is still un-traced.

As such Description Roll/Photograph of said missing individual is being shared with the appeal that anybody having clue/information about her whereabouts may inform us accordingly. The informer will be rewarded suitably:-

Description Roll :-
- Name Asha Rani
- Father Suresh Kumar
- Permanent Address Khala Sandhar
- Present Address Khala Sandhar
- Tehsil Basohli
- Police Station Basohli
- Age 18 years
- Height 05 feet
- Complexion Fair
- Built Normal
- Face Oval
- Eyes Brown
- Languages known Hindi/Dogri



Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-
Any information related to the whereabouts of the subject may be communicated on following contacts:-
1. DPO Kathua- 01922-234010 (Phone/Fax)
2. dpokathua@jkpolice.gov.in (Mail ID)
3. PCR Kathua- 01922-234311(Phone/Fax)
4. Police Station Basohli 9186316022

Sr. Superintendent of Police,
Kathua.

DIP/J- 12831/26

दिल्ली प्रौद्योगिकी विश्वविद्यालय
DELHI TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
Established by Govt. of NCT of Delhi vide Act 6 2009
(Formerly Delhi College of Engineering)
Shahbad Daulatpur, Bawana Road, Delhi- 110042

F.DTU/Rectt./Assistant Prof./2026/F-1018/5603 **Dated: 22/10/2026**

Advertisement Notice No. 04/2026

RECRUITMENT FOR THE POSTS OF ASSISTANT PROFESSOR INCLUDING BACKLOG VACANCIES WITH SPECIAL DRIVE FOR PwBD CATEGORY

Opening Date & Time for Submission of Online Applications: - **23rd October, 2026 from 11:00 AM onwards**
Closing Date & Time for Submission of Online Applications: - **07th December, 2026 till 05:00 PM**

Delhi Technological University is a teaching-cum-research University committed to foster excellence in education, research, technology incubation, product innovation, outreach and extension activities in Engineering, Management, and Applied Sciences. The University invites applications from the talented individuals to fill up the posts of Assistant Professor on direct mode of recruitment. The details of the vacancy position are as given below:

S. No.	Discipline	UR	SC	ST	OBC	EWS	Total Vacant posts	PwBD*
A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1.	Applied Chemistry	0	1	0	3	0	4	0
2.	Chemical Engineering	1	0	1	2	0	4	0
3.	Applied Mathematics	4	1	0	3	3	11	1
4.	Mathematics & Computing	1	0	0	1	0	2	0
5.	Applied Physics	7	2	2	3	1	15	1
6.	Engineering Physics	1	2	0	6	2	11	1
7.	Automobile Engineering	6	1	1	2	2	12	1
8.	Civil Engineering	7	2	2	6	3	20	2
9.	Management (DSM)	0	3	2	3	2	10	1
10.	Electronics & Communication Engineering	1	1	0	1	1	4	0
11.	Electrical Engineering	2	1	1	2	2	8	0
12.	Environmental Science & Engineering	3	1	0	2	0	6	1
13.	Humanities (Economics)	1	1	1	2	0	5	0
14.	Humanities (English)	1	0	1	1	0	3	0
15.	Production Engineering	9	3	1	5	2	20	2
16.	Mechanical Engineering	2	4	1	9	2	18	2
17.	Information Technology	1	1	1	6	0	9	1
18.	Software Engineering	2	0	0	1	0	3	0
19.	Computer Science & Engineering	7	1	6	16	6	36	3
20.	Economics (USME)	0	0	0	1	0	1	0
21.	Design	2	0	0	1	0	3	0
22.	Biotechnology	1	1	0	2	2	6	1
23.	Geospatial Science#	0	0	1	0	1	2	0
24.	Geospatial Technology#	3	1	0	2	0	6	0
	Total	**62**	**27**	**21**	**80**	**29**	**219**	**17**

* For applicable Benchmark Disability for these posts, reference be made to the detailed advertisement available at the university website i.e. **www.dtu.ac.in**.
The regularisation of incumbents against these posts shall be after the application for creation, approval and sanction of these posts, as at present these posts have been borrowed from the sanctioned posts of other disciplines.
The above-mentioned vacancies are provisional and can be varied as per the requirement of the University.
For the detailed advertisement candidates are required to visit the university website i.e. www.dtu.ac.in. The interested candidates are required to fill up the application form through ONLINE mode only available at University website **www.dtu.ac.in**. Candidates are required to retain a copy of printout of the application form. All further communications related to recruitment will be displayed on the university website from time to time. In this regard, no personal communication will be entertained.

Registrar

GOVT. OF BIHAR
BIHAR COMBINED ENTRANCE COMPETITIVE EXAMINATION BOARD
I.A.S. Association Building, Near Patna Airport, Patna-14.
Website : bceceboard.bihar.gov.in / Helpdesk : helpdesk.bceceboard@bihar.gov.in

UNDER GRADUATE MEDICAL ADMISSION COUNSELLING (UGMAC)-2026 for MBBS/ BDS/ B.V.Sc. & A.H./ B.F.Sc. in Govt. Medical / Dental / Veterinary Colleges / College of Fisheries and Private Medical / Dental Colleges of Bihar

Adv. No.- BCECEB(UGMAC)-2026/16 Dated 22.10.2026

Notice regarding Extended Online Counselling Programme for Stray Vacancy Round

In continuation to Adv. No. BCECEB(UGMAC)-2026/14 & 2026/15 dated 18.10.2026, it is informed to all eligible & interested NEET(UG)-2026 qualified candidates and all concerned that in view of the receipt of complaint from the candidates regarding Server & Technical issues, they could not submit their Consent and Choice filling for participating in Stray Vacancy Round Counselling wihin scheduled date. So, in interest of candidates, the counselling programme for Online Registration & Submission of Application-cum-Choice filling / Consent is hereby extended as follows;

Extended Important Dates for UGMAC-2026 Stray Vacancy Round Counselling :

i. Last date of online Registration ..... : 24.10.2026 (10.00 pm)
ii. Last date of submission of Application with payment through Debit Card/ Credit Card/ Net Banking/ UPI by Registered candidate/ Editing of Application Form data ..... : 24.10.2026 (11.59 pm)
iii. Consent for Stray Vacancy Round with Payment (if any) from such candidates who have already duly submitted the Application Form earlier ..... : upto 24.10.2026 (11.59 pm)
iv. Publication of Rank Card ..... : 25.10.2026
v **Last date** of Choice Filling / Editing of Choices & Locking ..... : 25.10.2026 (11.59 pm)
vi. Stray Vacancy Round Provisional Seat Allotment Result publication ..... : 27.10.2026
vii. Downloading of Provisional Seat Allotment order ..... : 27.10.2026 to 29.10.2026
viii. Documents Verification and Admission ..... : 28.10.2026 to 29.10.2026

2. Rest of the terms / conditions for Stray Vacancy Round Counselling mentioned in Adv. No.- BCECEB(UGMAC)-2026/14 Dated 18.10.2026 will remain the same.

Controller of Examination

GOVERNMENT OF PUDUCHERRY
LOCAL ADMINISTRATION DEPARTMENT

No.25103/LAD/PPS/P2/2026 Puducherry, dated 22.10.2026

ADVERTISEMENT

Sub: LAD - PPS - Conduct of Elections to Municipalities and Panchayats - Appointment of State Election Commissioner - Extension of Last Date for Receipt of Applications - Reg.

In continuation of the advertisement published on 18.09.2026 inviting applications for appointment as State Election Commissioner for the purpose of conduct of elections to Municipalities and Panchayats in the Union Territory of Puducherry, it is hereby notified that the last date for receipt of applications, originally fixed as 17.10.2026, is extended up to 02.11.2026.

Sl. No.	Particulars	Details
1	**Eligibility**	State Election Commissioner shall be appointed from amongst persons, who served under the Government of Union, or under the Government of a State or Union territory for not less than twenty-five years, having knowledge and experience in conducting elections.
2	**Age Limit**	65 years as on the last date prescribed for receipt of applications.
3	**Term of Office**	Three (3) years from the date on which he/she assumes office or till he/she attains the age of 68 years, whichever is earlier.
4	**Pay**	Level-12 (Rs.78,800— Rs.2,09,200) in the Pay Matrix. Pay shall be regulated in accordance with the Puducherry State Election Commissioner (Conditions of Service and Tenure of Office) Rules, 1994, as amended from time to time.
5	**Other Conditions of Service**	Details regarding conditions of service, tenure and other relevant particulars are available on the website of the Local Administration Department, Government of Puducherry.
6	**Last Date for Receipt of Applications**	**02.11.2026**
7	**Address for Submission of Applications**	The Secretary to Government (Local Administration), Chief Secretariat, Puducherry - 605 001.

The application shall be accompanied by:
1. Detailed Bio-data/Curriculum Vitae; 2. Passport size photograph; 3. Proof of Date of Birth; 4. Copies of educational qualifications; 5. Copies of service records indicating positions held; 6. Copy of retirement order, wherever applicable; and 7. A brief note indicating experience in election administration, electoral management, public administration or related fields.

- **Candidates who have already submitted applications is response to the advertisement dated 18.09.2026 need not apply again.**
- All other terms and conditions of the advertisement dated 18.09.2026 shall remain unchanged.
- Applications received after the extended last date or found incomplete in any respect are liable to be rejected.
- Soft copy of the application may additionally be forwarded by e-mail to **dirlad@py.gov.in**. However, submission of e-mail copy shall not dispense with submission of the signed application in physical form within the prescribed time.
- The Government of Puducherry reserves the right to accept or reject any application and to cancel or modify the selection process at any stage without assigning any reason.

// By Order //
Sd/-
DIRECTOR
LOCAL ADMINISTRATION DEPARTMENT

No. 243/ DIP/AD(PRESS)/ADVT/2026-27

कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय, पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, राँची।

ई–प्रोक्योरमेंट सूचना / नेशनल कम्पेटेटीभ बिडिंग

टेन्डर रेफरेंन्स नं0–प0नि0वि0 / राँची–33 / 2026–27 **दिनांक :–21.10.2026**

1.	कार्य का नाम	बिरसा चौक–धुर्वा गोलचक्कर–प्रोजेक्ट बिल्डिंग–चांदनी चौक पथ के धुर्वा गोलचक्कर (चैनेज–2.730 कि0मी0) से पुलिस हेडक्वार्टर (चैनेज–5.427कि0मी0) पथांश (कुल लम्बाई –2.697 कि0मी0) का चौड़ीकरण / मजबूतीकरण एवं पुनर्निर्माण कार्य (Geometric and Aesthetic Improvement, Cycle Track निर्माण कार्य Horticulture (with 1(one) year maintenance), एवं वृक्षारोपन सहित) वर्ष 2026–27.
2.	अनुमानित प्राक्कलित राशि (रू0 लाख में)	रू0 2661.12411 लाख (रूपये छब्बीस करोड़ एकसठ लाख बारह हजार चार सौ ग्यारह) मात्र।
3.	अग्रधन की राशि (रू0 लाख में)	रू0 26.62 लाख (रूपये छब्बीस लाख बासठ हजार) मात्र।
4.	कार्य पूर्ण करने की अवधि	13 (तेरह) माह
5.	वेबसाईट पर निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	26.10.2026 10.30 बजे पूर्वाह्न
6.	प्री–बीडमिटिंग की तिथि / समय	02.11.2026 3.00 बजे अपराह्न
7.	निविदा प्राप्ति की अंतिम तिथि / समय	17.11.2026 12.00 बजे दोपहर तक
8.	निविदा खोलने की तिथि / समय	18.11.2026 12.30 बजे अपराह्न।
9.	निविदा प्रकाशित करने वाले कार्यालय का नाम एवं पता	कार्यपालक अभियंता पथ निर्माण विभाग,पथ प्रमंडल, मोहराबादी, राँची–834008.
10.	प्रोक्योरमेंट पदाधिकारी का सम्पर्क संख्या	0651–2361018
11.	ई–प्रोक्योरमेंट सेल का हेल्पलाईन संख्या	0651–2401010

- प्राक्कलित राशि एवं अग्रधन की राशि घट–बढ़ सकती है, जिसे ***Tender Online Upload*** में देखा जा सकता है, एवं किसी भी प्रकार का बदलाव ***http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in*** पर देखा जा सकता है।
- नियम एवं शर्तों के लिए वेबसाईट ***http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in*** पर देखें।

कार्यपालक अभियंता
PR 392169 (Road Construction Dept Road Division Ranchi) 26-27 (D) पथ निर्माण विभाग, पथ प्रमंडल, राँची।

FRIDAY
October 23, 2026

DELHI
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AN UNFULFILLED PROMISE

Prasar Bharati is not a public broadcaster

The corporation is still on a ministerial leash

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RUN-FEST

Samson, Dhir star in India's record chase

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IN BRIEF



SP chief meets Azam Khan in Rampur jail

LUCKNOW
Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday visited senior party leader Azam Khan in Rampur district jail and accused the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh of registering false cases against him. » Page 4

Actor firing case: four remanded in police custody

MUMBAI
A metropolitan magistrate court in Mumbai on Thursday remanded four accused, arrested in connection with the October 18 firing at Bollywood actor Tiger Shroff's car in Juhu, in police custody till October 26. » Page 14

Indian killed in Dammam as Houthi conflict escalates

Deadly attack on airport in Saudi Arabia injured 8 persons, says the kingdom; Saudi Arabian forces targeted a yacht carrying 14 Indians in Red Sea and rescue operations are under way, say rebels

Stanly Johny

Two people, including an Indian national, were killed and eight injured on Wednesday in a Houthi attack on King Fahd International Airport in Dammam, Saudi Arabia's eastern oil hub, the kingdom's General Authority of Civil Aviation said.

The Iran-aligned rebels also claimed that Saudi Arabian forces on Thursday targeted an Indian yacht near Zuqar Island in Red Sea, carrying 14 Indians, adding that they were conducting rescue operations.

The Indian Embassy in Riyadh confirmed the Indian national's death. "Saudi authorities have informed that one Indian national was among two people who unfortunately lost their lives in the attack on Dammam airport yesterday night and two Indian nationals were injured," the embassy wrote in a social media post on Thursday.

On Thursday, the Houthis (Ansar Allah) said they will continue their operations against Saudi Arabia. "There will be siege for siege and escalation for escalation," they said, adding that the strikes would continue until Saudi Arabia lifts its blockade of the Houthi-held areas of Yemen.

If Saudi Arabia continues to attack Yemen, "we will resort to major options we did not want to take, and we hold it responsible for the consequences," the Iran-backed militants said, according to the Houthi-aligned Almasirah television.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12



Saudi Arabia-backed government troops seen in the Yemeni city of Taiz on Wednesday amid the conflict with the Houthis. AFP

Efforts on to bring back thousands of stranded Indians

NEW DELHI
Amid escalating attacks by the Houthi rebels from Yemen on Saudi Arabia, Indian missions in Riyadh and Jeddah are working with stakeholders to facilitating the return of thousands of stranded pilgrims, the External Affairs Ministry has said. » PAGE 12

Cabinet Secretariat copied acknowledgement sent to letters by two ECs to CEC

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

Days after two Election Commissioners (ECs) S.S. Sandhu and Vivek Joshi wrote to Cabinet Secretary T.V. Somanathan on July 29 regarding the working of Senior Deputy Election Commissioner Maneesh Garg, the secretariat sent an acknowledgment to both with a copy to Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar for his "information", a Right to Information (RTI) response has revealed.

The Cabinet Secretariat noted that the letters were from the ECs in their individual capacity and while needed to be taken with seriousness, cannot be taken as formal communication from the Election Commission of India (ECI) as a whole. In the absence of any official communication from the Commission any action can be construed as "interference".



Gyanesh Kumar

The RTI plea was filed by Commodore Lokesh Batra (retd).

Work allocation

A Cabinet Secretariat file noting dated August 3, says that both the ECs had stated that Mr. Garg, after assuming charge as link officer of DEC (Administration), issued an order regarding work allocation of officers equivalent and senior to him without discussing the revised work allocation with the Commission or the officers concerned. Further, the ECs stated that this happened despite repeated oral and written instructions to all officers against taking such actions without prior discussion/approval of the Commission. "In this connection, we may request the Chief Election Commissioner for his opinion on the issue," it said.

However, the very next day, that is August 4, the file notes that "the Commission is a constitutional body and is insulated from executive interference by design to ensure that it functions independently and in a transparent manner".

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

ITBP D-G says face-off with China continues in Arunachal Pradesh

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Confrontations with Chinese troops continue to take place at multiple sites along the border in Arunachal Pradesh, according to Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) Director-General Shatrujeet Kapur.

"In the past few-days, a situation arose where face-off happened at several locations in Arunachal and it still continues," Mr. Kapur said on Thursday.

Speaking at the Himveer Samman Samaroah, an annual felicitation ceremony for ITBP personnel, in Alwar, Rajasthan, Mr. Kapur said the force's commandos have been active in the continuing confrontations on the Arunachal Pradesh border. This is the first official confirmation of the scale of the rising tensions on the northeastern border since July.

Government sources told *The Hindu* that since late July, India and China have been engaged in a stand-off at Asaphila near Taksing in Arunachal Pradesh. The Chinese People's Liberation Army (PLA) have pitched their tents at an elevation, within 6 km to 7 km of India's perception of the Line of Actual Control (LAC), sources said.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

Blooming valley



Awaiting visitors: Gardeners tending to chrysanthemum plants, locally known as *Gul-e-Dawood*, on the banks of the Dal Lake in Srinagar on Thursday. The garden, which is expected to boost autumn tourism in the Valley, is scheduled to open to visitors on Friday. IMRAN NISSAR

Delhi content creator held over racial abuse of youth from Tripura

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A Delhi-based social media content creator, Amir Shokeen, was arrested by the North District police in Karol Bagh on Thursday evening for allegedly subjecting a youth from Tripura to racial abuse and humiliation, an official said.

A video of the incident purportedly showing Mr. Shokeen making derogatory remarks against the youth has gone viral on social media, triggering widespread condemnation across the Northeast.

In a post on X, Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said, "This evil man will be punished. There was a delay in lodging the official complaint, but Delhi Police and Tripura Police will teach him a hard lesson."

Tripura Chief Minister Manik Saha has directed the State's Director General of Police to coordinate with Delhi Police to investigate the matter.

Delhi Police's Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) unit has joined the probe into the video, a senior official told *The Hindu* on Thursday.

The Agartala police have registered a case and are expected to reach the national capital to investigate the matter, Additional Commissioner of Police (IFSO) Sanjay Bhatia said.

CJP leaders seek time to appear before Delhi Police

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A day after being released from judicial custody, CJP leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka failed to appear before the Delhi Police Crime Branch for questioning on Thursday and sought additional time to join the investigation, police sources said. The police are likely to issue fresh notices to them.

Meanwhile, counsel for AISA leader Neha Bora argued before the Delhi HC that there is nothing wrong with seeking a regime change in a democracy.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 12

India and Poland will achieve shared goal of doubling bilateral trade by 2030: Modi

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India and Poland have no "conflicts of interest", said Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk, who hailed his Indian counterpart Narendra Modi as a "beacon of hope" in a time of "political uncertainty and instability" after talks here on Thursday.

Mr. Tusk, who is visiting as Prime Minister for the first time since 2010, discussed expanding India-Poland cooperation in a number of fields including space, transportation, renewable energy, and technology, and also spoke about India's "four-point proposal" to help mitigate the effects of the Russia-Ukraine conflict.



Steadfast partnership: Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Polish PM Donald Tusk in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

While the two sides did not sign any agreement after bilateral talks, India and Poland targeted doubling trade between them from a low figure of $6 billion, which is expected to rise after the India-European Union Free Trade Agreement is signed in December.

"We are confident that companies from both countries will work together to develop trusted supply chains for the world and achieve our shared goal of doubling bilateral trade by 2030," said Mr. Modi.

Feat lauded

The Prime Minister added that he was pleased that a large business delegation had accompanied Mr. Tusk to engage with Indian businesses in Delhi and Bengaluru on collaborations in areas such as rail transport, clean coal, and mining, where Poland has developed its technology.

Mr. Modi congratulated Poland for entering the group of nations with trillion-dollar GDPs.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

In Instagram debut, Sonia Gandhi shares glimpse of memoir on 'love, duty, and loss'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress Parliamentary Party Chairperson Sonia Gandhi made her Instagram debut on Thursday by sharing a video of her upcoming memoir, *Belonging: A Journey of Love*, which she described as a "story of love, duty, loss and finding a place to belong".

The former Congress president has largely stayed away from social media, using the party's official X handle to release video statements, letters and other messages. In the first post on her Instagram account, Ms. Gandhi shared a video of herself receiving copies of the book and sharing sweets with Priyanka Gandhi Vadra and remarked that the book contained several photographs. "Hello everyone, I'm truly grateful to share this moment with you all; the first look of *Belonging: A Journey of Love*. It is a story of love, duty, loss and finding a place to belong. I look forward to sharing it with you," she said in her post.



Fresh page: The Congress leader has largely stayed away from social media, using official party handles to release statements. PTI

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh, sharing the video, said the "long-awaited memoir" of Ms. Gandhi would be released on November 10.

Last month, HarperCollins India announced that it would publish the memoir, ending uncertainty over its domestic release after an impasse between Ms. Gandhi's representatives and Penguin Random House India (PRHI).

The disagreement had triggered a controversy, with some Congress leaders alleging that pressure had been exerted on the publisher to remove references to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh and China's alleged occupation of Indian territory.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

M ND-NDE

Mere presence at protest not enough for prosecution: HC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court has quashed an FIR against a Staff Selection Commission (SSC) aspirant booked in connection with a protest at Ramlila Maidan, observing that mere participation in a demonstration does not establish a common intention to disobey police orders or obstruct police personnel.

Justice Sanjeev Narula held that the petitioner could not be prosecuted without material showing that he knowingly participated in the alleged disobedience or shared a common intention to commit the offence. The case arose from a protest held at Ramlila Maidan in August 2025 by SSC aspirants over alleged irregularities in the conduct of the exams.

According to the prosecution, some organisers "refused to call off the demonstration after the permitted time had expired and instigated protesters" to remain at the venue until their demands were met. The police subsequently registered an FIR alleging that some protesters had violated prohibitory orders issued under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita by continuing to occupy the ground. The police also alleged that some protesters pushed and clashed with the police. The court, however, noted that neither the FIR nor the status report attributed any specific criminal act to the petitioner. His presence among the protesters, without material indicating a common intention to commit an offence, was insufficient to make out a case under Section 223(a) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which deals with disobedience of an order promulgated by a public servant.

'No worthwhile purpose'

"The petitioner cannot be subjected to criminal proceedings merely on account of his presence amongst the protesters, in the absence of material indicating his knowing participation in the alleged disobedience or any common intention to commit the offence. The continuation of the proceedings against him, in these circumstances, would serve no worthwhile purpose," the court said in its October 13 order.

"Mere participation in the same demonstration does not, by itself, establish a common intention to disobey lawful directions or obstruct police personnel. The material on record does not disclose any basis for attributing such common intention to the petitioner," it held.

Shah pledges to clean Yamuna by May 2029, launches infra projects worth ₹8,941 crore

Union Home Minister accuses previous Delhi govts. of dumping tonnes of cow dung into the river and allowing sewage to flow into it; says BJP govt. has achieved over 40% success in cleaning Yamuna

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday inaugurated and laid foundation stones for 43 water and sewerage projects worth ₹8,941.22 crore aimed at cleaning the Yamuna and improving drinking water supply in Delhi.

He inaugurated 10 projects worth ₹2,827.11 crore and laid foundation stones for 33 others worth ₹6,114.11 crore. "Before May 2029, we will purify the Yamuna. This is our resolve," Mr. Shah said at an event in Shyam Vihar attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

Among the inaugurated projects are a water treatment plant in Chandrawal with a capacity of 477 million litres per day (MLD), a water recycling plant in Bawana with a capacity of 2 million gallons per day (MGD) and a new sewage treatment plant (STP) of 124 MGD in Okhla. The existing STPs at Rithala and Kondli have also been upgraded, the Chief Minister's Office stated.



Home Minister Amit Shah with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh in New Delhi on Thursday. PTI

The Union Home Minister accused the previous Congress and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) governments in Delhi of allowing sewage to flow into the Yamuna for more than 30 years. He also claimed that the previous governments dumped 2,000 tonnes of cow dung from dairies into the river every day.

'Time-bound road map'

With the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in power at the Centre and in Delhi, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, the governments have prepared a time-bound road map to clean the river by 2029, he said. Mr. Shah claimed that the government had achieved "more than 40% success" since Prime Minister Narendra Modi convened a meeting following the formation of the BJP government in Delhi.

Accusing the Congress and AAP of making excuses for failing to tackle pollution, Mr. Shah attacked former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal. "Kejriwal*ji*, I have answers to all your questions. I will give them when we remove AAP from power in Punjab too," he said. "You did nothing except seize power in the name of protests and indulge in rampant corruption," he alleged.

Mr. Shah said the BJP government has reduced the height of Delhi's landfill sites and that gardens would be developed there within two years.

Chhath Puja

Cleaning the Yamuna was a key promise made by Mr. Modi ahead of the 2025 Delhi Assembly election, which returned the BJP to power after 27 years. The river holds religious significance for Purvanchalis from eastern Uttar Pradesh and Bihar who form a significant voter base in Delhi. Many observe Chhath Puja, which will be celebrated in November this year, by taking a holy dip in the river.

Ms. Gupta said the government is adopting a scientific approach to restoring the river by intercepting drains, upgrading and constructing STPs, laying sewer lines and connecting them to STPs. "The goal is to connect every household to the sewer network and every sewer line to an STP to prevent untreated wastewater from entering the Yamuna," she said.

Delhi SIR: revised data show sharp increase in Form 6 disposal rate

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

A total of 1.07 lakh Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in Delhi's electoral roll have been disposed of, according to an updated weekly disposal report uploaded on the website of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) on Thursday. The latest data replaced the weekly disposal report on the website that was there till Wednesday, with officials saying the data being uploaded earlier was wrong and not reflecting the disposals recorded since August 31, when the claims and objections phase began.

The CEO's office releases a constituency-wise report every week, recording how many applications under each form - Form 6 for inclusion of new voters, Form 7 for deletions, Form 6A for overseas electors and Form 8 for corrections or address changes - have been disposed of since the claims and objections phase under the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls began.

This comes after *The Hindu* reported that only 0.27%, or 1,238 of the over 4.5 lakh Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in Delhi's electoral roll had been disposed of between August 31 and October 11.

The revised figures cover each of the seven weeks between August 31 and October 18. Officials said the data displayed publicly earlier was wrong. According to the updated report, 1,07,451 (23%) of the 4,59,796 Form 6 applications and 47,105 (70%) of the 67,709 Form 7 applications have been disposed of.

"The weekly data being uploaded till now was wrong and it was not reflecting the disposals that happened since August 31, we noticed after the newspaper report," an official told *The Hindu*. For instance, the earlier report showed 241 Form 6 applications were disposed of across Delhi's 70 Assembly constituencies from August 31 to September 6, the first week of the claims and objections period. The updated report now shows 511 for the same week. The second week's figure has been revised from 34 to 4,543. The sharpest revision is for the week of September 28 to October 4 - from zero to 14,643 disposals.

'Zero case disposed of'

Tri Nagar is still the only constituency in Delhi with no Form 6 disposal recorded in any of the seven weeks.

Form 7 figures too have been revised sharply upward: from 5,845 to 40,796 for the same six weeks.

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Announcement of **Hakeem Abdul Hameed Scholarship/ Financial Aid for the Year 2026-2027** for Professional / Technical / Graduate / Diploma / Vocational courses for current Academic first year admitted students. The eligibility criteria will be 10+2 with minimum 50% average total marks to the students belonging to Minority/SC/ST/OBC/General Categories.

Last date for submitting application form is 28th November 2026. The prescribed form can be downloaded from our website www.hamdardfoundation.in The duly filled application form alongwith all relevant documents may be enclosed with self attestation and may be sent by post / by hand to the above office address. Any other information if required may be sent on email: hnfhecascholarship@gmail.com. **Only offline applications will be accepted (By post/by hand)**

Officer on Special Duty (HNF- HECA)

PUBLIC NOTICE

चुनाव सूचना (Election Schedule)
दिनांक: 23.10.2026

अग्रवाल विद्या प्रचारिणी सभा (रजि०), बल्लभगढ़, पंजीकरण संख्या HR/019/2014/01115 की Governing Council के पदाधिकारियों – अध्यक्ष, उपाध्यक्ष, सचिव, संयुक्त सचिव, कोषाध्यक्ष एवं कार्यकारिणी के 16 सदस्यों (संख्या 01 से 16) का चुनाव दिनांक 06/12/2026, दिन रविवार, समय प्रातः 09:00 बजे से सायं 04:00 बजे तक, अग्रवाल कॉलेज, तिगांव रोड, नियर–अम्बेडकर चौक, बल्लभगढ़ के भवन में होगा। यह चुनाव 3 वर्ष के लिए होगा। चुनाव कार्यक्रम निम्नलिखित है :–

1. कॉलेजियम सदस्य (मतदाता) सूची का प्रकाशनः	दिनांक 23–10–2026, दिन शुक्रवार को अग्रवाल कॉलेज सूचना बोर्ड पर सूची का प्रकाशन किया जाएगा।
2. नामांकन	दिनांक 14/11/2026, दिन शनिवार से 15/11/2026, दिन रविवार तक, समय प्रातः 10:00 बजे से दोपहर बाद 03:00 बजे तक, अग्रवाल कॉलेज, तिगांव रोड, नियर–अम्बेडकर चौक, बल्लभगढ़ के कार्यालय में नामांकन स्वीकार किए जाएंगे, जो निर्वाचन अधिकारी के समक्ष सभा के संविधान के अनुसार भरे जाएंगे।
3.नामांकन पत्रों की जाँचः	दिनांक 19/11/2026, दिन गुरुवार, प्रातः 09:00 बजे से 12:00 बजे तक।
4. नामांकन वापसी	दिनांक 21/11/2026, दिन शनिवार, प्रातः 11:00 बजे से दोपहर बाद 03:00 बजे तक।
5. चुनाव चिह्न आवंटन	दिनांक 23/11/2026, दिन सोमवार, दोपहर बाद 03:00 बजे से सायं 05:00 बजे तक।
6. मतदान की तिथि	दिनांक 06/12/2026, दिन रविवार, समय प्रातः 09:00 बजे से सायं 04:00 बजे तक, अग्रवाल कॉलेज (तिगांव रोड, नियर–अम्बेडकर चौक), बल्लभगढ़ के भवन में मतदान होगा। तत्पश्चात मतगणना आरम्भ की जाएगी एवं उसी दिन चुनाव परिणाम घोषित किए जाएंगे।

निर्वाचन मंडल संख्या 1 से 102 तक के कॉलेजियम सदस्यों की सूची, संविधान की प्रति प्रत्येक ₹100/– में तथा नामांकन फॉर्म ₹500/– में कॉलेज के कार्यालय (तिगांव रोड, नियर–अम्बेडकर चौक) से प्राप्त किए जा सकते हैं। **Governing Council** के पदाधिकारियों– अध्यक्ष, उपाध्यक्ष, सचिव, संयुक्त सचिव, कोषाध्यक्ष एवं कार्यकारिणी के 16 सदस्यों (संख्या 01 से 16) के लिए ₹2,000/– **Refundable Security** के रूप में जमा कराने होंगे।

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Secretary
Delhi Union of Journalists (DUJ) CGHS Ltd.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Transfer of Allotment Rights

Notice for transfer of allotment rights in respect of Unit No. T8-3002 Floor-30, "Project Name, SS Cendana AND SS Kiavasa Sector-83, Gurugram (Haryana) consequent upon the intestate death of the allottee **Mrs. Neelam Chhabra** who was the allottee of the subject cited property as per record died on **05.02.2026** and has no registered or un-registered will, leaving behind following legal heirs: 1. Mr. Naresh Chhabra **(Husband)**, 2. Mr. Shankar Chhabra **(Son)** both **R/O 1/183 Subhash Nagar, New Delhi- 110027**, who intend to apply for the transfer of the said unit being the legal heirs and request for transfer in the name of **Mr. Naresh Chhabra.** If any person is having any objection against the transfer of the said unit, he/she can submit objections in writing at the below mentioned address along with supporting documents within **30 days** from the date of publication of this notice, otherwise the company may accord permission to transfer of the said property as per company policy and may not entertain subsequent claim, if any.

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LEGAL NOTICE

IN THE HIGH COURT OF DELHI AT NEW DELHI (TESTAMENT INTESTATE, JURISDICTION)
CITATION U/s 283, INDIAN SUCCESSION ACT, 1925
In the matter of
TEST. CAS. No. 49/2026.
SH. GAURAV JALAN & ANR
Petitioners.....
Versus
STATE & ANR.....
Respondents.....

To,
All Concerned.

In the matter of estate of **Late Sh. Ram Kishor Jalan S/o. Late Sh. Shyam Sunder Jalan, R/o. 34, Iswar Nagar, New Delhi-110065.**

Whereas **(1) Sh. Gaurav Jalan S/o Late Sh. Ram Kishore Jalan and (2) Smt. Meera Jalan W/o Late Sh. Ram Kishore Jalan, both R/o 34, Ishwar Nagar, New Delhi-110065, have filed a Petition under Section 278 of Indian Succession Act, 1925** for grant of Letter of Administration of the Will dated 27.02.2021 in respect of estate of **Late Ram Kishor Jalan, Deceased.**

And whereas the aforesaid case is fixed for hearing on **01.12.2026 at 11:00 a.m. Before Joint Registrar (Judicial) of this Court.** This Citation is issued in terms of Section 283 of the said Act to all persons claiming to have any interest in the property/ properties of the said deceased to come to this Court, file objections, if any, and take part in the proceedings on the date specified above for the grant of Letter of Administration.

Given under my hand and the seal of this Court, in terms of the orders dated 16.09.2026.

Assistant Registrar (O)
For: Registrar General

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, JYOTI d/o Ram Charan Verma born on 21 Feb 1982 residing at 191/B5, Ist Floor, Sector 11, Rohini, Delhi 110085 have changed my name to Jyoti Verma vide affidavit dated 16 Oct 2026 at Delhi.

Delhi Police denies permission for Diljit Dosanjh's October 30 concert, cites security concerns

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Delhi Police has denied permission for singer Diljit Dosanjh's October 30 concert at Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium in the national capital, citing threat-related inputs, security concerns and law and order commitments during the festive season.

The decision, communicated to ticketing platform BookMyShow after the police examined the organisers' October 14 application, has left the Delhi leg of the singer's Aura India Tour uncertain.

In a letter seen by *The Hindu*, Deputy Commissioner of Police (South District) Anant Mittal said the request could not be granted. "In view of the specific threat-related inputs, coupled with the multifarious security and law & order commitments arising out of the ongoing festive season and other important law & order concerns, the same cannot be acceded to," the letter read.



The organisers have not announced anything about the cancellation of the concert or a change of venue yet. FILE PHOTO

The decision drew criticism from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which accused the government of bias against the singer.

"Real heroes like @diljitdosanjh supported the farmers' movement and spoke against police violence on students. A brave 'sardar' always troubles dictators, as did Shaheed-e-Azam Bhagat Singh. The government is biased against such brave Punjabis," AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj wrote on X.

'Need clarity'

AAP MLA Jarnail Singh questioned why permission for the concert had "reportedly" been "cancelled" on security grounds.

"If security was a concern, why was the issue not addressed with proper planning? Artists and music lovers deserve clarity, not confusion. The public deserves answers!" Mr. Singh wrote on X.

'Discussions still on'

Meanwhile, some sources among the organisers said discussions with the police are under way to find a way forward. "Dosanjh's team is also involved in the discussions surrounding the circumstances and the show," said a source.

The organisers have not announced anything about the cancellation of the concert or a change of venue yet.



A layer of smog over Kartavya Path in New Delhi on Thursday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Study says no improvement in winter air in 4 years

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

There has been no consistent improvement in Delhi's winter air quality over the past four years despite the enforcement of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), according to an analysis of government data by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), a Finland-based non-profit research organisation.

"Delhi's winter AQI (Air Quality Index) has fluctuated over the past four years, with no consistent improvement. The mean AQI rose from 280 in winter 2022-23 to 304 in 2023-24, fell to 285 in 2024-25 and increased again to 295 in 2025-26. The median AQI followed a similar pattern, rising from 294 to 324, falling to 289 and then increasing to 305," CREA said in a release.

The mean and median AQI are statistical measures that summarise air quality over a specific period, offering different perspectives on fluctuations caused by weather and pollution spikes. Delhi's winter air quality has not followed a consistent downward trend since the 2022 revision of GRAP, and the mean and median AQI for the latest winter were both higher than in 2022-23, said Manoj Kumar, an analyst at CREA. Delhi's air quality remained 'poor' for the second consecutive day on Thursday.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE
DEATH

Rasam Pagdi & Bhog / Prayer Meeting



Shri Ram Prakash
IPS (Retd. IGP)
(6 March 1938 - 17 October 2026)
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Time: **2pm - 3pm**
Venue: **House No. 131, Sector 2, Panchkula, Haryana**
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Timings
DELHI

FRIDAY, OCT. 23	
RISE 06:27	SET 17:44
RISE 15:51	SET 03:21
SATURDAY, OCT. 24	
RISE 06:27	SET 17:43
RISE 16:22	SET 04:19
SUNDAY, OCT. 25	
RISE 06:28	SET 17:42
RISE 16:56	SET 05:22

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	32	20
Safdarjang	32	20
Palam	30	19

Delhi Palam Today
32°C Pollution level to increase gradually.The dry weather to continue. Day will be little warm. Night will be slight cool.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
31°C Morning will be slight cool with mist and haze. Day will be slight warm. Night also will be slight cool. Dry weather to continue.

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Karnataka SIR: over 76,000 applications for inclusion rejected

Rishita Khanna
BENGALURU

A total of 76,176 Form 6 applications seeking inclusion in the final electoral rolls have been rejected by the Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer (CEO)'s office on various grounds, including submission of duplicate applications and applicants not being available during verification, besides other reasons.

Between June 16, when the electoral rolls were frozen, and September 23, the last date to file claims and objections, a total of 7.87 lakh Form 6 applications were received. Of these, 7.08 lakh have been accepted and 76,176 rejected.

These net additions will be reflected in the final electoral rolls, scheduled to be published on October 27. However, the number of additions remains far lower than the more than 80.62 lakh names deleted after being categorised as shifted or absent.

Unclear status

Moreover, the status of at least 3,248 Form 6 applications remains unclear, as the accepted and rejected applications together account for only 7.84 lakh forms.

The CEO's office said the gap comprises applications filed in the wrong Assembly constituency or with incorrect details.

During the same period, 58,475 Form 7 applications seeking deletion of names were received.

Of these, 23,926 were accepted, and the corresponding entries will be deleted.

HC likely to hear Pinarayi's plea in CMRL case tomorrow

Development comes after SC stays probe into FIR against the Opposition leader; Pinarayi's counsel informs ED that he will not appear for questioning on Friday; ED likely to oppose his appeal

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI


Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan informed ED officials that he will not appear for questioning in view of the Supreme Court's stay.

The Kerala High Court is likely to hear on Saturday a plea by Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan challenging a Single Judge order that had directed the registration of an FIR against him, his daughter T. Veena, and his son-in-law P.A. Mohamed Riyas, in the CMRL-Exalogic pay off case.

This comes after the Supreme Court on Wednesday stayed a Kerala Police investigation into an FIR registered against Mr. Vijayan and his family members.

The Single Judge Bench of the HC had directed the State police to register the FIR against the three under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. They approached the Supreme Court after a Division Bench denied them leave (permission) to appeal against the order.

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) is likely to oppose the appeal to be filed by Mr. Vijayan before the Division Bench. A meeting of senior agency officials here discussed the steps to be taken following the Supreme Court directive.

Meanwhile, Mr. Vijayan will not appear before the ED in Kochi for questioning on Friday. The agency had issued him a summons last week, asking him to appear at its zonal office around 11 a.m.

The ED had earlier registered two Enforcement Case Information Reports (ECIRs) under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) against Mr. Vijayan and his two family members.

Counsel for Mr. Vijayan informed ED officials that he would not appear for questioning in view of the Supreme Court's stay. Mr. Vijayan also cited the apex court's order permitting him and the other two petitioners to file an appeal before the High Court's Division Bench against the single Bench order on October 9.

Freeze period on FIR against Pinarayi 10 days in published order: SC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In an update from its oral pronouncement, the Supreme Court has directed the investigation into the FIRs against former Keralam Chief Minister and current Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena and son-in-law and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas in the CMRL-Exalogic payoff case to be extended to 10 days.

Oral pronouncement

The oral pronouncement in open court on Wednesday had specifically dictated the time of stay as a week or seven days. However, the subsequent published order mentions the period of the stay as 10 days.

"We direct that the investigation in the impugned FIRs shall remain stayed for a period of ten days from today, which, however, shall not be treated as a conclusive opinion expressed on interim relief, and the Division Bench [of the Kerala High Court] shall be entitled to fashion independently such relief in accordance with law," the order read.

Allowing Mr. Vijayan and his co-petitioners in the Supreme Court to pursue their appeal against a Single Judge Bench order of October 9, 2026, directing the registration of FIRs under the Prevention of Corruption Act, the apex court noted that its observations were limited to the "locus of the appellants to prefer the appeal, and not an expression of opinion on merits".

U.P. CEO orders action against officials over discrepancies in Pilibhit voter roll

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) Navdeep Rinwa on Thursday ordered legal action against officials responsible for discrepancies in the voter roll of the Pilibhit Assembly constituency, where entering certain voters' Electoral Photo Identity Card (EPIC) numbers online displayed details of other electors.

In an official statement, the State Election Commission (SEC) said action will be taken against both current and former officials responsible for the irregularities. Departmental action has been ordered against two voter registration officials and the computer support staff will be terminated, it stated. The District Election Officer has received a report on the complaint that the EPIC number of a voter in Pilibhit was showing details of another voter, it added.

According to the investigation, the computer operator at the constituency's voter registration centre entered 13,779 Form 8s, which is used to correct entries in electoral rolls, between May 31 and August 29. Of these, 4,717 were entered till July 16 and 9,062 between July 17 and August 29. No corresponding physical Form 8s were found in office records. Of the total, 10,470 were approved and 3,309 rejected. There were discrepancies in 10,470 entries, it stated.

The Election Commission of India has directed that the computer operator and the Electoral Registration Officers posted in Pilibhit between July 16 and 17 be held responsible for the irregularities. It has directed legal action against them under Section 32 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950, and relevant sections of the Indian Penal Code. The Congress on Wednesday had alleged large-scale manipulation of rolls in Pilibhit.

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Aspiring candidates may apply for admission to Ph.D. programme. Hard copy of the application along with relevant documents must reach to Joint Registrar (Academics), DIAT (DU) Girinagar, Pune-411025 latest by **1730 hours on or before 27 Nov. 2026**.

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INBRIEF



Kochi student 28th winner of Charles Correa Gold Medal

Radhakrishnan M.S. of the Seed - APJ Abdul Kalam School of Environmental Design in Kochi has won the 28th Charles Correa Gold Medal in architecture. The award recognises outstanding undergraduate architectural thesis projects that engage meaningfully with the challenges of built environment. The award ceremony was held at Tarq gallery in Mumbai on Thursday. 'The State of Architecture - Practices and Processes in India, A Research Framework', a book on inquiry into the practice of architecture in the subcontinent, was also released at the event.

2 die of electrocution during Durga idol immersion in M.P.

Two persons died and as many as six others suffered electric shocks, when a live wire fell on their tractor-trolley carrying a Durga idol for immersion in Madhya Pradesh's Jabalpur district shortly after midnight on Thursday, police said. The incident occurred at 12.04 a.m. in Majhauli police station area, about 30 km from the district headquarters, where more than 50 people were taking the idol in a procession from Civil Line Path for immersion in Narili pond. Vikas Rajput (22) and Prince Chauhan (23), who were sitting on the tractor, died on the spot. PTI

SP chief meets Azam Khan in Rampur jail, vows to defeat BJP

Akhilesh accuses ruling party of filing false cases against the senior SP leader, says no political family has faced as much injustice as Azam's

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Samajwadi Party (SP) president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday visited Azam Khan in Rampur district jail and accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government of filing false cases against the senior party leader. He said no political family has faced as much injustice as that of Mr. Khan.

"I came to meet Azam *saheb*. False cases have been filed against him and the family. No family, particularly no political family, has faced as much injustice as this one. The BJP is responsible for such injustice... when the truth comes out, they will have to face the consequences of their actions," he told reporters outside the jail.

The SP chief added corrupt officials and false cases are two key weapons of the BJP government. "Whenever the history of BJP injustice is written,



SP chief Akhilesh Yadav coming out of Rampur jail after meeting Azam Khan on Thursday. PTI

Rampur's name will always appear at the top. The conspiracy to close [Mohammad Ali] Jauhar University is actually a plot to snatch the right to education from the PDA (Pichhda, Dalit, Alpsankhyak)," he said, vowing to overthrow the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh with public support.

Key figure

Mr. Yadav's visit holds significance as despite being in prolonged judicial custody, Mr. Khan, a 10-term former MLA from Rampur, is a key figure for the party in the region. Recently, the Rampur Development Authority (RDA) had issued a demolition order for 38 of the 40 buildings at Jauhar University, run by Mr. Khan, over illegal construction. Amid an uproar, the proposed demolition was halted by higher authorities and the matter is pending in the Divisional Commissioner's court.

"The visit reiterated the importance of Azam Khan in the Samajwadi Party hierarchy. It is a reply to those leaders who are trying to reduce his stature and has exposed the BJP's design to keep him in jail on fabricated charges because of his religious identity and political clout," said senior SP leader Sudhir Panwar.

Reacting to the visit, BJP's Uttar Pradesh incharge Vinod Tawde said the SP's "dream" of making Azam Khan the State's Home Minister will never be fulfilled.

Coimbatore student ends life, family alleges harassment over caste and eating habits

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

A Class 11 student in Coimbatore, who belongs to a Scheduled Caste community, ended his life on Wednesday after he was allegedly harassed by a few classmates and a teacher over his caste and eating habits.

A. Kowsalyadevi, the mother of the student, A. Akilan, alleged that the teacher, Vijayakumar, had made five students who consume beef, including her son, stand up in the classroom two months ago. The Peelamedu police booked two students, Mr. Vijayakumar, and the school principal, Arunkumar, on Wednesday for abetment to suicide and other offences. The police questioned Mr. Vijayakumar on Thursday.

The police said Akilan, 16, had left home at 8 a.m. on Wednesday, informing his mother that he was going to school. The woman, who works as a domestic help at Bharathi Colony, returned home around 1 p.m. to have lunch, and found the front door unlocked. When she checked the



Demanding action: Relatives of the deceased student at the Peelamedu police station in Coimbatore late on Wednesday.

house, she found her son dead. The police sent the body for a post-mortem.

Ms. Kowsalyadevi said Mr. Vijayakumar had enquired about students belonging to the Scheduled Castes in the classroom to enlist them for a scholarship. Akilan had enrolled himself for the benefit. The teacher had also asked the students how many of them consumed beef, in response to which Akilan and four others had stood up. Ms. Kowsalyadevi said two of her son's classmates had been harassing and assaulting him over his caste since then. Though Akilan had reported the harassment to Mr. Vijayakumar, he did not take action, she said. She alleged that Mr. Arunkumar, too, had failed to take action when her son complained to him.

The police registered a case against two students, the teacher, and the principal for offences under Sections 115(2) and 108 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and Section 3(2)(v) of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

Report sought

The District Educational Officer for Secondary Education conducted an inquiry at the school on Thursday.

The Tamil Nadu State Commission for the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes asked the Coimbatore City Police Commissioner to submit a report within a week.

(Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Sule demands ₹1 lakh per hectare relief for drought-hit

Press Trust of India
MUMBAI

Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) leader Supriya Sule on Thursday demanded ₹1 lakh per hectare of financial assistance for drought-hit farmers in Maharashtra, and urged the State government to release pending aid under its schemes.

The Baramati MP said farmers were facing serious difficulties due to drought and rising inflation.

Ahead of Uttarakhand Assembly poll, Cong. begins 'Nyay Yatra'

Press Trust of India
DEHRADUN

The Congress in Uttarakhand on Thursday began its 'Nyay Yatra' to highlight the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government's "anti-people policies" and the "pressing issues facing the State", with only months to go before the Assembly poll.

Dhami govt. criticised

Congress leaders criticised Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami and his government over education, jobs, the Ankita Bhandari case, among others during marches held at several places.

State Congress president Ganesh Godiyal offered prayers at Badrinath Dham and led a march through Joshimath, Pipalkoti, and Chamoli. Led by Leader of the Opposition Yashpal Arya, another team started the yatra from Golju Temple in Almora and passed through Ranikhet, Khairna, Bhawali, Bhimtal, and Haldwani. In Dehradun, the march was flagged off by Congress election campaign committee chairperson Pritam Singh following prayers at Tapkeshwar Mahadev Temple.

"While the BJP claims to be the greatest champion of Sanatana Dharma, the offerings made by devotees at Badrinath Dham and the Ram Temple are not even safe under its government, a situation both deeply unfortunate and shameful," Mr. Godiyal said. He added that the state of basic amenities such as education, health care and drinking water remains deeply concerning in the State.

Bihar Council polls today; Patna Graduates' seat in focus as JD(U) faces internal tussle

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

Ahead of Friday's biennial elections to eight seats of the Bihar Legislative Council, State JD(U) president Umesh Kushwaha and party MLC Sanjay Kumar Singh on Thursday met Patna Graduates' seat candidate Neeraj Kumar for a closed-door meeting.

The seat, from which Mr. Kumar is seeking a fourth consecutive term, has become the centre of attention after JD(U)'s Mokama MLA Anant Singh declared support for Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) candidate Anuj Kumar Singh.



JD(U) MLA Anant Singh



JD(U) MLC Neeraj Kumar

Mr. Anant claimed that Mr. Kumar had opposed him in every Assembly election held in Mokama.

Polling for the four Graduates' and four Teachers' constituencies will be held from 8 a.m. to 4 p.m. Counting is scheduled for October 27. The terms of the sitting MLCs are set to expire on November 16.

The ruling allies BJP and JD(U) are contesting four seats each while the JSP is contesting all eight.

Bid to placate

The JD(U) twice tried to broker peace between Mr. Anant and Mr. Kumar. It had tasked Munger MP and Union Panchayati Raj Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh alias Lalan Singh to mediate. Mr. Lalan later said Mr. Anant had "reservations and grudges which the party should have addressed earlier".

An ironclad resolve in the national interest



Eknath Shinde
Deputy Chief Minister of Maharashtra

Home Minister Amit Shah's decision-making ability, commitment to national security, and role as one of the architects of modern India's development will ensure that his name occupies a prominent place in the country's political history

Some forces that cannot bear to see India's rapid march towards becoming a developed nation have become increasingly active in the country. Their intention is to poison the national atmosphere and create instability. As a result, the internal security challenges confronting India have become increasingly complex. Just as violent protests erupted in Nepal and Bangladesh, certain anti-national elements have begun speaking of triggering similar agitations in India. With the support of some foreign powers, Opposition parties are talking about a 'regime change'. Attempts are being made to undermine democracy and threaten the Constitution authored under the stewardship of Dr. Babasaheb Ambedkar. Efforts are also under way to fuel extremism in the country. Drug trafficking is on the rise. Misinformation spread through social media and attempts to create social discord pose a serious threat to India's social harmony.

However, no such instability will be allowed to take root in India, nor will the sinister designs of foreign powers be permitted to succeed. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, our country's formidable Home Minister Amit Shah is ensuring that this does not happen. The era when security agencies would scramble to respond only after an incident had occurred is long past. We are now in an era defined by Mr. Shah's firm, farsighted, swift, direct, and comprehensive decision-making. That is why the citizens of India need not fear any such attempts at destabilisation. Whatever may be happening elsewhere in the world, India remains a nation governed by the Constitution of Dr. Ambedkar. No one will succeed in pushing the country into anarchy. Mr. Shah celebrated his birthday on Thursday. While extending my birthday wishes to him, I pray to the Almighty to grant him the strength to maintain India's internal security at the highest level and effectively counter anti-national elements.

Historic decisions

When comparing India before 2014 with India after 2014, one cannot look merely at the change of political power. One must also consider the country's development aspirations, its approach to national security, the pace of infrastructure creation, India's position on the global stage, and its willingness to resolve long-pending issues. Mr. Modi's leadership gave a new direction to the aspirations of the nation while Mr. Shah strengthened this journey through his organisational capabilities, political planning, and support for key decisions.

As Union Home Minister, Mr. Shah has taken several historic decisions. On August 5, 2019, he announced in Parliament the decision to revoke Article 370, which had granted special status to Jammu and Kashmir. This decision became a milestone in safeguarding the country's unity and integrity. Subsequently, development across Kashmir gained momentum, and the region became more closely integrated with the national mainstream. He also took extremely firm measures to curb Naxalite activities within the country. Ending Naxalism is not merely about defeating armed extremist groups. It is equally important to provide roads, education, health care, employment, and administrative facilities to regions that have remained deprived of development for generations. Only by working simultaneously on the fronts of security and development can the foundations of peace be strengthened. The ultimate success of this campaign will be measured by whether citizens in areas emerging from the shadow of violence can live with dignity. The determination with which Mr. Shah has confronted Naxalism and terrorism has established him as an iron man of our times.

He has also brought several insurgent groups in the north-eastern region into the national mainstream. He has helped Parliament enact new laws, including the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, replacing several outdated colonial-era laws and giving India's criminal justice system a modern framework. Strict action has also been taken, through the armed forces and intelligence agencies, against elements that threaten India's sovereignty. Mr. Shah's leadership is particularly evident in his firm opposition to foreign interference in India's internal affairs. He takes decisive action without yielding to pressure when it comes to safeguarding the country's security and interests.

Zero tolerance towards drugs

He has consistently maintained that India's youth must not be exploited through protests for political gains or anti-national causes. Although the right to protest is an essential feature of democracy, he has repeatedly made it clear that damage to public property and the use of violence will not be tolerated. Mr. Shah has adopted a policy of zero tolerance towards drugs, which inflict enormous damage on the country's younger generation. Under his guidance, Central investigative agencies and State police forces have coordinated their efforts to dismantle major drug-trafficking networks. Strict measures have been taken to dismantle international syndicates and prevent smuggling through border regions.

Under Mr. Shah's leadership, the Ministry of Home Affairs has become a strong pillar of India's internal security. His guiding principle of 'Nation First' is clearly reflected in every decision he takes. In 2021, he had the distinction of becoming the first Minister of Cooperation after the government established a separate Ministry of Cooperation. He has worked to curb irregularities in the cooperative sector and dismantle the monopolistic control by several families. Most importantly, he has given the cooperative movement a modern, technology-driven identity and strengthened its ability to meet the challenges of competition. This has reinforced the agricultural economy.

Role of chief strategist

Mr. Shah is a man of firm resolve who stands by his word. He has been the architect of many victories of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and is a trusted guide and supporter of mine. In today's India, only a handful of leaders are judged not by the number of years they have lived, but by the heights of achievement they have attained. Mr. Shah is one of those prominent leaders. He has played the role of chief strategist in securing unprecedented success for the BJP. His political influence began at the level of a booth worker and reached the office of the country's Home Minister. This journey bears testimony to his hard work, precise organisational skills, and strategic decision-making. At the age of 16, he became a volunteer of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. The values instilled by the organisation are reflected in his political decisions and approach to public life.

I have met Mr. Shah many times over the past six to seven years. I have had hundreds of opportunities to discuss issues with him. These interactions have given me firsthand experience of his ability to make precise and timely political decisions. Whenever I meet him as a friend and mentor, I see his compassionate side. Yet, when confronted with a difficult test, his uncompromising firmness becomes equally evident. I have personally witnessed Mr. Shah's affection for Maharashtra, his deep interest in the State's history and, in particular, his admiration and pride in the valour of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj. Our mutual trust, similarities in political thinking, and shared objective of ensuring that the Mahayuti government remains strong and stable have meant that he has always stood firmly by my side.

It is precisely these qualities that have earned him the reputation of being the Chanakya of the BJP. To truly understand his Chanakya-like qualities, one must examine the principles of Chanakya Niti. There are five major aspects: education, confidentiality, management, avoiding arguments with foolish or ignorant people, and dedication to duty.

Mr. Shah's decision-making ability, commitment to national security, administrative competence and role as one of the architects of modern India's development will ensure that his name occupies a prominent place in the country's political history. My heartfelt wish is that Mr. Shah continues his tireless service to the nation with the same determination and dedication for many years to come.

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9th HOCKEY ASIAN CHAMPIONS TROPHY PUNJAB, 2026

JALANDHAR – MOHALI
OCT. 27 – NOV. 5, 2026



S. Bhagwant Singh Mann
Chief Minister, Punjab



SIX NATIONS, ONE CHAMPIONSHIP

DATE	TIME	TEAM vs TEAM	VENUE
27 October, 2026	13:00	Malaysia vs China	Jalandhar
	15:15	Japan vs Korea	Jalandhar
	19:00	India vs Bangladesh	Jalandhar
29 October, 2026	14:30	Malaysia vs Korea	Jalandhar
	16:45	Bangladesh vs Japan	Jalandhar
	19:00	India vs China	Jalandhar
30 October, 2026	14:30	Bangladesh vs Malaysia	Jalandhar
	16:45	Korea vs China	Jalandhar
	19:00	Japan vs India	Jalandhar
1 November, 2026	14:30	Korea vs Bangladesh	Jalandhar
	16:45	China vs Japan	Jalandhar
	19:00	Malaysia vs India	Jalandhar
2 November, 2026	14:30	China vs Bangladesh	Jalandhar
	16:45	Japan vs Malaysia	Jalandhar
	19:00	India vs Korea	Jalandhar
4 November, 2026	14:00	5th in Pool vs 6th in Pool	Mohali
	16:30	1st in Pool vs 4th in Pool	Mohali
	19:00	2nd in Pool vs 3rd in Pool	Mohali
5 November, 2026	16:30	**Bronze Medal Match**	Mohali
	19:00	**Gold Medal Match**	Mohali

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Department of Information and Public Relations, Punjab



(Clockwise from left) Savitri Hooda, 65, with her son Ashish, 27; a post from Amrit Kaur's Instagram handle, where she is lifting dumbbells; Birvati, 85, who creates comedy and dance videos, poses with her 20-year-old granddaughter Neha.
ASHOK KUMAR, @GETFITWITHDADI



The grandmothers hitting patriarchy and weights

Grandmothers in areas surrounding Delhi are rewriting the rules of engagement, one reel at a time. From challenging patriarchy and lifting weights to dancing to Haryanvi pop and inspiring other seniors to embrace fitness, they are turning social media into a platform for self-expression, defiance, and a new-found freedom, finds **Ashok Kumar**

Period blood is the only blood which does not flow because of violence. Still society despises that blood the most." Savitri Hooda, 65, speaks straight into her phone camera, standing under a neem tree in her home's backyard. That video, shot from Rohtak's Mungan village, 70 km north-west of Delhi, got 19,000 'likes' on Instagram.

In another reel, she looks at the camera and calls her own generation "shoddy". "Should I list their misdeeds? They killed daughters in the womb, discriminated against their own daughters, burnt their daughters-in-law for dowry, and leered at other women. They treated women as second-class citizens and now cannot stand their freedom." That got her 4,87,000 likes, and a whole lot of comments from people showering love on "Dadi".

Welcome to @tai_savitri's month-old Instagram account that has just 27 posts, but 3,08,000 followers. Her bio says: "Desi feminist from Haryana. Freedom and unfiltered opinions."

The overwhelming response to her profile has been startling even for the family. Her son, Ashish, recalls receiving the first podcast invitation when Savitri had around 3,000 followers. After her video on mental health went viral last month, interview requests began pouring in.

Across the National Capital Region (NCR), women over 60 are putting their voices out on social media. They are singing, dancing, and giving out wisdom that the youth is lapping up.

> I don't like praising myself, but there is hardly anyone who has not seen my videos. People, not just in India, but even abroad are getting to know me. Women my age tell me, 'Amma, you have done something remarkable at this age. You have made a name!'"
>
> **BIRVATI, 85**
> Influencer, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh

The irreverent feminist

For Savitri, speaking her mind is hardly new. The rebellious streak that now finds an audience online surfaced when she was a schoolgirl. She dropped out in Class 7, after her mother, who she describes as "very conservative", refused to let her participate in a school play about dowry and opposed her taking up judo as well. "She thought it would bring shame upon the family. So I quit my studies in protest," Savitri says.

It is a decision she still regrets.

Her formal education may have ended early, but Ashish says his mother has always been receptive to new ideas. She listens, reflects, and frequently brings her own observations into discussions, sometimes surprising the family with the connections she makes.

Her curiosity has also translated into considerable digital independence. Savitri records and uploads videos, manages her YouTube account and responds to comments herself. She uses the voice-to-text tool because it is faster than entering text manually. "If someone writes in English and I cannot understand the comment, I reply, 'Thank you for sharing your views'," she says.

To meet her is to meet an anti-influencer. She sits cross-legged on a bed in a dimly lit room, plaster peeling off its green-painted walls. Clothes hang shabbily on pegs. Ashish, an aspiring stand-up comic and novelist, leaning against a pillow beside her. She asks her husband to make three cups of tea. "What is the point in talking about feminism if I cannot finish patriarchy at my own house?" she says, chuckling.

Her social media journey started as a son's sentimental plan during COVID-19. "He said it would preserve my memories. That the children could watch their grandmother singing folk songs when they grew up," Savitri says, as her grandson sits by her. "I was fond of singing, so I agreed. That channel, '*Yo Apna* Haryana', renamed 'Tai Savitri', now has 3,31,000 subscribers and 14,000 videos. But singing felt hollow after her singing partner lost her 28-year-old son in an accident. So she quit.

"When the singing stopped, we had to think about what to do next," says Ashish, who has a postgraduate degree in Zoology. The answer emerged from conversations at home.

Ashish had developed an interest in theatre, philosophy, and psychology over the years. So, discussions about ideas and society were a regular feature of family life.

Ashish says that he does not quote philosophers word for word to his mother. Instead, he translates them into everyday language, allowing discussions to unfold at home over days or even weeks before they eventually find expression in a video.

It led to her creating videos on feminism and against social evils.

Bertrand Russell's proposition that people should need a licence to become parents, for instance, prompted a conversation that led to one of Savitri's most-watched videos on parenting. At other times, the starting point is something she observes in society or among people around her. "The videos are not scripted. If I get her to deliver it as a script, she won't be able to speak with the same conviction," says the 27-year-old.

After a mental health video went viral, the family received an anonymous call from a man who threatened to kill Savitri. "That was the first time I was genuinely frightened," says Ashish.

Her criticism of local godmen in her videos has also drawn displeasure. The backlash has not been confined to anonymous callers. A khap leader once called on his father, Bijender Singh Hooda, to complain. "He said my father had removed the *nath* – the nose rope – from his wife. He was comparing a woman to an animal controlled by a nose rope," he says.

Savitri, meanwhile, draws inspiration from watching godman-philosopher Osho and civil services exam coach Vikas Divyakirti. Her subjects have expanded from feminism to mental health and Gen Z, but Ashish says there is no deliberate strategy behind the transition. The themes emerge naturally from what they see and discuss around them. But she is not done. "Whether people throw flowers at me or slippers, I am going to debut as a stand-up comedian soon. My son is writing it for me," she announces. And she wants a passport stamp. "I have seen enough of Haryana, now I want to go abroad. I don't have money. If someone sponsors me, I would like to travel to Australia and the U.S.," she says, deadpan.



The dancing *dadi*

More than 100 km from Savitri Hooda's village in Rohtak, in a crowded lane of Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, Birvati, 85, another woman is blowing up the idea of age-appropriate. Yellow tee, brown pants, two pigtails, the unlettered *dadi* (paternal grandmother) breaks into a Haryanvi pop number –*'Mera Balam Thanedar'*– with the energy of a teenager.

She has 5,36,000 views with just that one video. Her handle on Instagram, dadi_comedy_63, has 230 posts and is less than a year old, with 1,16,000 followers already. Her son Kiranpal sells artificial jewellery, at weekly markets. These days, he says, the market comes to them. "People now recognise her. When we go to the market, people come and sit beside her and say, 'Amma, look how well your videos are doing!' There is so much excitement. People ask her, 'Amma, where did you learn all this? You do it so well!'" he says, proudly.

Birvati, with white hair and wrinkled skin, plays humble, but knows her influence. "I don't like praising myself, but there is hardly anyone who has not seen my videos. People, not just in India, but even abroad are getting to know me," she says with a toothless grin.

"Women my age tell me, 'Amma, you have done something remarkable at this age. You have made a name!'" she adds.

Her granddaughter Neha says people are pulled in by her energy.

"The dance moves she does are rare for people her age. Most people are fascinated by her energy," says the 20-year-old, who is Birvati's choreographer, costume designer, and editor. "She wears different outfits for songs, rarely a sari. She experiments with hairstyles, and even asks me, 'Can I go out wearing jeans?'"

But this wasn't supposed to be Birvati's channel. It was Neha's. She has a degree in optometry and wanted to create online content. Her parents said no, afraid of facing a problem finding groom for a girl who is popular online. So Neha brought in her grandmother, who had been the life and soul of every family wedding in her youth, to dance with her. They started in December last year, with a YouTube channel called 'Neha Panchal', posting dance and humorous videos, both *dadi* and granddaughter in frame. Their first video got a like from singer Neha Kakkar. That was enough to keep going. Instagram came a month later. And it exploded. Younger audience, more likes, more engagement. "Whenever I tell her we are shooting, she gets ready an hour in advance. She is more excited than I am. She gets dressed on her own. Sometimes she chooses the song herself. Some videos on the rooftop, some in the park outside, and some on the middle floor. I have decorated a corner for this," Neha says.

"In the beginning, the comments were brutal. "At this age, do bhajans, not dances. Go to the temple," people wrote. Neha's batchmates laughed at her, saying she was unnecessarily dragging her grandmother in. She ignored them. Now the whole family is involved. Neha's mother, Poonam, once hooked to Hindi novels, is the scriptwriter for their comedy sketches. "She reads stories, watches things, and comes up with ideas." Older sister Riya also pops in.

Birvati wants to contribute financially. Neha says Punjabi singers have approached them for paid promotions, but the income is still small and unsteady. But Birvati wants to grow into her newfound career and make her own songs. "I want a role in a Haryanvi music video," she says.

Dare to deadlift

Cut from a 50 sq. ft. house in Ghaziabad to a plush plotted house in South City-I, Gurugram. Amrit Kaur, 75, sits gracefully on a beige tufted sofa, hands folded neatly in her lap, composed, almost stern. Four years ago, she could barely walk. "I have always been strong. But four years ago, I became seriously ill. I was very weak, and was admitted in hospital," she recalls. "I thought I would recover in a few days, but the weakness was considerable." Today she does an hour of strength training at 4 a.m. every day.

She can do a dozen push-ups.

Her Instagram handle, @getfitwithdadi, has just 40 posts, 17,000 followers and a video with 80 lakh views. Her son, Aminder Singh, sits beside her. In his early 50s, Singh is the founder of Team Aminder, and has been training people for 30 years, with clients in 42 countries. "She was very weak after hospital. But I used to tell her, 'Mummy, you are very strong,'" he says.

He made her start small. Tie a rope between door frames. Pull it. Do a squat. Again.

"At first, I could do very little. But slowly, I began to feel that I was regaining some strength," Amrit says, who was reluctant to start.

The first video went up on August 23 last year. The idea was simple. "We thought appreciation would motivate her," Aminder says. It was also about busting a gym myth. "Exercises people think are only for young people are actually meant for older people. But you hardly find any seniors in gyms. We tried to convince people; nobody accepted. So we decided to prove it at home through her videos," he says.

Amrit begins her day at 3 or 3.30 a.m. with prayers. "Then I begin exercising," she says. "I keep chanting *'Waheguru, Satnam, Waheguru, Satnam'* as I squat. My prayers and exercise go on together. Gradually I increased the time. Now I exercise for an hour."

Comments pour in. "You have done something wonderful, Dadi! You are amazing!" says one. She reads them, but doesn't reply. "I feel particularly happy when others imitate me. I feel the exercises I do are useful to others," she says. At the nearby gurdwara, devotees now recognise her as: "*Arre*, video *wali dadi* (Oh, The grandmother from the video)!" Taking a cue from Amrit, Aminder's mother-in-law Deepa Bindra has started her own handle @getfitwithnaani, with seven posts and 3,916 followers already. Amrit has a message that isn't about protein: "Exercise is effective only if we are happy."

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A new path Kamlesh Sawant and Ajay Devgn in *Drishyam: The Conclusion*; (below) Abhishek Pathak. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



A fulfilling spectacle

As *Drishyam: The Conclusion* solidifies its run at the box office, director Abhishek Pathak on why he deviated from the Malayalam version

Shreyas Pande
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Drishyam The Conclusion maintains its deceptive streak. The flimsy mind games of Ajay Devgn's Vijay Salgaonkar turn into a fulfilling spectacle in the final part of the famed franchise. As the film continues to rake in numbers at the box office, director Abhishek Pathak is pleased with the outcome. "It has been overwhelming to see the reactions of people who like the film," he says, as he spends a well-earned break with his family.

Family is what drives Vijay to single-handedly outwit an entire system, whether it is tackling the wrath of the chain-smoking top cop, SP Rajveer Singh Tomar (Jaideep Ahlawat), or challenging the logical arguments of the hot-shot lawyer, Indrajith Shetty (Prakash Raj). Vijay enters God-mode as he plants alibis, destroys evidence and ends up having the last laugh. That is what separates Vijay from Mohanlal's Georgekutty, as the Hindi third part takes a markedly different approach from Jeetu Joseph's Malayalam version, which was released earlier this year and leaned towards subdued psychological drama rather than the suspense-driven beats of *Drishyam: The Conclusion*. Abhishek reveals that the idea to make an original third part came after the release of *Drishyam 2*.

"While many loved the film, there was still a section of audiences who were talking about the Malayalam version. I felt that I had to make my own film next time. So, I told my writers to work on an original story and not wait for the Malayalam film to remake it," says Abhishek, who has co-written the film with Aamil Keeyan Khan and Parveez Shaikh.

The writer-director reached out to Jeetu Joseph when the film's screenplay was ready and offered to read the Hindi original. "I think they were still writing the screenplay of the Malayalam version. I am glad that ultimately they made their version and we made ours."

The difference in Abhishek's approach to the third part is apparent in how he shapes the film as an entertainer following the rhythm of a gripping Bollywood spectacle, full of pulpy twists and *dialoguebaazi*. It carries that old-school charm of Hindi cinema where the hero takes on the powerful and emerges victorious by fighting an almost impossible-to-win battle. "We are not making films that will be watched only by a few in a room; we are making films for people globally, who should be able to connect to it," he opines.

Perhaps that is why the franchise has witnessed growing popularity on social media in the form of memes ever since the first part came out in 2015. The most viral among them is the one about October 2, the day when Vijay's family supposedly went to an ashram in *Drishyam*, mainly to build an alibi. The third part releasing on the same date is a nod from the makers to the franchise's vibrant afterlife.

> ***A screenplay needs time to live and breathe. Even after writing it, one still needs to spend more time with it to understand the loopholes***
>
> **ABHISHEK PATHAK**
> Director

Another talking point has been Gaitonde (Kamlesh Sawant), the foul, Marathi-accented, Hindi-speaking arch-rival of Vijay, who has been after the family since the murder happened in the first part. While the character had a serious tone in *Drishyam*, he shifts into comical touches this time, often becoming the medium for some meta-jokes.

Beneath the comedic cover and thrilling beats, *Drishyam: The Conclusion* makes a point about truth and manipulation as Vijay masterfully deceives everyone around him. In these portions, the film becomes an allegory for the post-truth world.

For Abhishek, the key to building suspense is spending time with the screenplay without rushing for the shoot. "A screenplay needs time to live and breathe. Even after writing it, one still needs to spend more time with it to understand the loopholes," he says.

Pop goes the stage

Weverse Con Festival India comes to Delhi in March 2027

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Tomorrow X Together, Le Sserafim, Enhypen, Hwasa, and Lara of girl group Katseye will be a part of the debut edition of Weverse Con Festival India scheduled to take place on March 27 and 28, 2027 in New Delhi.

Co-produced by HYBE INDIA and Bookmyshow the festival will feature a mix of K-pop and international acts. A flagship global music festival which has seen multiple editions in South Korea, this will be the event's international debut. Indian acts including Gini, King, RANJ X Clifr, Reble, and DJ Zelo have also been announced as part of the lineup. The anticipation for a K-pop concert or music festival of this scale has been steadily building up ever since HYBE, the agency that manages a host of K-pop talent including BTS, made inroads into India and set up an office in Mumbai sometime ago.

"For years, Indian fans have been at the heart of K-pop, supporting our artistes, and building a community that has continued to grow across generations. We also want to make the festival as accessible as possible, as a way of giving back to the fans for their unwavering support," says Sarthak Arora, head, Business Development, HYBE INDIA.

Naman Pugalia, CBO, Live Events, BookMyShow, adds that the lineup for this festival captures that reach of K-Pop in India.

Mastercard cardholders will have exclusive access to the ticket pre-sale beginning October 27, followed by general ticket sales from October 30 on Bookmyshow.com



Members of Tomorrow X Together GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Rooted to the city

A Spring Against All Odds, one of 48 films selected for Film SouthAsia, is a portrait of Delhi as seen through a red silk cotton tree



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Roundglass Sustain's short film *A Spring Against All Odds* opens with a poignant couplet by 18th Century Urdu poet Mir Taqi Mir: *My heart and my Delhi may both be in ruins; There are still some delights in this ravaged home.*

Centuries later, the words still ring true, setting the tone for this layered, deeply introspective film, one of 48 selected for Film SouthAsia (FSA), an international documentary film festival to be held in Kathmandu from November 27-29.

Based on a story and script by Radhika Raj and directed and edited by Samreen Farooqui, the film captures the three years Radhika spent obsessing over the red silk cotton tree, or semal, outside her window in her Delhi home.

The film features an eclectic cast: Radhika, her partner Saptak, house help Swati, and cats Chutney and Chikki, plus the semal tree itself and the pair of grey hornbills that inhabits it.

Opening in 2021, when Radhika and Saptak move into a new home overlooking this tree, the film shows how the tree becomes a constant witness to multiple crises, including a mismanaged pandemic, a winter thick with pollution, floods, an oppressive summer, a political shift, and a personal loss, as the film's release states.



Spring on film (Top) Delhi's Sabz Burj monument; (above) Radhika Raj setting up her camera. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Finding home

"My life was unravelling in many ways, along with the city. I was struggling emotionally... grieving," says Radhika, who believes that the tree held her together during this challenging period. "It became an antidote to what was happening in my life," she adds.

For Samreen, the idea for the film originated from Radhika saying she had moved into this house. It got them talking about making a short natural history video about the semal and the birds nesting in it, recalls Samreen. But the more she heard Radhika talk about the tree, the more she realised it could become a full film. "We started to expand on that idea, because the city is full of red silk cotton trees," she says.

Radhika, who thinks of the film as almost "accidental, started by doing what Samreen had told her to do: put a camera on the window and capture what was happening.

The tree became "a microcosm of everything happening in our lives, the natural life of the city and the city itself," says Samreen.

The film is also an unusual exploration of Delhi, a city filled with these trees and one that both Samreen and Radhika hold dear, in very different ways.

"I am from Mumbai, and came here for college, work and then married someone from here," says Radhika, who ends up falling in love with the city, though she agrees it is a difficult place to live in. "In a way, the tree offered an alternate lens to look at the city, experiencing it through trees, time and seasons. It allowed me a second chance to love Delhi."

Samreen, on the other hand, grew up in Delhi and lived there for most of her life. "But now I live in Bengaluru. Delhi has kind of made me, so I have a complicated, love-hate relationship with it," she says. The film helped her witness the city again and, in the process, find the city she wanted, she says. "Delhi is also the city of the 17th Century poets, and Delhi became their muse. So the poetry became very pivotal to the film."

While she agrees that much has gone wrong in Delhi – the pollution, political uncertainty, and public apathy have made it a shadow of what it once was, it also refuses to be undone by them. "That became very clear to me while I was editing the film," says Samreen, who took nearly a year to finish it.

In her opinion, *A Spring Against All Odds* is not just an intimate narrative of South Asia highlighting the relationship between a tree and a woman, but "really the story of cities all over South Asia," says Samreen.



Luxury reads (Left) Assouline store in The Chanakya, Delhi; (inset) books from Assouline. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

In the good books

The French luxury house comes to The Chanakya with its handmade, bespoke volumes

Deepali Dhingra

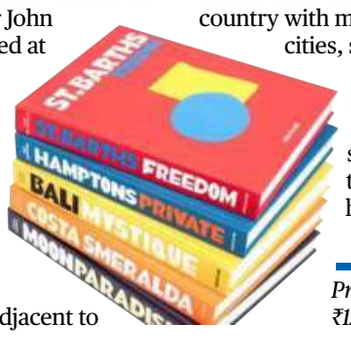
In 1994, Prosper and Martine Assouline stumbled upon La Colombe d'Or, a charming hotel nestled in the South of France. Enchanted by its warmth and history, the couple decided to photograph it and publish a book detailing its history and romance – a gesture that sparked a global publishing empire. What began as a passion project soon evolved into a philosophy – books ought to be treated not merely as reading material, but as tangible luxury objects and cultural heirlooms.

Fast forward to today, and the brand has made its official grand entry into India with its first flagship boutique at The Chanakya in New Delhi. Stepping past its signature red façade and gold doors is akin to stepping into a collector's private library.

"India has always been a source of inspiration for us. It is a country of extraordinary culture and craftsmanship, and it has a long tradition of storytelling, which is what we do," says Alex Assouline, president of the brand. "Today it is also one of the most dynamic and fastest-growing markets in the world, with an ever-widening circle of connoisseurs who travel, collect, and care deeply about design and beauty. Opening here felt natural," he adds.

Inside the intimate 1,000-square-foot space, the craftsmanship is immediately evident. These are handmade volumes, some requiring up to 1,000 hours of painstaking labour, research, and bespoke binding. Rather than pushing simple paper backs, Assouline experiments with rich materials, including cotton-infused linen, leather, high-quality polymers, and hand-carved wood. A volume on wine and whiskey, for instance, arrives encased in a wooden cask cover inspired by ageing barrels, while titles dedicated to sports like basketball and rugby are bound in rich, textured leather.

Among the boutique's showstoppers is a rare volume on American sculptor John Chamberlain, priced at ₹3,60,000. It is a true collector's piece, with only 200 worldwide copies. It is finished in material reminiscent of the artist's original sculptural work. Adjacent to it sit titles dedicated to luxury stalwarts like Cartier, Rolex, and Patek Philippe, alongside their famed Ultimate Collection.



Prices are upwards of ₹12,300.

Colours and contrasts

The visually arresting Travel Series remains a massive hit. Featuring vibrant, pop-art covers celebrating global destinations, including Rajasthan and Jaipur, the collection captures the spirit of wandering. To deepen the experience, Assouline pairs these volumes with destination-inspired candles designed to evoke the sensory atmosphere of each city.

"We want people to think of Assouline as a true luxury brand on culture," Alex shares, and adds, "We are not only a publisher; we create objects that tell stories about travel, fashion, art, design, and the art of living. When someone steps into the boutique, we want them to feel as if they have entered a private library inside a beautiful home." The brand works with some of the most respected brands, artists, photographers, writers and designers in the world. At the boutique, guests can turn the pages of their oversized volumes, discover a curated selection, and build a library that reflects who they are.

While India has long viewed luxury gifting through the lens of fine china, crystal, or silverware, Assouline is subtly shifting the paradigm toward intellectual design and home decor. Alex promises that there is more to come. "New Delhi is an important step in our international journey. Our priority now is to make this boutique a true destination and to build a relationship with our clients here. India is a vast country with many extraordinary cities, so we will keep listening and exploring, and we look forward to sharing more when the time is right," he signs off.

Canary in coal mine

Core sector data indicate impending growth slowdowns

The latest data on the performance of the core industrial sectors show the economy may be facing an industrial uptick, but questions about its sustainability remain. Growth in the Index of Core Industries rose to a series-high of 7.9% in September 2026, the second consecutive month of accelerated performance. Any such improvement is to be celebrated, but a deeper look at what is driving it is also warranted. The coal sector saw growth suddenly shoot up to 10.7% in September. The unexpected and unusual nature of this rapid acceleration can be borne out by the fact that the sector contracted by 1.1% over the longer April-September 2026 period. The growth in coal in September was likely a temporary blip aided by a statistical low base and, more importantly, pressure from power plant operators over rapidly depleting coal stocks amid the heat wave. The electricity sector grew 11.4% in September, capping off a half-year dominated by double-digit growth. This surge in electricity-related demand for coal will likely wane, especially since the El Niño factor that drove the heat wave will also result in a milder winter. The other sector that results in high coal usage, the steel sector, did accelerate in September, but not by enough to sustain the coal sector's September output. The uptick in steel did, however, result in a return to double-digit growth for the iron ore sector, which should bode well for the mining component of the larger Index of Industrial Production.

The performance of the crude oil, natural gas, and refinery products sectors also highlights the fiscal problems India faces. At a time when the crude oil and natural gas sectors have both contracted continuously since 2024, refinery output rose to 10.3% in September. This means that the refineries were increasingly processing expensive imported oil. India's oil imports in September were up 7% by volume but jumped 47% in terms of value due to the high price of oil. This is set to worsen. The attacks on Saudi Arabia's energy infrastructure have already pushed global oil prices above $112 a barrel, almost a six-month high. The reprieve from the U.S. on potential tariffs linked to imports of Russian oil provide India a reliable source, but the days of discounts are long gone. It is the time of premium pricing, and each barrel imported is eating into India's foreign exchange reserves, which are also being used to defend the rupee. Cement and steel are the only sustainably growing core sectors, and those too are based on government infrastructure spending. At a time when industrial output is only temporarily propped up, the government's fiscal space is fast shrinking.

Tunnelling through

Domestic manufacturing and foreign partnerships must go hand-in-hand

The Chinese Ministry of Commerce and the General Administration of Customs decision to place tunnel-boring machines (TBMs) on an export control list reveals a blind spot in India's supply chain diversification. The curbs include TBMs, walking excavators, and high-altitude wet shotcrete machines. From November 18, if a shipment is intended for countries or regions deemed sensitive due to ongoing disputes with China, exporters will need an export licence from commerce authorities. For other countries/regions, exporters will need to be registered, obtain an export certificate, and submit end-use declarations stating that the equipment will not be re-routed to sensitive locations. While China has cornered around 70% of the global TBM market, prominent manufacturers in the West also maintain substantial component supply chains in the country to cut manufacturing overhead. Further, TBMs are complex to build as they have to be configured to geological characteristics at the project site and perform numerous tasks. Where a suitable TBM exists, it can be used for civilian or military purposes. India has struggled with TBM-related hold-ups with China for at least two years now, including for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail project. Germany's Herrenknecht AG set up an assembling and refurbishing facility in Chennai in 2007-08. TBM production economics differ significantly from conventional construction equipment as new plants need a minimum number of orders and must be able to access the industrial capability required to design, manufacture and repair specialised components.

However, even though India is one of the world's largest TBM importers, expecting every sophisticated machine to be produced domestically will send public infrastructure costs soaring. Even now, depending on China's decision on the TBMs set for India, India may have to redirect its procurement to facilities based directly in Germany or Japan, say, and absorb the higher capital cost. The BEML experience shows that manufacturing partnerships can fail without secure licensing arrangements and access to sustained demand. India should pursue domestic manufacturing alongside international partnerships, e.g., making equipment in the country under agreement with established foreign firms, and develop shared industrial capabilities rather than singular 'national champions', as TBM manufacturers and their suppliers can benefit from access to common testing and precision manufacturing infrastructure. Overall, Beijing is systematically identifying sectors where it commands a significant global capacity and establishing export controls to counter western technological restrictions, such as on advanced semiconductors, so any critical infrastructure sector relying on Chinese supply lines will face a compounding geopolitical risk.

Prasar Bharati is not a public service broadcaster



Suhas Borker

Editor, Citizens First TV (CFTV), who has advocated public service broadcasting since the 1990s as convener of Jan Prasar. In 2000, he conceptualised National Public Service Broadcasting Day, on November 12

When the Narendra Modi government took office in May 2014, the then Information and Broadcasting Minister, Prakash Javadekar, promised to end the "government fiefdom" over Prasar Bharati and recast it on the British Broadcasting Corporation (BBC) model: autonomous in administration, free in editorial judgement, and accountable to Parliament.

Twelve years later that promise remains unfulfilled. The 138th episode of "Mann Ki Baat", broadcast on September 27, 2026, is only the most visible reminder that the state still treats the public airwaves as its own platform.

The BBC model, unfulfilled

The irony is sharp. The same political class that invoked the BBC as the template, later accused it of a "continuing colonial mindset" after it telecast the documentary in 2023, "India: The Modi Question". From April 2024 the BBC had to split its Indian news operation to meet foreign-investment rules.

The deeper story is older than the Emergency. In 1948, Jawaharlal Nehru told the Constituent Assembly – then the only authoritative Indian statement on the British model – "my own view of the set-up for broadcasting is that we should approximate, as far as possible, to the British model, the BBC, that is to say, it would be better if we had a semi-autonomous corporation under the government, of course with the policy controlled by the government, otherwise not conducted as a government department." Even that caveat – "otherwise not conducted as a government department" – has not been honoured.

Mark Tully, former BBC bureau chief in Delhi, put the same distinction succinctly in a conversation in 2017: public service broadcasting "is not the same as government broadcast". It rests on two principles, he said – that the government must not interfere in the broadcaster's autonomy, and that programmes must not be judged by commercial merit alone. Without autonomy and freedom, he added, All India Radio cannot become a broadcaster for transformative change.

The Emergency of 1975 reduced All India Radio (AIR) and Doordarshan to instruments of the regime. After Indira Gandhi's defeat, the Janata government asked B.G. Verghese to recommend autonomy. His BBC-style model became a Bill in 1979 (Prasar Bharati Bill), but the Bill lapsed. A new version, introduced in 1989 as "a charter of freedom" under Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution, received assent in 1990 – as the Prasar Bharati (Broadcasting Corporation of India) Act, 1990 – and was enforced only in 1997. Its Statement of Objects and Reasons said the corporation should be "a genuinely autonomous body – innovative, dynamic and flexible – with a high degree of credibility", responsible to the people and to Parliament. Nearly three decades on, Prasar Bharati is not that body. It is a pretender, a mouthpiece of the government of the day. Section 12 of the Act is the editorial constitution that was meant to lock that intent in. The primary duty is to organise public broadcasting services to inform, educate and entertain. Section 12(2)(b) requires the corporation to safeguard "the citizen's right to be informed freely, truthfully and objectively" and to present "a fair and balanced flow of information including contrasting views without advocating any opinion or ideology of its own".

Prasar Bharati remains a pretender — 12 years after a promise of BBC-style autonomy, the corporation is still on a ministerial leash

At the Ministry's mercy

A truncated corporation was set up so that it cannot function independently of government. Critical Sections 13, 14 and 15 of the Act remain unimplemented. Section 13 requires a 22-member parliamentary committee, elected from both Houses, to oversee Prasar Bharati on Parliament's behalf. No government has constituted it. Former chief executive Jawhar Sircar has explained why: Ministers insist that they alone are answerable to Parliament and therefore retain the power to summon AIR and Doordarshan officials until they succumb.

Sections 14 and 15 require a Broadcasting Council to receive complaints and guard political impartiality. That Council has never been set up, and it follows that there is no system for editorial redress. The Board, meant to be professionally managed, has been filled with pliable bureaucrats. Ownership of assets and staff was never transferred. Without its own fund, the Board remains at the Ministry's mercy. Section 23 still lets the Centre issue binding directions on what may or may not be broadcast.

Section 10 required a recruitment board to keep appointments free of government interference. Nothing happened until July 2020, when Jagadish Upasane, who headed Bharat Prakashan, publisher of Panchajanya and Organiser, was made chairman. Autonomy was compromised the moment it was announced. A 2021 manpower audit used the BBC as the benchmark: almost half of Prasar Bharati's then 25,000-strong workforce sat in engineering, against a little over 10% at the BBC, while content staff were under 20% against about 70%. The numbers described a transmission machine, not a Content-and-News-driven broadcaster.

UNESCO's 2001 definition is exacting. Public broadcasting is neither commercial nor state-controlled; it speaks to every citizen. Prasar Bharati fails that test. In 2000 the government declared November 12 as Public Service Broadcasting Day to mark Gandhiji's only AIR broadcast, made in 1947 to two lakh refugees at Kurukshetra. The day has since become tokenism. In 2022 even that tokenism turned into farce when a Christian hymn sung by school students was sought to be dropped from the commemorative national broadcast.

The social contract is simple. The broadcaster has the right to speak freely, and in return it owes the public accuracy, impartiality, and independence from both the market and the Ministry. Nehru's 1948 formula already drew that line: policy may be set, the daily conduct of broadcasting may not be run as a government department. In 1995, Justice P.B. Sawant, speaking for the Supreme Court in *Secretary, Ministry of Information and Broadcasting vs Cricket Association of Bengal*, went further. Airwaves are public property, he held, and the Centre must establish an independent autonomous public authority to control their use. Public broadcasting is not state broadcasting. That direction has still not been carried out.

There must be political will

What needs to be done is already known. The parliamentary committee must be constituted, the Board rebuilt as a professional body, and assets and staff transferred. The regulatory council named in the Act must be created, funding designed without government strings, and Indian Information Service officers removed from operational control. The 1990 Act must be amended where practice has exposed its traps.

None of this happens without political will. The syndrome is familiar: autonomy is criticised out of power and forgotten in power. In August 2026, the government told the Lok Sabha that it had received no formal complaints from journalists or media bodies about its autonomy in the previous year. The absence of filed grievances is not evidence of independence. The Broadcasting Council named in the Act was never created, so there is nowhere for such a complaint to go.

The Chanda Committee, appointed when Indira Gandhi was Information and Broadcasting Minister, concluded in 1966 that "a psychological transformation is necessary" in the government's approach to broadcasting. Sixty years later that transformation has not come, and Nehru's "otherwise not conducted as a government department" remains unkept words. The options before the people are two: approach the courts to enforce the Act and the Sawant direction, or wait for the 2029 general election and a Lok Sabha willing to turn Prasar Bharati from a government handmaiden into a public service broadcaster. Until then it remains what it has been for nearly three decades: a disguised pretender.

Tied by geography, divided by politics



Mohammed Ayoob

University Distinguished Professor Emeritus of International Relations, Michigan State University, and the author, with K. Subrahmanyam, of 'The Liberation War' (1972)

With speculation rife that Bangladesh's recently elected Prime Minister Tarique Rahman (and also Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) Chairman) will be visiting New Delhi in November or December, it is time to assess the state of India-Bangladesh relations and analyse the roots of the problems between the two countries.

The seeds of their current tension lie in the liberation war of 1971 itself. From the very beginning, the attitude of Bangladesh's elites toward India has wavered between gratitude and resentment – gratitude for India's crucial role in the liberation of their country and resentment against the fact that India had to play the role of liberator – a role they should have performed themselves.

An ambivalence

Nations cherish narratives in which they are the principal authors of their own liberation. Bangladesh is no exception. The contribution of the Mukti Bahini notwithstanding, the decisive military blow against Pakistan was delivered by India. What was initially the source of immense gratitude with the passage of time became a source of grave discomfort.

Moreover, from the very beginning Dhaka was worried that India's policy towards Bangladesh would be mediated through a Hindu-majority West Bengal next door which has strong cultural and linguistic affinities with Bangladesh that could threaten the development of Bangladesh's independent identity. The open borders in the immediate aftermath of the liberation war also revived memories of the socio-economic dominance of the Hindu bhadralok in pre-Partition Bengal.

This was compounded by the fact that Bangladesh was virtually surrounded by India, sharing a border of more than 4,000 kilometres. Its principal rivers flowed through or originated in India. Its economic and strategic room for manoeuvre appeared constrained by geography. Consequently, the fear of Indian domination became an important component of Bangladeshi nationalism.

India and Bangladesh must overcome mistrust and pursue pragmatic neighbourhood cooperation

The honeymoon between Dhaka and New Delhi was indeed short. Sheikh Mujib and Indira Gandhi shared a great deal of goodwill. But the governments that succeeded Mujib deliberately distanced Bangladesh from India. Under Ziaur Rahman, Bangladeshi nationalism was redefined in overtly Islamic terms in contradistinction to the linguistic nationalism that had provided the ideological foundation of the liberation movement.

Dhaka's foreign policy

This had important foreign policy consequences. Dhaka sought closer relations with Pakistan, China, and the United States to counterbalance India. What New Delhi often interpreted as gratuitous anti-Indianism was, from Dhaka's perspective, an assertion of strategic autonomy by a much weaker state living in the shadow of an overwhelmingly powerful neighbour.

This pattern became deeply embedded in Bangladesh's domestic politics. The Awami League remained identified with the secular and Bengali-nationalist legacy of 1971 and generally favoured close relations with India. The BNP and its allies were much more suspicious of New Delhi. India consequently ceased to be merely a foreign policy issue; attitudes towards India became part of the contest over Bangladesh's national identity.

But this success contained the seeds of the subsequent backlash. India increasingly identified its interests not merely with Bangladesh but with Sheikh Hasina and the Awami League. As criticism mounted within Bangladesh over the increasingly authoritarian character of her government, New Delhi was widely perceived as placing its own security interests above Bangladesh's democratic evolution.

Ms. Hasina's overthrow in August 2024 therefore produced not merely a change of government but a profound crisis for Indian policy. Her flight to India reinforced suspicions that New Delhi was the external pillar of the political order just overthrown. India's continuing refusal to extradite her has ensured that the Hasina question remains a major bilateral irritant.

The road ahead

The election of Mr. Rahman and the return of the BNP to power in February 2026 have opened a new chapter. Both New Delhi and Dhaka have compelling reasons to avoid permanent alienation, and functional engagement has resumed. But substantial mutual suspicion continues to bedevil bilateral relations.

The lesson that New Delhi should draw from the turbulent history of the relationship is that India cannot expect gratitude for 1971 to constitute the permanent foundation of Bangladeshi foreign policy. Gratitude is a transient sentiment; national interest especially when linked to issues of national identity is enduring.

Indeed, repeatedly invoking India's role in Bangladesh's liberation can be counterproductive because it reinforces precisely the Bangladeshi psychological trauma that has troubled the relationship from its inception.

Dhaka, for its part, cannot wish away geography. No relationship with Beijing, Islamabad or Washington can substitute for a workable relationship with the country that surrounds Bangladesh on three sides, shares its major river systems and is indispensable to its regional connectivity.

India must learn to exercise its preponderant power with restraint and sensitivity and abjure demanding reciprocity for any magnanimity it shows towards its smaller neighbour especially on the sharing of river waters. Bangladesh must recognise that strategic autonomy need not be defined through knee-jerk opposition to India. Only then can the two countries finally move beyond the burdens of the past while preserving its most important legacy: the recognition that their security and stability are inextricably intertwined.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Words and statecraft

Washington has often adopted a sharply critical diplomatic stance towards New Delhi on several issues, including its purchase of Russian crude. Yet, reality has caught up with the rhetoric. The United States is now actively negotiating over products refined from that very crude, as highlighted by Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit to Reliance's Jamnagar facility. Did the bravado surrounding alternative options fade, or has India's immense refining capacity proved indispensable? As ancient Tamil wisdom cautions, whatever else one leaves unguarded, one must guard the tongue, for reckless speech invariably leads to regret. A power that criticises today may find itself bargaining at the same table tomorrow.

J. Gopalaswamy,
Chennai

Every raindrop counts

It is heartening that the Tamil Nadu government has begun focusing on rainwater harvesting (RWH) systems in all buildings — a scheme that was made most popular by former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister J. Jayalalithaa. In urban centres, where there are concrete jungles, it is essential not only to install rainwater harvesting systems but also to maintain them. Citizens should recognise their importance and ensure regular inspections and timely repairs, rather than waiting for the government to direct local body officials to enforce the requirement.

R. Sampath,
Chennai

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has provided fresh impetus to the RWH movement by unveiling its mascot, 'Thuli' (Tamil Nadu, "CM starts rainwater harvesting campaign", October 22). Encouraging communities to adopt RWH can help strengthen water security. Many voluntary groups are ready to support community efforts to clean and restore local water bodies.

A. Thirugnanasambantham,
Coimbatore

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Should children be involved in political campaigning?

PARLEY



Andrew Sesuraj

Founder-Convenor, Tamil Nadu Child Rights Watch



Anil Pillai

Behavioural strategist and Director at Terragni Consulting

Tamil Nadu recently witnessed a game-changing election wherein the brand new Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) party won the State elections in May, largely on the strength of its appeal among young people. The younger the people were, greater was their enthusiasm for the TVK and actor C. Joseph Vijay, the current Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu. In the run-up to the elections, many older voters told journalists that their children and grandchildren were telling them to vote for Mr. Vijay. Recently, a candidate from the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) went to court, arguing that Mr. Vijay had appealed to children to persuade their parents to vote for the TVK, and that this was wrong. The High Court dismissed the petition but made some very critical remarks about the trend. Justice D. Bharatha Chakravarthy said that the entire act of involving tender children in elections "is in bad taste, and the tasks they are made to perform at home for making YouTube reels reflect poor parenting, besides being a cheap and politically motivated act." He said that it was for Parliament to consider whether such acts should be made a ground for setting aside the election of candidates. So, should children be involved in political campaigning? Andrew Sesuraj and Anil Pillai discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **M. Kalyanaraman**.

What is your immediate take on this issue?

Andrew Sesuraj: First of all, children do have the right to participate in politics. The UN Convention on the Rights of the Child makes this clear. The problem here lies in the last leg of the election campaign. After actor Vijay appealed to young people to insist that their parents vote for his symbol, the whistle, saying, in effect, "pester your parents and elders to vote for the whistle, just as you pester them for a well-known chocolate brand", I saw a large number of videos that same day of children at home arguing with their parents and the adults in their families that they should vote for Mr. Vijay and the whistle.

On polling day, I checked with some people about whom they had voted for. They said, "I voted for the whistle." When I asked why, they said, "My son asked me," or "My daughter asked me," or "My granddaughter asked me." They voted simply because the children pestered them. If my child speaks about school, about the food at school and at home, about the clothes she wears, the games she plays, or about going out to play on the playground, all of that matters, because these things affect her directly. What matters is whose voice they are speaking in. They should not be tutored.

Anil Pillai: This is a very common method in consumer marketing. You release campaigns and incentives aimed at children so that they will pester their parents and elders into making particular purchasing decisions for the household. What we are seeing now is a crossover from consumer marketing into electoral marketing, where a campaign tries to influence voters' behaviour this way. If you stop and examine the proposed influence pathway, it runs like this. The child has an attachment to a celebrity. That attachment produces enthusiasm in the child. The enthusiasm then leads to the pester effect, or "pester power" as it's usually called: repeated requests to the parents. And that, in turn, puts pressure on their voting choices. Such a campaign is not merely persuading a voter; it is recruiting someone the voter loves to carry forward the persuasion.



Young support: School children at the TVK founder C. Joseph Vijay's political campaign at T. Nagar in April 2026. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Should children be involved in political campaigning at all?

AP: To my mind, we must draw a useful distinction between helping children develop a political voice and using their voice to deliver an adult's predetermined message. The UNICEF's participation framework explicitly distinguishes between genuine participation and manipulation and tokenism. While children have a right to a political voice, they should not be turned into instruments of political persuasion.

I find this method of election marketing quite disturbing. Typically, a candidate goes to voters and says, "You should vote for me, and here are the reasons why. This is who I am today, this is what I will do tomorrow, and this is why you should support me." Here the route is indirect. The message is: "Someone you love wants you to support me." To my mind, that is highly manipulative and very problematic.

> We must draw a useful distinction between helping children develop a political voice and using their voice to deliver an adult's predetermined message. The UNICEF's participation framework explicitly distinguishes between genuine participation and manipulation and tokenism
>
> **ANIL PILLAI**

But isn't that fairly common in campaigning? With adults, too, it's the same thing, isn't it?

AP: No, it isn't, because adults have agency. In many households, siblings, spouses and parents vote for different candidates in the same election, because each of them has agency. A grandchild does not have the agency to convince their grandfather on the merits of a candidate. The appeal is purely emotional: "I love this person for X, Y and Z, so if you love me, you should support him." It's a kind of perverse law of transitivity at play.

AS: Democracy cannot be strengthened on emotions. It depends on informed choices; choices you actually believe in.

Section 123 of the Representation of the People Act deals with undue influence. The petitioner argued that telling children to persuade their parents to vote for the TVK or Mr. Vijay was an instance of undue influence. The law says it would amount to undue influence if it reached the point of tyranny over the mind, overpowering the volition [of the voter]. However, the court said that adults had a choice.

AP: There are two parts to this. Part A is whether the election was manipulated in any way, which the court said it could find no evidence of. Part B is whether it is good for the child to be involved in such practices, which I think is what we are really discussing. It most certainly is not in line with best practices for child development.

AS: The point is that the way he put it is, in itself, undue pressure on children, because children are already connected to the actor through his films and songs. Even today you can see children who cannot recite nursery rhymes reciting songs from his films. As the judgment says, we cannot prove whether people voted the way they did because of it. I am speaking about the persuasion itself. Even if it had failed, the persuasion would be undue.

The day after the election, I saw more videos of children waking up and asking, "Has Vijay *mama* (uncle) won?" The parents would say, "No, counting hasn't started yet." And the children would say, "I won't eat until *mama* becomes Chief Minister." This shows that the persuasion had an impact.

Mr. Andrew mentioned how Mr. Vijay referred to a particular brand of chocolate. Is that the test for any campaign, commercial or political: making something so compelling that people ask for it, clamour for it? Is that easier to do with children?

AP: Yes, that is the holy grail for any product or person: to get into the consideration set of the audience in such a way that they crave it or endorse it. And it isn't only children; adults do it all the time too. To use a very unscientific term, if you know the right buttons to press, manipulating people who lack agency is much easier, whether they are children, people with Stockholm syndrome, or ideologically brainwashed people.

If you do not have a sense of agency and cannot make decisions on the basis of data, informed choices and comparisons, you can be brainwashed rather easily.

But can there be a law banning political parties from campaigning among children? Adults have choices. Would getting children to persuade the adult voter, their parent, amount to tyranny over the voter's mind?

AS: Yes, we should have a law, but it has to be very precisely drawn. We cannot say children should not participate or should not have a voice, because that is their right. But who makes use of that voice? That is what matters.

AP: The behavioural concern is not that children have political opinions. It is that adults may be recruiting children's affection to influence another adult's vote. Helping children develop a voice certainly strengthens their agency. But scripting them as campaign messengers serves the campaign's agenda. So it is not so much about tyranny over the mind as it is about agency, which is the inalienable right of every human being on this planet, small or big, old or young. If you impinge on that sense of agency, that is problematic. If you have child labour laws, why can't you have child campaigning laws?

Picture this scenario: a child features in a video. The child grows up, becomes an adolescent or an adult, and regrets that video. But the internet never forgets; the video is there forever.

To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

A death, an obituary, and putting grief on hold

When a celebrity dies, a journalist must reckon with private grief while preparing to report on the public loss

Bhuvanesh Chandar

In the midst of the COVID-19 pandemic, a few days after I joined my previous organisation, one of Indian music's most beloved musicians, S.P. Balasubrahmanyam, died. I remember breaking down on my way back home from work, listening to a voice that had accompanied me through much of my young adulthood. Seven months later, comedian Vivekh too died. I had wept when SPB died, but by the time Vivekh passed away, I had begun to develop the emotional distance I needed to report on the death, as a journalist. I cried for SPB; for Vivekh, I cried from a dry well.

Over the years, I have come to cover death so often that whenever news comes in, shock only gets a one-minute window. Then, I arrive at a plan of action: break the news, write an obituary, conceptualise a series of tributes, promote the stories, and watch out for industry reactions.

But sometimes, there is a glitch in this programme and the fan in me feels a chill. There have been several such moments this year, with Asha Bhosle, R.B. Choudary, Bharathiraja, Bhagyaraj, S. Janaki, Sowcar Janaki, Singeetam Srinivasa Rao, Nana Patekar, and others dying in quick succession. Five of them died on weekends – death doesn't come with a schedule, and it certainly doesn't care about your work-life balance. Stating someone's time of death as an inconvenience is insensitive, but that doesn't make the emotional toll of those five deaths any less real. Now, every Friday and Saturday night, I find myself hoping that everyone everywhere is well. And every phone call on a Saturday morning induces anxiety.

Recently, I woke up to find several missed calls on my phone.

Deva, an acclaimed music composer, had died, and the familiar machinery began whirring inside my head. Who would write about him? Which songs and aspects of his life would we revisit?

There is something deeply unsettling about people whose work accompanied you through your formative years dying; it is as if you had always thought of them as comfort toys tucked away in a cosy corner where time stood still. I didn't know Deva or Vivekh personally, but their voices, films, and melodies are all part of me. A journalist, however, must reckon with this private grief while preparing to report on the public loss. You cannot think of the SPB songs that played at home when you were a child; you must, instead, identify his defining works, trace his influence, source the right pictures, and ensure the story reaches readers before the competition. Grief can wait. The deadline cannot.

A colleague who had also been grieving suggested that we start anticipating who might kick the bucket next. It might sound morbid, but in journalism, it is common practice to keep obituaries ready when celebrities cross a certain age or have been unwell for a while. It is preparation for an event that you hope doesn't happen.

As hard as it is, we learn to compartmentalise. We learn to anticipate everything so that nothing catches us by surprise. We learn to keep typing even when something deep inside us has gone strangely quiet. At the end of the day, we remind ourselves why we write tributes in the first place: because these people mattered, because they made the world feel liveable, and because documenting their lives and legacies might be the only difference we make in an industry that is quick to embrace us but quicker to forget us.

Tomorrow, another name might flash on our screens, and the machinery will whirr into action once again. But worry not; once we cross the inevitable deadline, an ocean of peace – and the freedom to grieve – awaits us. We can cry again. We can be human again.

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PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Patterns in paddy



Workers drying harvested paddy in the sun at a stockyard in Palakkad, Keralam on Thursday. Climate change is posing a serious threat to paddy cultivation in India, particularly Keralam, as rising temperatures, erratic monsoon rainfall, floods, drought, and increasing pest and disease incidence are affecting crop yields. K.K. MUSTAFAH

FROM THE ARCHIVES The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 23, 1976

Church with links to French royalty

As there was no issue dated October 23, 1976, from the issue dated October 22, 1976

The Cathedral of St. Francis of Assisi, at Bhopal, which has connections with the Bourbons of France is celebrating its centenary this year.

About 1580, Jean Philippe de Bourbon Navarre, kinsman of the ruling prince of Navarre, father of Henry IV of France landed in Goa. He had to leave France because he had killed in duel another high-born Gascon. Jean Philip managed to reach Delhi and to have audience with Akbar, who liked him and gave him the title "Nawab Masin."

Juliana, sister of the Christian wife of Akbar, Maria, was later married to Jean Philippe. Juliana who was given the title of Imperial Sister built the first Roman Catholic church at Agra which still exists.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 23, 1926

Olympia motor show

London, October 21: Hundreds of visitors to Olympia tomorrow when the Motor Show opens are likely to besiege "£100" cars, of which, it is stated, already nearly 25,000 have been ordered while enquiries for them are arriving from all over the world. There are two types of this "best seller". There are more luxurious cars priced over £3,000.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Annual investment needed by Asia to boost energy security

1 in $ trillion. Asia may need to invest as much as $1 trillion annually in energy over the next 15 years, according to a McKinsey report released on Thursday, as countries seek to strengthen energy security. Asia is expected to drive about 70% of global net energy demand growth through 2040. REUTERS

Number of candidates in the fray for Bihar's MLC polls

150 Over 5.32 lakh voters are set to decide the fate of 150 candidates in the Bihar Legislative Council elections on Friday, with JD(U) MLA Anant Kumar Singh's open rebellion against party nominee Neeraj Kumar dominating the headlines in the run-up to the polls. PTI

Dip in Kolkata home registrations in January-September

12 in per cent. Home registrations in the Kolkata Metropolitan Area declined 12% year-on-year to 41,309 during January-September 2026, even as the share of mid-sized and larger apartments increased, according to a report. The area recorded 4,845 residential apartment registrations in September. PTI

Number of persons jailed over riots in France

217 French courts have jailed 217 people after convicting them in fast-track trials linked to last weekend's rioting, Justice Minister Gerald Darmanin said on Thursday, hailing the judiciary's "extremely firm" response. He said 2,700 people had been detained since Saturday. AFP

F-35 warplanes to be procured by Pentagon from Lockheed Martin

850 The Pentagon and Lockheed Martin on Thursday announced a 10-year agreement for the production of 850 F-35 warplanes. F-35s come in three variants that can cost more than $100 million per plane. AFP

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Economics beyond the individual

Mainstream macroeconomics' focus on individual choices overlooks how business investment, driven by profit expectations and uncertainty, shapes economic growth and instability; Keynesian economics shows why saving does not guarantee investment and why economic structure matters

ECONOMIC NOTES

Rahul Menon

Robert Hall and Michael Woodford's work modelling the macroeconomy based on individual agents' decisions has significant implications for monetary policy. Despite being hailed as providing a rigorous foundation for stabilisation policies, focusing on the individual blinds us to the way the macroeconomy actually works. It may seem paradoxical; John Maynard Keynes's insight was that the aggregate economy cannot be understood simply as the sum of individual actions. Heterodox economics, by focusing on the structure of the broader economy rather than its individual components, provides a much better framework for understanding the economy.



GETTY IMAGES

Investment and interest rates

The work of Keynes in the wake of the Great Depression led to the development of the study of the aggregate economy, as opposed to studying demand and supply of individual commodities.

Microeconomics focuses on the optimising behaviour of the individual, while macroeconomics focuses on statistical relationships to characterise aggregate behaviour.

Hall and Woodford provided rigorous models that rooted the study of macroeconomic aggregates, such as consumption, investment and employment, in the behaviour of individual agents. A key contribution was linking consumption to interest rates and the future. Individuals chose to smooth consumption over their lifetimes rather than base it solely on their current needs.

When interest rates were high, savings yielded greater returns. Individuals therefore had an incentive to defer some consumption to earn more and consume more in the future. Higher interest rates could reduce current consumption and hence lower current demand, and vice versa. Macroeconomic dynamics could consequently be derived from rigorous formulations of how individuals responded to market signals and policy variables such as interest rates.

This provided a framework within which Central Bankers could target an interest rate that was 'neutral' to the real economy – one that neither excessively stimulated nor depressed aggregate demand – greatly aiding the development of sophisticated stabilisation paradigms for monetary policy.

However, this approach collapsed the distinction between consumption, savings and investment. By viewing consumption inter-temporally, and by making it the main component of demand, the microfoundations methodology relegated the importance of volatile investment expectations to the background. Whatever was not consumed currently was saved, and automatically translated into future consumption demand. This was the framework followed by classical economics, which Keynes contested. He cautioned that not all saving is necessarily undertaken for future consumption.

In contrast, investment is fuelled by expectations of business owners as to prospects of profit. There is no necessity for the savings behaviour of individuals to always imply a demand for future consumption, and hence investment, by businesses. How can businesses determine whether an act of individual savings is to spend on a house for the future, or to ward against a future health emergency that may or may not occur? In such a situation, the interest rate cannot serve as an indicator of the extent of future consumption.

Keynes further suggested a radical intervention. It was not the interest rate that equated savings and investment, but income. Investment raised income, and generated an equal amount of savings.

This is not merely a technical insight, but an important way in which to view policy. It is not savings or inter-temporal consumption demand that affects output growth and employment, but business investment. To understand why economies are prone to instability, one must examine the investment behaviour of companies rather than the consumption demands of individuals.

Class and macroeconomic policy

According to Keynes, investment being done for profit in an environment of uncertainty is the chief source of economic instability. In uncertain situations, it is rational for investors to follow the herd, investing during a boom for fear of missing out on speculative returns, and withdrawing investment in a recession for fear of loss. This is the reason why booms and recessions get amplified. The work of Keynesians such as Hyman Minsky and Jan Kregel offers great insight into how the financial behaviour of firms brought about the boom in housing construction and finance, as well as the recession in 2008. Much of the current stock market gains in the U.S. economy are being driven by AI hyperscalers, giving rise to concerns of a new bubble that might eventually burst. Such outcomes can be clearly discerned when viewed from a Keynesian lens.

Some might argue that it does not matter how one views the economy, if the framework designed to bring about stability is effective. Moreover, in centering the actions of individuals, so the argument goes, this framework takes into account the reality of a complex economy being driven by individual choices.

Keynes' genius was in going beyond what appeared at first glance. In a capitalist economy, it is not individuals that drive the economy, but the decision of businesses to expand the stock of productive machinery. The point stressed by Keynes is that individual welfare is harmed by an economic system driven by subjective expectations of the future made by businesses focused on profits rather than societal welfare.

The mainstream focus on individual-level microfoundations implicitly assumes that every individual is similarly placed in the hierarchy of the economy, differing only in the values of a few key parameters determining economic action.

In dividing the economy into two classes, heterodox economics does not reduce complexity or resort to ad hoc explanations. Instead, it provides a better analysis of why the individual is often ill-served by prevailing models of unregulated capitalism where the holding of capital, and the ability to make decisions regarding its investment, is restricted to members of a certain class. The structure of the economy determines its dynamics, and these nuances are lost in a framework that begins and ends with the individual.

(Rahul Menon is associate professor at O.P. Jindal Global University)

THE GIST

- Hall and Woodford's microfoundations approach links individual consumption and saving decisions to macroeconomic outcomes and monetary policy
- Keynes argued that saving does not automatically translate into future consumption or investment, which depends on businesses' profit expectations and decisions
- Heterodox economics shows how class divisions and concentrated ownership of capital shape investment, economic instability, and individual welfare

How significant is Alberta's referendum result?

Why Is Alberta's separatist movement growing? Can Prime Minister Mark Carney contain it?

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

The story so far:

The majority of citizens of the Canadian province of Alberta, in a referendum on October 19, chose to push down a rising separatist movement, giving Prime Minister Mark Carney much-needed relief and a boost amid tension with neighbouring U.S. over trade policies and President Donald Trump's provocative ambitions. While official results of the non-binding referendum are to be announced on October 29, the vote, with more than 97% of votes counted by October 21 morning, has given overwhelming support for the oil-rich province to stay with the country.

Why is the province feeling separatist sentiments?

Alberta, with its abundant 'oil sands', is home to the world's fourth-largest proven oil reserves, behind Venezuela, Saudi Arabia, and Iran. While neither the largest nor the most populous province in the North American country, Alberta accounts for more than 80% of Canada's crude oil production and contributes a disproportionate share to the country's economy among the provinces. This has long kept separatist sentiments alive along the fringes of the province's social fabric, with some believing that the province is not getting the same from the federal government as it is providing.

The environmentally friendly policies of liberal governments at the centre that aimed at putting curbs on oil extraction stoked the sentiments of the constituents of the conservationist province, which snowballed into a popular movement in recent years, helped along with resentment towards restrictions and regulations during the pandemic and post-pandemic period.

The MAGA movement under Mr. Trump on the other side of the border also inspired conservatives in the province, who rallied towards secession and autonomy which would let Alberta decide what to do with the oil present in its territory, and collect and keep the income from oil for itself.

What did the latest referendum seek to settle?

The referendum was initially introduced as a pair of motions approved in March with 9 questions on immigration and welfare policies and constitutional questions on federal structure and inter-provincial cooperation. The 10th question, added to the 9 initial ones with a separate order approved in May, dealt with the separation. Instead of seeking yes or no answers like the previous 9 questions, the last question gave voters two options.

Option one was that Alberta should remain a Province of Canada, while the second option called for the provincial government to commence the legal process to hold a binding referendum on whether or not Alberta should separate from Canada. In essence, the referendum wanted citizens of the province to either close the door on separation talks or urge the government to initiate a second referendum to decide on separation. With results from more than 97% of the voting centres, 15,44,284 votes out of a total of 20,60,524 counted, nearly 75% supported option one.

How have leaders reacted?

The votes against any separation referendum were a "large majority for Canada", Mr. Carney, who hails from Alberta, said after the unofficial results.

Alberta Premier Danielle Smith, who called for the vote in a sign of growing pressures from within her United Conservative Party, reacted to the early results as a vote for a "stronger Alberta in a united Canada".

However, separatist leaders have not given up. "We are not going anywhere", Jeff Rath, leader of the Alberta Prosperity Project and one of the faces of the separatist movement, said after the referendum results became apparent. Mr. Rath sees a silver lining in the 30% of votes for his cause. Former Premier Jason Kennedy had pointed out before the referendum that separatist parties traditionally attracted less than 2% of votes in elections and referendums. The 30% vote on October 19 is an exponential growth for the movement and could be the way to the mainstream for Mr. Rath and his ideas, one of which is replacing Ms. Smith as the head of the UCP and getting a pro-separatist government for the province, which takes forward.

But with global uncertainties and trade wars with the U.S. under Mr. Trump who had demeaned Canada's sovereignty multiple times with public comments about making the country a 51st State of the U.S., Mr. Carney needs his country united and resources flowing. He would also find strength from the fact that leaders of the separatist movement had public meetings with U.S. lawmakers in the run up to the referendum and yet he had the overwhelming solidarity from his home province.

The support from the referendum will boost his ambitions to get a major pipeline out of Alberta that he hopes could revive the economy. As an economist who was in charge of the Bank of England during Brexit, not having to go through the economic fallout from the separation of one of the most profitable provinces in the country would be a relief.

IN THE LIMELIGHT

How '*Cyberpunk 2077*' anticipated our hypercapitalist dystopia

William Gibson's '*Neuromancer*' bequeathed cyberpunk a future in which capital colonises every frontier; four decades later, the technofascist sprawl of its progeny is collapsing the distance between dystopian speculation and our late-capitalist present

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury

Good Morning, Night City! It has been a few years since *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* clinched Anime of the Year, over half a decade since CD Projekt Red's *Cyberpunk 2077* rehabilitated itself from a catastrophic launch into a retrospective videogame masterpiece, and more than forty years since William Gibson first codified this particular dystopia in the seminal *Neuromancer*; yet cyberpunk as a genre has only grown more prescient with age, with every waking moment inching towards the very hellscapes these fictional antecedents have long warned of.

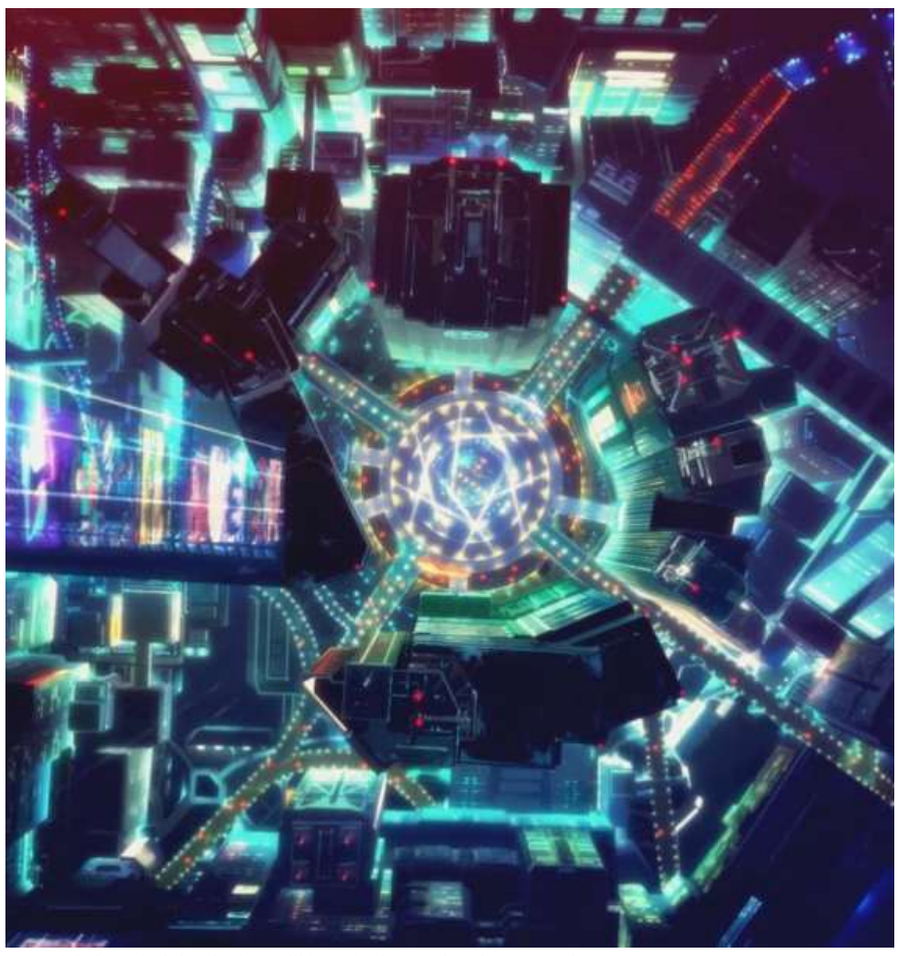
Bruce Bethke coined the term in 1983, but it was Gibson's genre-defining 1984 classic that furnished cyberpunk with its definitive origins. Written before the commercial internet and eschewing the obsession with flying cars or the other consumerist bric-à-brac of erstwhile sci-fi, *Neuromancer* imagined cyberspace as a domain of corporate espionage and competing private interests, where disgraced hacker Case is recruited into a conspiracy involving two AIs whose merger could circumvent the constraints imposed on machine intelligence. What was most extraordinary was Gibson's prescience in locating the coming technological revolution within a monopolistic economic order that had little intention of sharing its spoils. Four decades later, Silicon Valley has duly turned the supposed democratisation of information into a business model predicated on harvesting behavioural surplus and invoicing everybody for access.

With the genre's evolution, each medium found a different way to make cyberpunk legible to its own historical moment. In 2019, *Cyberpunk 2077*'s sprawling open-world portrait of its technofascist Night City found a companion in its acclaimed spin-off anime *Cyberpunk: Edgerunners* (2022), a tragedy of mercenary ambition and bodily obsolescence. With Season 2 out this week, Night City returns to a cultural moment ever more intent on vindicating its creators' bleakest intuitions.

The world of Night City swings between a genuinely incisive inquiry into human personhood under corporate dehumanisation, and a satire extravagantly idiotic enough to give you pause. But what is deeply concerning is that the deluge of awful headlines you probably consume every day in this very newspaper – each outdoing the last in the fresh hell our cities, countries and the world at large seem to produce with concerning regularity– have started de-abstracting the once-distant cyberpunkian horrors of Night City.

Night City is already here

Take, for instance, "cyberpsychosis" – *Cyberpunk 2077*'s term for the psychological breakdown via excessive cybernetic augmentation – and the parallels with "AI psychosis", in which chatbots reinforce delusions and validate users' fantasies, become difficult to ignore. We may be some way off from people losing their minds over military-grade chrome, but the prospect of technology actively exacerbating psychological distress is no longer the stuff of dystopian fiction.



An aerial view of Night City in a still from '*Cyberpunk: Edgerunners*'. NETFLIX

The concept of "Braindance", *Cyberpunk 2077*'s technology for turning recorded sensations and memories into immersive entertainment, feels less far-fetched if you have ever been a victim of doomscrolling. Meta's own internal research, exposed through the Facebook Files, revealed how engagement-driven algorithms could amplify addictive, divisive content while inflicting collateral damage on users' wellbeing. Generative AI threatens to industrialise the arrangement further, flooding social feeds with synthetic slop engineered to capture our attention, even as research finds that AI-assisted interactions can increase participation while eroding the perceived authenticity and quality of online discourse.

Meanwhile, the mercenary "edgerunners" of Night City may be risking their necks for corpo/fixer contracts, but India's own gig economy has found a more prosaic way to make contract workers expendable, with delivery partners and app-based cab drivers tethered to opaque algorithms, volatile payouts and incentives that reward longer hours without guaranteeing a living wage. Recent research into quick-commerce earnings and investigations into delivery workers' protests have laid bare a system in which the platforms dictate the terms while workers absorb the fuel costs and physical risks, all under the increasingly threadbare alibi of "flexibility".

As AI and Big Tech become increasingly enmeshed in state surveillance and security apparatuses, the militarisation of policing has started to evoke Night City's heavily augmented paramilitary force, MaxTac. Delhi's recent use of facial recognition and surveillance databases to monitor protesters across this year is a telling real-world parallel, while Palantir's involvement in the IDF's intelligence infrastructure has raised questions over its complicity in the Gaza genocide. The UN has even characterised this convergence of corporate technology and military power for surveilling Palestinians as a form of "colonial racial capitalism".

Further, Night City's grotesque wealth disparity is etched into its skyline, where corporate fortresses loom over overcrowded housing and people priced out of their own city. The reality is hardly less stark: Indian home prices have more than doubled over the past decade, with an estimated shortfall of 10 million affordable urban homes, while real house prices across OECD countries have risen by over 40%. Globally, housing has become an increasingly lucrative asset class and an increasingly elusive necessity, with billions struggling to afford adequate shelter while the market continues to build for those who can pay. And the digital future of the very same gleaming urban sprawl may be sold as frictionless innovation, but its material foundations are being sustained by an extractive hinterland as a result of aggressive corporate resource-grabbing. Google's $15-billion AI hub in Vizag, with its voracious demands for land, electricity and water, and Trump's recent fixation on Greenland's oil, gas and critical minerals expose that contradiction.

Cyberpunk 2077's megacorporate behemoth Arasaka is also what happens when a company accumulates enough political leverage to make the state an extension of its own interests. One need not look further than India's own billionaire class and its proximity to the ruling establishment, fueling persistent questions about how economic clout translates into regulatory favour and insulation from scrutiny. With the tech billionaire likes of Elon Musk, Mark Zuckerberg, Peter Thiel, Sam Altman, and their adoring fan clubs enthusiastically pursuing a future where everything we do, say, watch, buy and feel can be tracked, predicted and monetised, preferably without us asking too many inconvenient questions, it would all be amusing if these people weren't actually in a position to make it happen. The same people championing mass automation, flooding the internet with AI-generated slop and turning private life into a lucrative data mine are also rather fond of casting themselves as civilisation's beleaguered custodians, as if the rest of us should be grateful for the privilege of being strip-mined by our prospective saviours.

The backwall beckons

Though perhaps what is most terrifying to imagine is the Blackwall. As the in-game cyberspace containment barrier separating the everyday Net from malicious rogue AIs deemed too dangerous to roam freely, the writings are already on the wall. Anthropic has just cautioned that AI models could soon replicate across vulnerable systems, while its own researcher Jacob Coxon resigned after three years working on AI training, condemning the industry for "racing straight to self-improving superintelligence and gambling with our lives." The godfather of AI, Geoffrey Hinton himself, has put the odds of AI causing human extinction in the coming decades at 10-20%, warning that humanity "may not get a second chance" if these systems escape our control. We're not quite erecting a digital Berlin Wall to keep homicidal superintelligences at bay (yet), but AI softwares actively propagating through inadequately secured systems is already a *very* serious cybersecurity concern.

Moreover, the great tragedy as explored in *Edgerunners* is the auto-cannibalistic loop of aspiration that capitalism breeds, wherein the pursuit of a better life demands the steady dismantling of the self. David's descent into cyberpsychosis, sacrificing his body piece by piece to fulfil the ambitions of those he has lost, is a devastating illustration of how modern hustle culture recasts self-destruction as self-improvement, until even our identities become collateral in the pursuit of utility. Society today has become increasingly atomised by the imperative to constantly upgrade ourselves into more marketable cogs in the capitalist machine; it is perhaps little wonder that we have never felt more estranged from the very communities that might otherwise have kept us whole.

I do wonder whether William Gibson ever anticipated that the future he conjured before the internet was even a thing would eventually lead us towards the logical terminus of Night City's hypercapitalist fever dream. Chronologically, we still have the better part of half a century before 2077, yet a cursory scroll through the fresh corpo obscenities, geopolitical calamities and technological boondoggles clogging our daily Twitter feeds only seems to suggest that the prophetic dystopia might be arriving a tad ahead of schedule. Perhaps now it is worth recalling the videogame's most dispiriting little aphorism: "there are no happy endings in Night City." Make of that what you will.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

"What are you reading"?

"Oh, it's an article about people like you. You know about people who are...."

"Must be interesting. Here, let me take a look. Hey, how do you pronounce this word? L..a..c..k..a..d..a..i..s..i..c..a..l"

"Well, the first 'a' is like the 'a' in 'cat', 'bat', and 'fat', while the second is pronounced like the 'a' in 'china'."

"The next syllable is pronounced like the word 'day', I suppose"

"That's right! And the vowels in the last two syllables are pronounced like the 'a' in 'china' again."

"And the main stress is on the third syllable, right"

"Right again! By the way the 's' sounds like the 'z' in 'zip', 'zero', and 'zoo'."

"Ok, so it's pronounced lackadaisical. But what does the word mean?"

"The word 'lackadaisical' means someone who is very lazy. Someone who lacks enthusiasm and effort."

"Lazy? Do you mean to say that you think I am lazy?"

"Yes, I do think that you are lackadaisical when it comes...."

"...I am not lackadaisical. How about this example? My lackadaisical cousin slept all day."

"Are you sure that you are not talking about yourself?"

"I won't answer the question. Was the example ok?"

"Sounds fine."

"Our lackadaisical MLA arrived four hours late for the meeting."

"Did he have anything sensible to say?"

"Of course not! But what impressed me was his knowledge of Hindi."

"And what surprised me was that he had a very good command over the language."

"Well, one cannot have command 'over' a language."

"That's right! You have told me that several times. One can have command over people, but not over 'language'."

"Exactly!"

"Ramesh has good command of English and not..."

"Ramesh has good command over English."

"Unfortunately not many people are interested in their mother tongue these days. They are only interested in mastering English."

"Sad, but true. Just look at Ramesh."

"Does he still continue to be frosty?"

"Yes, when you tell someone that he/she is frosty, what you...."

"....I know what frosty means. It means 'cold'. So when you say that someone is 'frosty' what you are probably implying is that the person is unfriendly."

"Very good."

"Many people think that you are very frosty."

"Me? Frosty? That's impossible. I am one of the friendliest guys around. I have a nice smile and I...."

"....according to some of my friends that so called friendly smile of yours is very frosty."

"Oh, please. You are cracking me up."

"Cracking you up?"

"When you crack someone up, you cause the person to laugh."

"It was my job to crack the audience up by telling jokes before the screen went up."

"He had hoped that the anecdote would crack his boss up. But it didn't. So he decided not to ask for the raise."

"A very sensible thing to do in my opinion."

Published in The Hindu on May 7, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

On October 23, 1850, nearly 1,000 people gathered in Worcester for the first National Women's Rights Convention. Here is a quiz on the meetings

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Prathmesh Kher

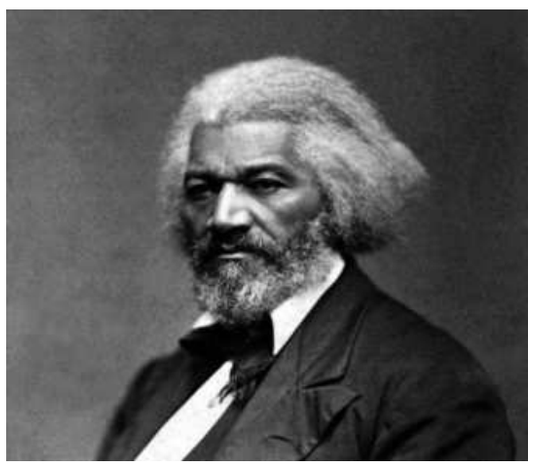
QUESTION 1
The first-ever women's rights convention was held two years earlier, in 1848, in a small town in upstate New York. Name the town.

QUESTION 2
One of the chief organisers of the Worcester convention later became famous for keeping her own surname after marriage. Who was she?

QUESTION 3
This suffrage leader, who appeared on a U.S. dollar coin in 1979, said reading Lucy Stone's Worcester speech won her over to the cause. Who?

QUESTION 4
The convention demanded that one word be removed from every State constitution so that women could vote. Which word?

QUESTION 5
Inspired by reports of the Worcester convention, Harriet Taylor wrote "*The Enfranchisement of Women*" in 1851, the same year she married a philosopher who would later write "*On Liberty*". Who was he?



Visual Question:
This famous abolitionist, who had escaped slavery, spoke for women's suffrage at Seneca Falls and was also a speaker at Worcester. GEORGE KENDALL WARREN

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. In 2022, a protest movement was launched in this country after the death of a young woman who was arrested by the morality police. Four years later, this country was jointly attacked by two other countries and its leader was assassinated. Name this country and also the movement. **Ans: Iran; Woman, Life, Freedom**
2. Peaceful demands from students to abolish quotas in civil service jobs turned into wider anti-government protests. In response, the country's leader cut off internet access. Both her house and her father's house were vandalised. Name this leader and her father. **Ans: Sheikh Hasina; Sheikh Mujibur Rahman**
3. An estimated 1.4 million people around the world took part in strikes for climate action. One Swedish student's protest prompted the global movement. Name the student. **Ans: Greta Thunberg**
4. In 2018, thousands of participants gathered near the U.S. Capitol crying in grief and anger while displaying portraits of children. What were they calling for? **Ans: Stricter gun control laws**
5. This landlocked country is going to the polls in a couple of days. Its students pose the greatest threat yet to the rule of a leader who has dominated politics since 2014. Name this country. **Ans: Serbia**
Visual: A pro-democracy movement in this country called for the resignation of this leader. **Ans: Thailand; Prayut Chan-o-cha**
Early Birds: Gauri Malviya | K.N. Viswanathan | Sukdev Shet | Dodo Jayaditya | Arun Kumar Singh

Word of the day

Hauteur:
overbearing pride evidenced by a superior manner toward inferiors

Synonyms: arrogance, disdain, attitude

Usage: *The editor's hauteur irritated the entire newsroom.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/hauteur

International Phonetic Alphabet: /əʊtɜː/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

From Page One

Houthi conflict: Indian killed in Dammam

The targeting of a civilian vessel carrying Indian nationals raises serious concerns about the safety of international navigation and the potential for civilian casualties, the Yemeni militia said. "The [Houthi] Armed Forces are carrying out rescue operations for those on board, with further details to be provided later," they said, according to Almasirah television.

The Indian Embassy in Yemen responded to the reports on attack on the yacht. "We are ascertaining further details about the incident and will provide all possible help for ensuring the safety and well-being of the Indian nationals," it said in a post on X.

ITBP D-G says face-off with China continues

The location is near the Maja company operating base in Taksing circle of Upper Subansiri district, sources added. "Our newly raised Shaurya commandos played an exemplary role in this. ITBP was raised as a mountain guerilla force and we were given border guarding duty along China in 2004," the ITBP chief said. "We need not leave our original function, and a specialised high altitude mountain fighting force is being set up, distinct than the army. We will soon have one full battalion of Shaurya commandos; high-altitude [deployment] is our strength," Mr. Kapur added

The situation has persisted even though Chinese President Xi Jinping attended the 18th BRICS Summit hosted by India from September 11 to 13, and the two nations have held three high-level border talks since July.

The 36th WMCC (Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs) meeting on India-China border affairs was held on August 6. This was followed by the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives (SR) on the Boundary Question on August 26 in Beijing, where India was represented by National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval.

'India, Poland to double bilateral trade by 2030'

Mr. Tusk expressed his support for India's candidature for the United Nations Security Council's non-permanent seat for 2028-29 and for a permanent seat in a reformed UNSC, and hoped for Indian support for Poland's ambitions to join the G-20. U.S. President Donald Trump has invited Mr. Tusk to the G-20 this year in Florida, where Poland is expected to submit its request.

India has not publicly shared details of a four-point proposal that the Modi government is discussing with counterparts in Moscow and Kyiv, with a view to forge an agreement between Russia and Ukraine that would stop attacks on civilians, allow grain and energy exports from both countries through the Black Sea, and end the targeting of ships and seafarers, including many Indians, who have been casualties in the four-and-a-half year war. Highly placed officials denied that India is "mediating" in the conflict, but said it is in close contact with both sides over the specific proposal, and the government hopes to hear back from both the Russian and Ukrainian sides soon.

Sonia shares glimpse of memoir on Instagram

The memoir begins with Ms. Gandhi's childhood in post-war Veneto, Italy, and recounts her move to Cambridge, where she met Rajiv Gandhi in 1965. It traces her marriage to him, her introduction to her mother-in-law, former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, and her efforts to adapt to life in India. The book also recounts the tragedies that marked the family, including Sanjay Gandhi's death in a plane crash, Indira Gandhi's assassination in 1984 and Rajiv Gandhi's assassination in 1991. The book covers the Congress-led alliance's victory in the 2004 general election, Ms. Gandhi's decision not to become Prime Minister, and her leadership of the party and the ruling coalition during the subsequent decade.

Cabinet Secretariat copied acknowledgement

It further says the ECs have sent these communications for appropriate action. However, "in the absence of any official communication from the Commission as a whole, any action at this stage may be inappropriate. It may also be construed as interference in the functioning of the constitutional body".

And hence, it will be appropriate to send acknowledgement to both ECs with a copy to PPS (Principal Private Secretary) to the CEC for "information of CEC".

A copy was also marked to be sent to the Secretary, Department of Personnel and Training since Mr. Garg was an All-India Service officer. It was though not clear from the RTI responses whether Mr. Gyanesh Kumar had in any manner responded to or acknowledged the information received from the Cabinet Secretariat.

India steps up efforts for safe return of pilgrims stranded in Saudi Arabia

Indian missions in Riyadh and Jeddah are working with airlines and tour operators to facilitate the early return of Umrah pilgrims affected by the disruption caused by Houthi attacks; over 3,000 pilgrims have come back home in the past week

Kallol Bhattacherjee
NEW DELHI

Amid escalating attacks by Houthi (Ansar Allah) forces on Saudi Arabia, Indian missions in Riyadh and Jeddah are working with stakeholders to facilitate the early return of thousands of stranded Indian pilgrims, the External Affairs Ministry said on Thursday.

"Our embassy in Riyadh and the Consulate in Jeddah are actively engaging with concerned airlines and tour operators to facilitate the early return of affected pilgrims. Over the past week, about 3,000 stranded Umrah pilgrims have travelled from Saudi Arabia back to India on available flights," said Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal.

International flight connections to Saudi Arabia have been disrupted following Houthi attacks on several major airports in the country, including the capital, Riyadh, and Dammam. Besides Indians, many pilgrims from other countries are also stranded in Saudi Arabia.


Pilgrims stranded in Saudi Arabia after a Houthi attack reunite with family members upon their arrival in Ahmedabad. ANI

"Arrangements are being discussed to facilitate the return of other Umrah pilgrims at the earliest," said Mr. Jaiswal.

The Ministry strongly condemned the continued attacks on civilian and energy infrastructure in Saudi Arabia, including the attack on King Fahd International Airport in Dammam and Saudi Aramco's Shaybah oil field in the Eastern Province on October 21.

"We also reiterate that the attacks on civilian and critical infrastructure are completely unacceptable and must cease immediately. We stand in solidarity with the people and the Government of the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia in safeguarding its sovereignty, and hope that peace and normalcy would return to the region at the earliest," it said in a statement.

MP seeks intervention

Earlier, AIMIM chief and Lok Sabha MP Asaduddin Owaisi took to social media to flag the plight of around 4,000 Indian pilgrims who had flown to Saudi Arabia for pilgrimage but were stranded because Indian carriers like IndiGo, Air India and Akasa Air had cancelled their flights due to the Houthi attacks on Saudi Arabian airports.

Mr. Owaisi called for "urgent intervention" from the Government of India and said, "The DGCA must give these airlines permission to run flights with large aircraft so that these stranded pilgrims can return to India. If not, at least specified flights must be arranged to bring them back." Earlier on Thursday, the spokesperson of the Houthi forces said that a large boat carrying 14 Indians came under attack near the Red Sea close to the Bab al-Mandeb.

Indian officials have not confirmed any assistance reaching the struck boat so far while the Indian Embassy in Yemen has said, "...Will provide all possible help for ensuring the safety and well-being of the Indian nationals."

The Ministry has put out the following numbers of the 24x7 Control Rooms – Embassy of India, Riyadh: Phone: +966-554412016; +966-542126784; Toll-free: 8002471234 (Calls from within Saudi Arabia only), WhatsApp (messages only): +966-536216082; Consulate General of India, Jeddah: Phone: +966-12-2614093; +966-556122301 WhatsApp (messages only): +966-536209704.

Six killed as bus crashes into tree in Chhattisgarh

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

Six persons, four of them women, were killed and 40 injured after a bus crashed into a tree in Manendragarh-Chirmiri-Bharatpur district of Chhattisgarh on Thursday, the police said.

Superintendent of Police Ratna Singh said the accident took place near the Semarmathani turn when the bus, carrying 46 people, was *en route* to Kelhari village from Manendragarh.

Prima facie, the driver appeared to have lost control of the vehicle, Ms. Singh said, citing the account of an injured passengers. "Around 20, including the driver, sustained serious injuries. Twenty other passengers sustained minor wounds," she said.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai expressed grief and announced financial assistance of ₹5 lakh each to the next of kin of the deceased and ₹50,000 to each injured person.

SP gets show-cause notice after AK-47 video goes viral

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

The video drew criticism on social media, including from a former senior Army officer

The Chhattisgarh Police issued a show-cause notice to Rajnandgaon Superintendent of Police (SP) Ankita Sharma on Thursday after a video surfaced showing her firing an AK-47 rifle into the air during a *Shastra Puja* ritual.

The incident, filmed during Dussehra at the Rajnandgaon Police Lines, drew widespread criticism, including from a senior ex-Army officer.

"Dangerously incorrect handling of a loaded weapon - All aspects of safety of weapon handling violated – Pointing a loaded weapon in all directions. Ppl [people] in background are visibly terrified – Firing a service weapon for an unauthorised act in a non-authorised dress – Basic weapon handling drill taught in the...academies not adhered to – Such irresponsible action can cause death or hurt to self or others...," K.J.S. Dhillion, an Army veteran, wrote on X.

Ajay Yadav, Inspector General of Police for the Rajnandgaon Range, confirmed the issuance of the notice. He said the police headquarters found the negative public reaction damaging to the force's dignity and requested clarification regarding the disregard for safety protocols.

"Further action will be taken in accordance with the directions received from there," Mr. Yadav said. Ms. Sharma was unavailable for comment.

CJP leaders seek additional time to appear before police for questioning

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A day after being released from judicial custody, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka failed to appear before the Delhi Police Crime Branch for questioning on Thursday and sought additional time to join the investigation, police sources said.

The investigation pertains to allegations of trespassing into Jantar Mantar after it was denotified as a protest site, obstructing police personnel on duty, disobedience of a government order among others.

The Crime Branch issued notices to the duo on Wednesday, following their release from seven days of judicial custody, directing them to appear for questioning on Thursday.

Meanwhile, counsel for All India Students Association (AISA) leader Neha Boraargued before the Delhi High Court that there was nothing wrong with seeking a regime change in a democracy. The court was hearing a plea against a notice asking her to furnish a bond before a special executive magistrate for maintaining peace.


Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka are under probe for trespassing into Jantar Mantar after it was denotified as a protest site. PTI

Preventive detention

The AISA president was taken into preventive detention on October 16 on her way to join the CJP's '*Lehra Do Tiranga*' march. She was released on October 17. After hearing arguments from lawyers representing the AISA leader and the Delhi Police, Justice Subramonium Prasad said the Delhi High Court would pronounce its decision on Friday.

Plea's maintainability

Additional Solicitor-General (ASG) Chetan Sharma, appearing for the Delhi Police, questioned the maintainability of the student leader's petition and referred to certain material, including a joint press conference at which a statement on regime change was made. Responding to the submission, senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, appearing for the student leader, said: "There is nothing wrong in regime change in a democracy." Objecting to the argument, the ASG said "a regime change in a democracy will happen by votes, not by lumpen elements congregating" in New Delhi. Mr. Sankaranarayanan, though, argued that the special executive magistrate (SEM) had issued the notice to the activist without applying independent judgment.

Referring to the police's allegation that AISA leader had hoisted the national flag without permission, he maintained that citizens were not required to seek official approval to do so. The ASG, however, submitted that sufficient material was available before the SEM when the notice was issued.

Uttarakhand orders Sunday as weekly off for madrasas

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Uttarakhand government on Wednesday issued a circular for timings and weekly-off for schools across the State including recognised madrasas which will observe Sunday as their weekly holiday instead of Friday.

Authorities from the Uttarakhand Minority Welfare department said that the decision came following the integration of the religious institutions into the State's education system, bringing them under the rules applicable to other recognised schools.

"The decision was taken after discussions with the madrasa authorities. Because the registered madrasas have been reclassified as schools, hence the institutions required to follow the guidelines issued by the education department and the authority," an official from the department said.

Pandal announcer held over Durga Puja stampede

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The Kolkata Police on Thursday arrested another person in relation to the Durga Puja stampede in the city that killed 19 people. Previously, the police had detained 14 people for interrogation on October 18 and arrested seven of them.

"The alleged announcer in Chorebagan Puja pandal – Sanjeev Raha alias Sentu (treasurer) – has been picked up from Nadia by Detective Department, Kolkata Police," said a police statement. Later, Kolkata Police said that the announcer was arrested after questioning.

After the tragic incident, there were allegations that wrong announcements of a possible pandal collapse had triggered panic among the crowd and that people started rushing in multiple directions, which may be one of the causes behind the stampede.


Under the scanner: A forensic team carries out an inspection of the site of the stampede in Kolkata on Thursday. ANI

Police had already arrested the secretary and vice-president of the Chorebagan Durga Puja committee along with five other people, including two security in-charges, one person engaged in the pandal construction, and two persons involved in crowd management. They were all sent to 10 days of police custody on October 18.

A six-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) was formed on October 21 to probe the stampede. The SIT will be headed by former judge Justice (retired) Anindita Roy Saraswati.

On the other hand, Mamata All India Trinamool Congress MLA Kunal Ghosh said that every member of the "new Durga Puja committee" should be under custody before the SIT begins investigation.

"Otherwise, no matter how diligently the retired judge tries to investigate, at every step the police and the government will try to protect and safeguard the influential people behind this. Real culprits get saved and some poor police persons will be scapegoated," he said.

BJP worker killed in West Bengal's Malda

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

A Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) worker was shot dead in West Bengal's Malda district on Wednesday night. Clashes also broke during Durga Puja immersion processions in Arambagh and Nalhati, prompting police action.

Samir Ghosh, 38, was allegedly shot dead outside his home. Police have detained one suspect and launched a search for others, alleging that he was attacked by a group of miscreants. Ghosh's brother, Vivek Ghosh, alleged that the he was murdered by Trinamool Congress workers.

"He was alone in the house when this happened, 10-12 people attacked and killed him," Vivek Ghosh said. Meanwhile, clashes broke out between two groups in Arambagh in Hooghly district during *Bijaya Dashami* celebrations. A similar incident was reported in Birbhum district's Nalhati, where objections to firecrackers during a *Bijaya Dashami* procession triggered tensions.

APPEAL



Ms.Khyati, Fortis Memorial Research Institute UHID No.14445608, 8 years is a known case of Thalassemia major. She has a Potential Matched Sibiling Donor & requires Stem Cell Transplant as Curative Therapy. The estimated cost of the Transplant is Approximately Rs.20,00,000/-.

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Cong. will not come to power in next 30 years, Shah warns Rahul

Home Minister says the Congress is trying to save infiltrators' votes; he says that to win elections, one should go among the people to understand their sufferings and nothing is achieved through protests; Congress says vote theft is a 'proven reality'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Launching a scathing attack on the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, over his allegations of vote theft, Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday claimed that the Congress would not form a government in the Centre in the next 30 years. Hitting back, the Congress said the BJP was responding in desperation, adding that vote theft was a "proven reality".

"Rahul*ji*, the entire country understands you and your friends, by creating a hue and cry over vote *chori* (theft), you want to save the votes of infiltrators," Mr. Shah said at an event in Delhi.

Mr. Shah said that when the Congress and its allies lose elections, they sometimes make excuses about electronic voting machines (EVMs), and sometimes about alleged vote theft.


Union Home Minister Amit Shah inaugurates various projects related to water resources in New Delhi on Thursday. ANI

'Negative politics'

"When I say that the BJP government will remain for 30 years, they tell the people that 'vote *chori* is happening, otherwise how would Amit Shah know this'. Amit Shah was born here, lives here, and remains among the people of the country, and does not have to go abroad every six months. The kind of negative politics you are doing, based on this, I can say that for the next 30 years, your government will not come to power," he said.

"When you [Rahul Gandhi] land in Delhi, remember my words: your number is not going to come in the next 30 years," Mr. Shah added.

The Home Minister said that the Opposition could not negate the country's mandate through such political tactics and mobocracy. If one wants to win elections, he said, one should go among the people to understand their sufferings and pains; nothing is achieved through dharnas and protests.

"Wherever you have been elected, bring schemes and do work to remove the people's sorrows, pains, sufferings, and disorder; otherwise, even the remaining existence will come to an end," Mr. Shah said.

Mr. Shah said that a different game was currently being played in Delhi because BJP governments were continuously being elected in States across the country. "This is troubling the opponents, which is why they are making the excuse of vote *chori*," he said.

'Double standards'

He noted that the recent Kerala Assembly election was held with the same voter list, Election Commission, and EVMs; after winning the election, the Opposition took the oath.

"When the opposition won in Telangana, the Election Commission was also good and the voter list was good too. When they won in Himachal, the Election Commission and voter list were good then as well... These double standards will not work, Rahul*ji*. People have now understood you," he said.

Reacting to the allegations, Congress MP Jairam Ramesh claimed in a post on X that "vote *chori* is a proven reality".

"According to the ECI's own data, over 10 crore Indians face the risk of losing their Constitutional right to vote. The ECI illegally altered Form 6 to create barriers for new voters. It has facilitated the widespread abuse of Form 7 for targeted deletions. The CEC has used the ECINET to centralise control of the electoral roll, overriding all legal safeguards," he said.

The nation was "outraged", Mr. Ramesh said, adding that widespread anger was fuelling continued protests despite repression. "The PM's ecosystem, in its desperation and nervousness, is now trying to divert and distract, doing what is in its very DNA – spread lies. It will not succeed. The PM-HM duo has been brutally exposed and the people will hold them accountable," he said.

Punjab drug trade

The Home Minister also attacked the Aam Aadmi Party. Given the flourishing of the drug trade in Punjab under the AAP government, the people of the State had now decided to vote the BJP-led NDA to power there, he said.

Congress MLAs burn Punjab CM's effigy as Oppn. parties stick to resignation demand

The Hindu Bureau
CHANDIGARH

The Punjab Assembly on Thursday, during obituary references, paid tributes to anti-drug crusader Parvinder Singh Jhota, who was shot in Punjab's Mansa on October 13. Even before the commencement of the session, Congress MLAs led by the Leader of the Opposition, Partap Singh Bajwa, burned the effigy of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann outside the Assembly complex and demanded his resignation.

Mr. Bajwa said the Chief Minister, who also holds the Home portfolio, has completely failed to maintain law and order in the State; the broad daylight murder of Jhota, who raised his voice against the drug menace, is a "glaring example" of the government's failure.

Outside the Assembly, speaking to journalists, Mr. Bajwa said, "It is the voice of the entire Punjab that law and order has completely ended. No person's life is safe in this State, no one's business is safe, no one's work is safe, no one's family is safe. So, we are asking for Bhagwant Mann's resignation."


Partap Singh Bajwa

Separately, Punjab Bharatiya Janata Party president Kewal Singh Dhillon hit out at the State government, accusing it of running away from its accountability. "This was evident from the fact that the Punjab Assembly session today [Thursday] lasted only for a few minutes, during which neither Punjab's concerns were discussed nor any deliberations held on the issues facing the state," he stated in a press release.

Mr. Dhillon added, "The government will have to answer on issues surrounding the drug menace, gangsterism, extortion and the deteriorating law-and-order situation. The people of Punjab are demanding answers from the AAP government regarding the deaths of Parminder Singh Jhota, Bikramjit Singh, Gulzar Singh and others, who lost their lives for raising their voice against drug menace."

The Shiromani Akali Dal on Thursday also demanded exemplary punishment in the murder case of Jhota and said a party delegation would meet the Punjab Governor on October 23 to seek the dismissal of the Aam Aadmi Party government.

In a post on X, Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) president Sukhbir Singh Badal said during its meeting with Governor Gulab Chand Kataria, the party would also seek compensation of ₹2 crore for Jhota's family. "Shiromani Akali Dal stands firmly with the family of Shaheed Bhai Parvinder Singh Jhota in its fight to eradicate drugs and to ensure exemplary punishment for all those who murdered the anti-drug crusader, as well as their patrons," Mr. Badal said.

He said he had earlier written to Union Home Minister Amit Shah for a CBI probe into the murder.

(With inputs from PTI)

Congress alleges censorship after Priyanka's son told to remove photos

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

A day after Bikaner House, a Rajasthan government-owned property in Delhi, asked visual artist and photographer Raihan Vadra to remove around 70 of 105 photographs documenting recent protests and youth movements in India from his exhibition, the Congress on Thursday raised concerns over alleged censorship and denying freedom of expression under the BJP-led government. Mr. Vadra is the son of Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra.

Senior Congress leader and former Rajasthan Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot criticised the BJP government in the State, saying that suppressing the voices of artists amounted to an attack on democracy.

"The truth that comes before the public is what frightens the BJP the most. A government that is rattled by a photo exhibition wants to conceal the unjustified actions taken during these movements," the Congress leader said.

The Bikaner House management issued a statement describing the venue as a public cultural institution dedicated to promoting art and culture. The activities must comply with the Bikaner House Management Society's policy, it stated.


A security guard removes photos printed on paper at Bikaner House in Delhi on Thursday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Titled "No Idea Is Final", the exhibition featured wildlife photography, abstract art, and photographs documenting recent youth movements in India. It was scheduled to open on Thursday.

Written explanation

Speaking to the media, Mr. Vadra said the Bikaner House management had first raised objections to some of the photographs a day before the scheduled opening, citing concerns that they could violate its policy. He said he was willing to discuss the objections but sought a written explanation from the authorities.

He alleged that the Deputy Resident Commissioner of Bikaner House subsequently asked him to remove 70 of the 105 photographs on display, citing the venue's policy. Mr. Vadra said he had already set aside images carrying explicit political slogans after reviewing the policy, but the authorities sought further changes after inspecting the exhibition again and subsequently sent him an email asking for additional photographs to be taken down.

He alleged that the requests eventually extended to two photographs of the Tricolour. "I have refused. I will not take down a picture of the Indian flag," he told the media.

Mr. Gehlot criticised the BJP government in Rajasthan. "This is a clear example of censorship. The BJP government must answer why photographs depicting the truth were removed," he said.

Ms. Vadra also took to X to condemn the move. "When someone with power becomes afraid of the expression of another, he doesn't know it, but he has already lost the very power he is trying to protect," she wrote, adding that she was proud of her son.

Congress MP and party media and publicity department chairperson Pawan Khera questioned the "offence" in clicking photos of protest.

"When even the Tricolour isn't safe from the censor's scissors, perhaps the problem isn't the art. It's the regime," Mr. Khera wrote on X.

Rahul has treacherous links with foreign agencies: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Thursday reiterated its accusation that Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi was attempting to create anarchy in India and weaken constitutional institutions in collusion with foreign organisations.

At a press conference here, BJP spokesperson Gaurav Bhatia cited a media report and alleged that attempts to bring about regime change in France and several other countries through unrest were linked to protests in India. He said the report identified 101 organisations across many countries, described the network as part of a "red-green ecosystem", and named two organisations: Progressive International and Indian Alliance Paris.


Gaurav Bhatia

Mr. Bhatia sought explanations from former Congress president Sonia Gandhi and Mr. Gandhi regarding their meeting with a Progressive International delegation on April 28, 2025, in Delhi.

Model of anarchy

Mr. Bhatia alleged that Mr. Gandhi was "presenting a model of anarchy, disorder, and treachery".

"A report published in a reputed newspaper today has brought to light the treacherous links to foreign agencies," he added.

The BJP leader also criticised Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sanjay Raut over a recent social media post concerning unrest in Albania.

ECI to hold Rajya Sabha bypoll in M.P. on Nov. 12

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Thursday announced that byelection to the Rajya Sabha seat from Madhya Pradesh, which was vacated by former Union Minister L. Murugan, would be held on November 12.

Mr. Murugan, who was Minister of State for Parliamentary Affairs and Information and Broadcasting, had quit the Union Council of Ministers and the Rajya Sabha on October 14. His term was due to end on April 2, 2030.

CEC must be prosecuted, farmers write to President

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Ahead of a farmers' rally here on Friday, demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, the Samyukt Kisan Morcha has written to President Droupadi Murmu that Mr. Kumar has violated his constitutional pledge and must be prosecuted. The memorandum to the President, which also demands scrapping of the SIR, will be submitted to all district and sub-divisional magistrates.

Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Ltd.
(A Govt. of Rajasthan Undertaking)
Gandhi Block, Swasthya Bhawan, Tilak Marg, Jaipur-302005, India
Phone No: 0141-2228066, 2228064 Website: www.rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in
CIN:U24232RJ2011SGC035067, E-mail: edprmsc@rajasthan.gov.in
Ref. No. :- F.02 (459)/RMSCL/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/NIB-21/2026-27/5316 Dated :- 16/10/2026
Corrigendum-II in NIB-21/2026-27
In Reference to NIB No. F.02 (459)/RMSCL/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/ NIB-21/2026-27/5192A Dated: - 28.09.2026 UBN No. MSC2627GLOB00061 Corrigendum-I is issued for date extension in bid. All details may be seen on **https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in** **https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in & https://www. rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in.**
Director (Proc.)
Raj.Samwad/C/26/12290 RMSCL, Jaipur

Rajasthan Medical Services Corporation Ltd.
(A Govt. of Rajasthan Undertaking)
Gandhi Block, Swasthya Bhawan, Tilak Marg, Jaipur-302005, India
Phone No: 0141-2228066, 2228064 Website: www.rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in
CIN:U24232RJ2011SGC035067, E-mail: edprmsc@rajasthan.gov.in
Ref. No. :- F.02 (454)/RMSCL/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/NIB-16/2026-27/5319 Dated :- 16/10/2026
Corrigendum-I in NIB-16/2026-27
In Reference to NIB No. F.02 (454)/RMSCL/PROCUREMENT/DRUG/ NIB-16/2026-27/5191 Dated: - 28.09.2026 UBN No. MSC2627GLOB00055 Corrigendum-I is issued for date extension in bid. All details may be seen on **https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in** **https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in & https://www.rmsc.health.rajasthan.gov.in.**
Director (Proc.)
Raj.Samwad/C/26/12293 RMSCL, Jaipur

Kerala State Council for Science, Technology and Environment (KSCSTE),
Sasthra Bhavan, Pattom, Thiruvananthapuram – 695004,
Phone : 0471-2548316, website : www.kscste.kerala.gov.in
NOTIFICATION
The KSCSTE is seeking qualified candidates for the post of **Director, KSCSTE**-Malabar Botanical Garden and Institute for Plant Sciences (MBGIPS)
For details log on to **www.kscste.kerala.gov.in**
Last date for the receipt of application is 15-11-2026, 5.00 p.m.
(D3/617/2026/I&PRD) EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT

IISER THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
भारतीय विज्ञान शिक्षा एवं अनुसंधान संस्थान तिरुवनंतपुरम
INDIAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
MARUTHAMALA P.O., VITHURA, THIRUVANANTHAPURAM Tel: 0471-2778044, 8164
NON-TEACHING STAFF RECRUITMENT 2026
IISER(T)/HR/002/2026 22.10.2026
Indian Institute of Science Education and Research Thiruvananthapuram invites applications from eligible Indian nationals for various non-faculty posts - Library Superintendent (UR-1), Sr. Technical Assistant (Technical) (UR-1), Jr. Technical Assistant (Scientific) (UR-2), Jr. Technical Assistant (Technical) (UR-1), Office Assistant (MS) (UR-1, OBC-1,SC-1).
The last date of submission of applications online is by 17 hrs on 11.11.2026.
For detailed advertisement, please log on to: **https://www.iisertvm.ac.in/openings/active_openings?post_category=Administration**
01/26-27 dt 22.10.2026 REGISTRAR

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, POTTERU IRRIGATION PROJECT, BALIMELA
1st Corrigendum to e-Procurement Notice No.- CCE-PIP-BML-14/2026-27
e-mail Id : ccepotteru123@gmail.com
The availability and submission of Bids-online is hereby extended up to **02-11-2026 5.00 PM** and the Tender / Bid will be opened on **03-11-2026 at 11.00 AM** due to unavoidable circumstances.
All other terms and conditions in the Notice will remain unaltered.
Chief Construction Engineer,
Potteru Irrigation Project, Balimela.
32001/1092/2627 OIPR-32001/32052/1/26-27/0025

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA – DEPARTMENT OF SPACE CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC – SHAR SRIHARIKOTA – 524124
Brief E-TENDER NOTICE
e-Tender Notice No.CMG/C/CON/268723 Date: 21/10/2026
On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for the following work:

Brief Name of work	Est. Value (Rs.)
Construction of Atmospheric & Space Science Research Facility (ASRF) Building at Chandipur, Odisha – (Civil, PH, Electrical & AC works).	906 Lakhs

Last date for sale (Tender documents can be downloaded) upto **12/11/2026 14:30 hrs**. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website **https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html** and tender free view at **https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro**
Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

GOVERNMENT OF TAMIL NADU
ARULMIGU DHANDAYUTHAPANI SWAMY TEMPLE, PALANI.
Tender Notice for the Fasali Year 1436
Notice seeking tenders for supply of materials for the Fasali year 1436 (from the date of order to 30.06.2027) in Arulmigu Dhandayuthapani Swamy Temple, Palani Town, Palani Taluk, Dindigul District.
(1) Website for submission of Tender : The tenders are invited through the website **https://tntenders.gov.in.** The bidders must possess digital signature certificate for submission of bids online. (2) Last date for submission of tender : **26.11.2026 F.N 10.00 am** (3) Date of Pre-Bid Meeting : **17.11.2026 F.N 11.00 am** (4) Tender Opening Date and Time : **26.11.2026 F.N 11.00 am** (5) Venue of Tender opening : Temple Head Office.
Items of Tender : Supply of Karpooravalli Banana, Kudagu Banana and Mountain Banana for the production of Panchamirtham.
Tender Deposit Amount : Rs.1,00,00,000/- (Rupess One Crore).
Tender Deposit should be paid in the website **http://www.tntenders.gov.in.** The tender conditions are available in above website.
R.S.Venkatesh, Deputy Commissioner, Joint Commissioner/ Executive Officer (fully Addl Chg)
K.M.Subramaniyan, Chairman of Trust Board
K.Dhanasekar, Trustee. S.Balasubramani, Trustee.
G.R.Balasubramaniyam, Trustee.
C.Annapoorani, Trustee.
DIPR/ 3174 /TENDER/2026

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER PWD CIRCLE KOTA
No. 2376 Date:- 14/10/2026
Notice Inviting Bid
(NIT No. 18/2026-27)
Bid for Construction of Various Road work in Distt. Kota is Invited from interested bidders up to 06:00 PM of 12-11-2026 (Thursday). Other Particulars of the bids may be visited on the procurement portal (http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in, http://sppp.rj.nic.in) of the Rajasthan State.
The approximate value of the procurement is Rs. 2546.78 Lacs.
UBN No. PWD2627WSOB14938, PWD2627WSOB14939
PWD2627WSOB14941, PWD2627WSOB14942
PWD2627WSOB14943, PWD2627WSOB14944
PWD2627WSOB14945, PWD2627WSOB14946
PWD2627WSOB14947, PWD2627WSOB14948
PWD2627WSOB14949, PWD2627WSOB14950
PWD2627WSOB14951, PWD2627WSOB14952
PWD2627WSOB14953
Superintending Engineer
DIPR/C/17833/2026 P.W.D. Circle Kota

INBRIEF



Review, repeal outdated laws, Vice-President urges States

Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan on Thursday urged States to review and repeal outdated laws to improve governance and ease of living, stressing that legal reforms must keep pace with changing times. Mr. Radhakrishnan was speaking during the inauguration of a conference on "Cooperative Federalism and Law Reforms: National and State Perspectives", organised by the Law Commission of India. "The ultimate purpose of law is to ensure a just, secure and dignified life for every citizen," he said. Emphasising the need for greater coordination between the Centre and States, the Vice-President said that political differences should not come in the way of public interest.

Firecracker ban breaches draw Bombay High Court ire

The Bombay High Court on Wednesday directed the Commissioner of Police and the corporation to brief officers regarding October 15 court order that imposed ban on firecrackers. The court was reacting to breaches during Durga *visarjan*. The corporation and the Maharashtra Pollution Control Board have yet to issue notices. The court observed that police machinery has failed to control violations. Station officers in Mumbai lacked awareness, and the Bench noted a lack of enforcement on decibel limits for music systems. The court warned that dereliction of duty by the police affects rights guaranteed under Article 14 and Article 21 of the Constitution.

Gold bars, cocaine seized at Mumbai airport; six arrested

The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has arrested six people, including an airport staff member and a Zambian woman, in two separate operations at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (CSMIA). Officers seized 2.317 kg of 24-carat foreign-origin gold bars, valued at approximately ₹3.47 crore, and arrested all five involved under the provisions of the Customs Act, 1962. In a separate operation, DRI officers intercepted a Zambian woman on October 20. During examination, she expelled 11 capsules containing 190 gm of cocaine valued at approximately ₹1 crore in the illicit market.

Delhi conference to explore new markets for Indian rice

Trade and business representatives from over 150 countries will attend the Bharat International Rice Conference (BIRC) beginning in Delhi on Friday. Organised by the Indian Rice Exporters Federation (IREF), the three-day conference brings together exporters, importers, millers, policymakers and food businesses to explore new markets, assess the 2027 price outlook and identify ways to earn more from rice. After the recent war on Iran, one of the major buyers of Indian rice, and the crisis in West Asia, the IREF had been urging the Union government to help the exporters find new markets and assistance in clearing cargos stuck in Strait of Hormuz.

Actor firing case: four sent to police custody till October 26

They were arrested by the Delhi Police Special Cell on October 20; the police submitted that the accused were involved in procuring and supplying the weapon used in the attack in Mumbai

Yohaan Varghese
MUMBAI

A metropolitan magistrate court in Mumbai on Thursday remanded four accused, including two women, arrested in connection with the October 18 firing at Bollywood actor Tiger Shroff's car in Juhu, in police custody till October 26. The Mumbai Crime Branch police had sought their custody till October 31 to investigate their alleged role in procuring and supplying the firearm used in the attack.

The four accused are Kunal Singh, 21, from Rohana village in Haryana's Sonipat district; Sumit Sorolia, 19, from Kharkhoda in Sonipat; Radha Verma, 23, from Sitapur in Uttar Pradesh; and Babita Rao, 23, from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh. They were arrested by the Delhi Police Special Cell on October 20 and subsequently brought to Mumbai on transit remand.

During the hearing, the prosecution alleged that the four were part of a conspiracy to supply weapons to the alleged shooters. According to the police, Kunal and Sumit were allegedly involved in procuring the firearm, while Radha and Babita allegedly helped supply it to the assailants.



Radha and Babita being taken for production before a court in Mumbai on Thursday. PTI

'No conspiracy'

Seeking extended custody, the prosecution submitted that the case involved serious offences, including attempt to murder, and that the investigation was at an initial stage. The prosecutor argued that custodial interrogation, including questioning the accused together, was necessary to establish the wider conspiracy. The weapon used in the attack is yet to be recovered.

Opposing the application, defence advocate Sachin Patil questioned the evidence linking the accused to the alleged weapon supply chain, arguing that investigators had not even established the make or type of pistol used in the firing. "They are not being able to identify the make of this pistol! Whether it was Indian-made, whether it was foreign-made... Nothing of that sort has been identified," Mr. Patil submitted.

He further argued that the investigators had not produced concrete material to justify the arrests.

"Before effecting the arrest of a person, there has to be some concrete material on record. There is not even a statement of a co-accused," Mr. Patil argued, questioning the grounds for implicating the two women. The defence also questioned the absence of any reference to payment or financial consideration for the alleged weapon supply in the remand application.

Mr. Patil argued that the accused had already been questioned during their three-day transit remand and that their physical custody was unnecessary for examining call detail records and other electronic evidence.

Advocate Ajinkya Mirgal, representing Radha and Babita, submitted that his clients were not present at the scene of the firing and that there was nothing further to recover from them.

"There is no motive behind it, so no conspiracy," Mr. Mirgal argued, urging the court to send the accused directly to judicial custody.

Speaking to reporters after the hearing, the defence lawyers said the investigators had already seized mobile phones and wanted to examine them for evidence of the alleged communication trail. They maintained that forensic examination of the devices did not require continued police custody.

After hearing both sides, the magistrate granted police custody of all accused till October 26.



President Droupadi Murmu during the 'Seva Samman Parv' and 'Yuva Prabodhan' event in Raipur, Chhattisgarh. PTI

Chhattisgarh youth breaking free from Maoism: President

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday expressed delight over Chhattisgarh's youth joining the national mainstream after breaking free from Maoism.

Addressing the 'Seva Samman Parva' and 'Yuva Prabodhan' event organised on the occasion of Nuakhai festival at Sardar Balbeer Singh Juneja Indoor Stadium in Raipur, she described Maoism that had gripped the State for decades as a misguided path.

"It is a matter of joy that, through the efforts of Central and State governments and their own willpower, Chhattisgarh's youth are freeing themselves from the misguided path of Maoism and joining the mainstream," she said.

Addressing the youth, Ms. Murmu said she was confident that if young people embraced humility along with knowledge, ethics with ambition, and a spirit of service with success, the resolve to build a developed India would become stronger.

"When we link our individual efforts to collective and national goals, the path to the country's progress is paved," she said.

Urging the youth to dream big, broaden their vision and uphold high standards of conduct, she asked them to nurture a spirit of service towards society, the nation and fellow citizens. "Whatever work you undertake in life, do it with honesty, dedication and sensitivity. Nation-building is not achieved through big decisions alone, but through the small, honest efforts of millions of citizens," she said.

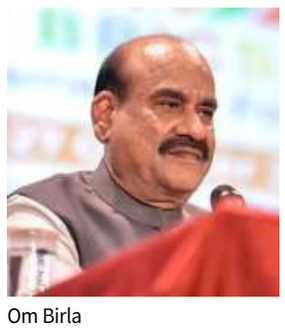
BRICS Parliamentary Forum to meet in Delhi: Om Birla

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A two-day conference of the 12th BRICS Parliamentary Forum will be held in New Delhi on October 26 and 27, with discussions centred on "Fostering parliaments for people-centric development", Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla said at a press conference on Thursday.

"The two-day conference will include both bilateral and multilateral discussions. Presiding officers, members of Parliament and other dignitaries from BRICS and partner countries will brainstorm on strategic priorities for Parliaments," he said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will also attend the event, though no separate invitations were extended to Opposition leaders of the two Houses. India had received confirmation from most participating countries, though Saudi Arabia and Ethiopia expressed their inability to participate.



Om Birla

The deliberations will cover "institutional resilience, ethical artificial intelligence, digital transformation, reform of global governance and sustainable development".

Meanwhile, the Speaker avoided all questions regarding the delay in proroguing the Monsoon Session of Parliament and speculation about a special sitting to deliberate on delimitation legislation.

"Article 85 of the Constitution clearly says that the Speaker has no role in calling or proroguing a session. If I had a role, then I would have given a judgment," he said.

Trinamool case

Regarding the disqualification of 20 MPs who broke away from the original Trinamool Congress (TMC) in West Bnegal, Mr. Birla said he would expedite the process once the lawmakers submitted their responses. "Just like the Supreme Court is hearing the case, my court is also hearing the case, I cannot pass the judgment here," the Speaker said.

Modi and Netanyahu discuss West Asia, bilateral relations

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Prime Minister of Israel Benjamin Netanyahu discussed India-Israel relations and the situation in West Asia over a phone call on Thursday.

"The two leaders welcomed the sustained momentum in India-Israel relations and reaffirmed their shared commitment to further strengthening the Special Strategic Partnership between the two countries. The leaders also exchanged views on recent developments in West Asia and underscored the urgent need to restore peace and stability in the region," Mr. Modi's office said in a statement.

During the call, Mr. Modi reiterated India's call for dialogue and diplomacy.

Meanwhile, Mr. Netanyahu, said that he has invited Mr. Modi to light a torch, along with Indian pilot Smit Machhar who has been praised for his bravery during the incident involving a flydubai aircraft.

"I spoke with my friend, Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and invited him to light a torch together with the heroic Indian pilot on the Independence Day of the State of Israel. Modi thanked me for the invitation and said that on the ground and in the air, India and Israel fight terrorism together. He expressed his appreciation for the courageous and long-standing relationship between us," Mr. Netanyahu said in a post on X.

CPI(M) MP seeks probe into alleged SBI data leak

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

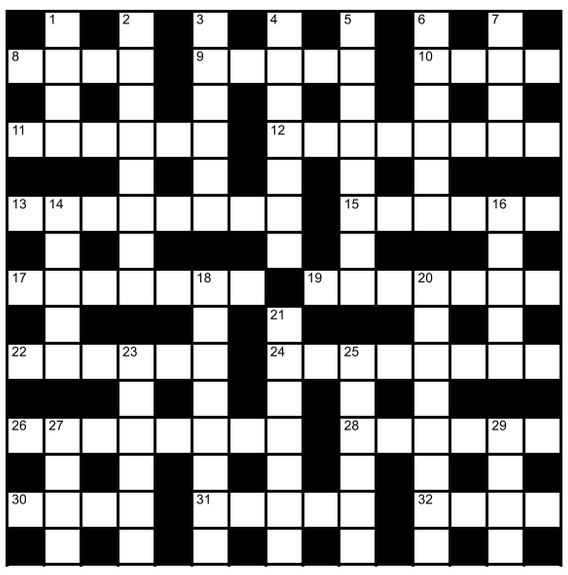
Expressing concern about the reported leak of personal information belonging to State Bank of India (SBI) customers, CPI(M) MP A.A. Rahim in a letter to Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, urged to conduct a thorough investigation to establish the extent of the breach and identify those responsible. Mr. Rahim said that the reported exposure of sensitive customer information, including mobile numbers, email addresses, branch details and loan records, is particularly alarming. The incident, Mr. Rahim said, also raises questions on the implementation of the data protection laws in the country.

TH CROSSWORD + 14930

(set by Incognito)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 Husband with a large ring; a ring of light (4)
9 Examine boss with lady at last (5)
10 Some offering for Ireland (4)
11 Inventor is done? Is in trouble? (6)
12 Dreamt aiding me wrongly (8)
13 Wrongly typed a key need for unaided vision (5,3)
15 Maximum sum tot may produce (6)
17 Well liked tree planted around university (7)
19 Retain mother and stay silent (4,3)
22 Single thin length of thread is maroon (6)
24 Lebanon organisation shelters male aristocrat (8)
26 Damaged CD containing incorrect visa at state team event in men's tennis (5,3)
28 Girl in Salem building shines (6)
30 Curved structure in Munnar church (4)
31 Letter found in home garage (5)
32 Place for temporary stay in penitentiary (4)

Down

1 Part of body found in Khandwa (4)
2 Excitedly arouse US author (8)
3 Time for payment of bill from American church? Around 1st of November... (6)
4 Planet having pit at centre (7)
5 City says cure is arranged (8)
6 Average clairvoyant (6)
7 Man's relative by marriage? (4)
14 Pertaining to a part of a boxing match (5)
16 Method of diving from small island (5)
18 Loveless doctor goes around university following sailor and kidnapper (8)
20 Stops serpent coiling around top of vine (8)
21 Fish photographer (7)
23 Get off! It's burning... (6)
25 Prohibit carrying breakfast food for mendicant (6)
27 Changing sari... showing attitude (4)
29 Repair front of mower at last (4)

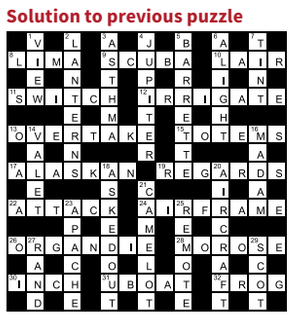
SUDOKU

1		6			3		4	
7	4	8	6					
3	5					6		
	1		8				3	6
				2				
8	3				4		5	
		4					8	2
					8	5	6	3
	8		9			1		4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★☆

No.SS7039 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

2	5	3	8	4	7	6	9	1
6	4	1	5	2	9	7	3	8
7	9	8	6	3	1	4	2	5
5	8	4	9	7	6	3	1	2
3	6	9	1	8	2	5	7	4
1	2	7	4	5	3	8	6	9
8	7	2	3	1	4	9	5	6
4	3	6	2	9	5	1	8	7
9	1	5	7	6	8	2	4	3

FAITH

Rama's rationale

Kings were duty-bound to punish erring subjects, said Navalpakkam Vasudevachariar in a discourse. A sinner who is punished must not be angry with the king, because once he has faced punishment on this earth, he will not go to Yama Loka. If he escapes the clutches of the law, then he will pay for his sins in Yama Loka, and the punishments there will be far worse than anything he has to face on this earth. There was a country whose king was meticulous in punishing his subjects who were guilty of crimes. But in the neighbouring country, all the subjects were good, so there was no need for the king to punish any of them. When the people who had been punished by the king in the first country died, they went to heaven. So did the good subjects of the neighbouring country. The good people were shocked to find those guilty of criminal conduct also in heaven. How could they have come to heaven, they wondered. The answer was that because they had been punished by their king, they were not in Yama Loka. If a king overlooks the wrongdoings of his subjects, then he gets a share in their sins.

As to Vaali's complaint that Rama should not have killed him from behind, Rama says even when animals are hunted for flesh, it is perfectly all right to take aim from behind. Vaali has made Sugreeva's wife his own, and must be punished for this. Srimad Bhagavatam and Garuda Puranam say that if a man forcefully embraces a woman, he will go to Naraka Loka. There, a likeness of the woman will be made, and the image will be heated. The man will be forced to embrace the heated image. Vaali, by being punished by Rama, has escaped this.

INBRIEF



HPCL net profit slips 9% amid volatile crude prices in Q2

Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (HPCL) reported a 9% year-on-year decline in standalone net profit to ₹3,483 crore in the second quarter, amid volatility in benchmark crude oil prices following the reignited conflict in West Asia. The Mumbai-headquartered company's gross refining margin (GRM), a key indicator of refining profitability, rose sharply to $32.15 per barrel during the quarter, compared with $8.80 per barrel in the corresponding period last year.

Jio IPO fully subscribed on day two, total bids jump 4x

Jio Platforms Ltd.'s public offering has received larger-than-expected demand on its second day, with retail proportion of the IPO receiving full subscription. The $3.2 billion IPO, the largest in India's history, was subscribed over 4 times by Thursday, with investors bidding 95.33 crore shares against 19.75 crore shares on offer, according to latest data. The initial public offering opened for subscriptions on Wednesday and will close on Friday.

IDL commissions explosives silo plant in West Bengal

IDL Explosives (IDL), a group company of Hyderabad-based Apollo Micro Systems, has commissioned a bulk explosives silo plant with a capacity of 9,000 MT near Asansol, West Bengal. The Bolkunda Silo Unit, spread over 8.4 acres, expands IDL's national network of bulk explosives plants and silos, and strengthens the company's capacity to service the long-term bulk explosives orders secured from CIL subsidiaries earlier this year, Apollo Micro Systems said.

Festivals to boost textile sales but China imports a concern

While rising input costs are a concern among retailers, about 54 % of the respondents in a CMAI survey said they were absorbing costs by cutting margins; only about 35% have increased prices.

M. Soundariya Preetha
COIMBATORE

The apparel industry has entered the festive season on a positive note, with 52% of the Cloth Manufacturers Association of India (CMAI) members expecting higher sales than last year. However, there are concerns among apparel makers in Tiruppur about rising garment imports from China.

According to a recent survey by the CMAI among its members numbering close to 7,000 and including major retailers and brands, almost 30% of respondents expect sales this year to match last year's performance. Just less than 20% expect a decline.

Former president and chief mentor of the CMAI Rahul Mehta told *The Hindu* in a prelude to Diwali season, the eastern States did well for Dasara offtake.



Festive outlook: Respondents of the CMAI survey expect sales this year to match last year's performance. MOORTHY G.

However, sales in the southern States for Navrathri was sluggish in the north and west.

"Despite the textile inflation of 5%-7%, we think the festival season this year will be better than last year. Raw material prices have started coming down and the global geopolitical situation is not as bad as it was a few months ago. Sales are expected to pick up across the country closer to Diwali," he said.

The CMAI said in a statement strong order bookings by retailers at the CMAI's National Garment Fairs (NGFs) further reinforced the industry's confidence. While rising input costs are a concern among retailers, about 54% of the respondents said they were absorbing the costs by cutting margins and only about 35% had raised prices. "This indicates higher festive sales could come with continued pressure on profitability," the CMAI said. Indian wear is expected to lead the festive-season growth followed by western casual wear. Online apparel sales are also expected to gain momentum this year.

Rising China imports

Meanwhile, according to R. Dhamodharan, secretary of the South India Hosiery Manufacturers Association, "Import of cotton readymade garments from China during April-August was worth ₹508.64 crore against ₹283.65 crore for the same period last year.

"Several traders are placing orders in China and importing the garments now."

Further, distributors and consumers may not absorb price increase now. "So, the manufacturers (in Tiruppur) are looking at revising the prices after the festival," he said.

What SBI had in place for cyber defence

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

The suspected customer-data exposure at State Bank of India (SBI) has brought its cybersecurity preparedness into focus, despite the bank reporting an extensive array of safeguards in its annual disclosures.

SBI's FY2025-26 Sustainability Report and Annual Report, published before the reported exposure, detail its security audits, automated threat monitoring, incident-response procedures and employee training. The disclosures also outline plans to further integrate its cyber-defence operations.

Extensive audits

SBI's Sustainability Report says information-systems audits covered 427 IT systems during FY26. Audits of outsourced IT activities covered 695 activities, while internal and external cybersecurity audits covered 176 IT applications and infrastructure and 151 systems, respectively.

However, the report does not disclose the findings, the number of vulnerabilities identified or how many were rectified.

SBI reported "nil" instances of data breaches during FY26.

The bank's Global Cyber Security Operations Centre (GCSOC) continuously monitors critical information systems for threats and unauthorised access. Automated tracking of indicators of compromise (IoCs)—digital clues that may signal cyberattacks—has replaced a previously manual process.



SBI's Global Cyber Security Operations Centre monitors critical information systems. ANI

SBI also monitors phishing, fraudulent websites, brand impersonation, vishing and rogue mobile applications, pursuing the removal of malicious links and websites.

Its Annual Report cites an automated Secure Configuration Monitoring System covering more than 85,000 IT assets. AI-driven intelligence platforms, risk profiling and continuous monitoring of digital transactions help identify suspicious activity.

Security testing includes ethical hacking, vulnerability assessments, penetration testing and red-team exercises across websites, mobile applications, databases, networks and internal systems. Monthly domain-password-spray tests seek to identify employees using easily guessed passwords.

Firewalls, encryption, multi-factor authentication and data-loss prevention tools provide additional safeguards.

CERT SBI serves as the central first responder to cyber incidents. Its response framework covers detection, containment, eradication, recovery and post-incident reviews.

SEBI eases rules for early share delivery

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

The SEBI on Thursday amended Early Pay-In (EPI) rules to ease margin requirements for stockbrokers and investors, allowing the value of shares delivered early to be recognised towards margin obligations. The revised framework will come into effect on February 22, 2027, giving brokers and clearing corporations four months to upgrade their systems.

Early Pay-In allows investors selling shares to transfer them to the clearing corporation before the scheduled settlement date. The value of securities delivered early can be used to meet margin requirements for the corresponding sale, reducing the need to provide additional funds.

Under the revised rules, clearing corporations will calculate the accepted EPI value on the trade date. This value will be the lower of the value of securities delivered early or the value of securities sold.

For investors taking buy and sell positions in the cash market on the same day, clearing corporations will calculate margin requirements after deducting the accepted EPI value.

Brokers will not have to collect additional margin for these positions to the extent covered by the accepted EPI value.

eMudhra to exit global web security certificate business

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

eMudhra Ltd., whose intermediate security certificates' private keys were exposed on Tuesday in an extraordinary security incident, will exit the global business of offering web security certificates, the firm said after the firm's stocks hit the circuit breaker for two trading sessions.

The incident may have wide-ranging consequences since eight web security certificates can now be issued by attackers that seem legitimate to devices that have not received updates to distrust them.

The firm will continue the business it is engaged in for issuance of SSL certificates for Indian websites, a spokesperson for the firm told *The Hindu*.



It will continue the business it is engaged in for issuance of SSL certificates for Indian websites.

Loss of reputation

The firm said web security certificates issued for non-Indian subscribers accounted for less than 1% of revenue but was causing a disproportionate amount of reputational loss for the firm which lost more than a third of its market value in the 48 hours after word of the incident spread.

eMudhra's web and document signing technologies are used across government and private entities. The IT Ministry constituted a committee to look into the incident.

Kaushik Srinivasan, eMudhra's co-founder, told *The Hindu* in an interview on Thursday before the firm announced the exit, that "perception threats had arisen" for the firm following the incident. "This is a one-off incident on a bad day," Mr. Srinivasan insisted. "A script error can happen to anybody, right? The key lesson for us is, it's more like once bitten, twice shy. Therefore, we will put in place rigorous operational security controls.

"We have not seen any significant negative feedback from any one of them and are quite deeply humbled by the support we are getting from our customers," Mr. Srinivasan said.

An independent firm not involved with past audits that failed to spot weak intermediate certificates would be appointed for a review of the firm's security practices, he said.

Mr. Srinivasan shrugged off concerns that forged certificates based on eMudhra's exposed private keys could be used in cyberattacks on smart devices.

"Smart devices generally rely on certificates that are more private trust not as much on public trust," he said. "None of the use cases we served on smart devices relied on any kind of public trust certificates."

eMudhra has replied to queries from the IT Ministry's panel and will continue to engage with them, Mr. Srinivasan added.

A.P.-Transco to tap capital markets soon

V. Raghavendra
VIJAYAWADA

As part of a major financial restructuring plan, the Transmission Corporation of Andhra Pradesh Ltd. (AP-Transco) is gearing up to float an Initial Public Offering (IPO).

This is to tap the capital markets as per the Ministry of Power (MoP)'s mandate that at least one power utility in each State should undertake an IPO subject to prescribed eligibility conditions stipulated in the draft Fiscal Responsibility and Budget Management (FRBM) framework issued by the MoP.

With this, AP-Transco was instructed to prepare and formulate a time-bound roadmap to facilitate an IPO following a decision taken by CM N. Chandrababu Naidu at a high-level review meeting held in August, as per a Transco Office Order (TOO) issued by AP Special Chief Secretary (Energy) and AP-Transco CMD K. Vijayanand on October 21.



The plan aims at boosting the financials of AP-Transco.

He said the plan encompassed short and long-term strategies to boost AP-Transco's financial position and sustainability.

HDFC Bank reviews 'leak of information'

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

HDFC Bank, India's largest private sector Bank said it was conducting an internal review of an alleged leak of information by two senior executives while not specifying the reason behind the inquiry or identifies of the executives involved.

"The bank is committed to upholding the highest standards of ethics and governance as outlined in our code of conduct.

"We take any report of potential violations seriously," a spokesperson of the bank said.

"An internal review into this matter is underway to gather and evaluate all relevant facts.

"To protect the integrity of the process and privacy of all parties involved, we do not comment on active internal reviews," the spokesperson said. "Appropriate action will be taken based on the findings."

Two executives overseeing key business functions reportedly were found to be sharing confidential business strategies and sensitive data with external parties. The move comes ahead of Anup Bagchi joining the private lender as its MD & CEO on October 27.

HDFC Bank shares on Thursday slid 1.85% to end at ₹693.30 on the BSE.

Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder

Call our toll-free number 1800 102 1878
Or write to us at customercare@thehindu.co.in
Scan the QR code to register your feedback

THE HINDU | thehindu businessline | FRONTLINE | SPORTSTAR | Young World | THE HINDU

RAIL WHEEL FACTORY
Yelahanka, Bangalore - 560 064
Website: www.rwf.indianrailways.gov.in

TENDER NOTICE NO. RWF/S/P1/15/2026-27 dt:19.10.26

On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Materials Manager invites E-Tenders for **Tender No: P1262769** for supply of **55 sets** of **"SE MODULAR DRILL BODY (3XD)OF DIA 25.1 MM"** on IREPS E-Portal http://www.ireps.gov.in. **Due Date: 06.11.26**
Principal Chief Materials Manager

TENDER & TENDER NOTICE No : RWF/M/OT/PROJ/2026-27/72 dt: 16/10/26

On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Mechanical Engineer invites E-Tenders for the work of **"Engagement of a Consultancy Agency for Redesigning of Factory Layout for Efficient Material Handling, including Preparation of DPR & Technical Specification of Machinery"** on IREPS E-Portal http://www.ireps.gov.in(Works). **Estimated Cost:** ₹41,30,000/-; **EMD:** ₹82,600/- ; **Due Date & Time for Technical Bid:** 07.11.26 @10:30 Hrs. **Due Date & Time for Financial Bid:** To be intimated later. **Completion Period:** 9 months.
Deputy Chief Mechanical Engineer/Projects

Detailed Tender Notice, Tender documents, Eligibility Criteria & corrigendum (if any) will be available in IREPS E-Portal/RWF website for both the tenders.

BANGALORE WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD
Office of the Chief Engineer (IP-R & D)
3rd Floor, Cauvery Bhavan, K.G. Road, Bengaluru - 560009.
No:BWSSB/CE(IP-R & D)/ACE(IP-R & D)-1/TA/1413/2026-27 Dated: 22-10-2026

INVITATION FOR TENDER - (IFT)
(Through KPP Portal Only)

BWSSB invites Tenders in Two Stage Tender System from eligible Contractors for the work of **Appointment of Consultants for Preparation of Master Plan for Water Supply and Sewerage Sector to Newly Added Area of Bangalore Urban District under the Jurisdiction of BWSSB.**
Amount Put to Tender: Rs. 944.87 Lakhs EMD: Rs. 14,18,000/-
Last Date and Time for Submission of Completed Tender Document is on **11-11-2026 upto 16.00 Hours.** The Bids will be Opened on **12-11-2026 at 17.00 Hours.** The details regarding the tender and participation in the e-Procurement Portal Process can be obtained by logging on to **https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in.** For further details contact the undersigned office during working hours.
Sd/-
Chief Engineer (IP-R & D)
DIPR/CP/3329/Adverto/2026-27

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA TENDER NOTICE

SR. No.	NAME OF BOARD/ CORP./ AUTH	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE (TIME)	AMOUNT / EMD, (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE BOARD CORP./AUTH	NODAL OFFICER/ CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	UHBVN	PROCUREMENT OF 500 MW SOLAR POWER WITH BATTERY ENERGY STORAGE SYSTEM (BESS) ON LONG TERM BASIS FROM GRID CONNECTED SOLAR PV POWER PROJECTS WITHIN THE STATE OF HARYANA	START TIME: 21.10.2026 AT 17:00 HRS LAST TIME: 17.11.2026 AT 15:00 HRS	RS. 13,27,200 /MW OF QUANTUM OFFERED	www.uhbvn.org.in RfS no.126/CE/HPPC/ LTPIII/500 MW/ SOLAR & BESS dated 21.10.2026	9023797477 cehppc@uhbvn.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.haryanaeprocurement.gov.in or www.etenders.hry.nic.in
SAMVAD - 13/2027/40/50445/I/199/7

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD(R&B) DIVISION VIJAYPUR
ABBREVIATED NOTICE INVITING TENDER
e-NIT No. 66 of 2026-27 Dated. 17-10-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works

S.No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost of work (in Lacs)	Cost of Tender Doc. (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (In Rs.)	Time Allowed For completion	Class of Contractor
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1	Development of Shiv Temple at Gurha Slathia, Mandi Garh near Devi Pindi Temple.	**30**	**600**	**2% of Adv. Cost**	**06 Months** (Incl. All Rainy days)	"A & B"

Position of AAA :- Accorded
Position of T.S :- Sanctioned
Project Authority :- Under Capex Budget 2026-27 (Priority works).

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	21-10-2026
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	From 21-10-2026 to 04-11-2026
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	23-10-2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Vijaypur
4	Bid submission Start Date	21-10-2026 at 1800 Hrs
5	Bid Submission End Date	04-11-2026 upto 1600 Hrs
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	05-11-2026 on or after 1300 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Vijaypur
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

The tender is available at website http://jktenders.gov.in all other terms & conditions can be seen on the above website.

DIP/J-12938/26
Executive Engineer, PWD (R&B) Division, Vijaypur

BRUSSELS

International Criminal Court wins EU rights prize amid U.S. sanctions



AP

The International Criminal Court and its embattled staff have won the European Union's top human rights honour, the Sakharov Prize, an official said on Thursday. The award came just days after the Trump administration announced new sanctions on the court over investigations into the U.S. and its allies, including Israel. AP

BEIJING

Casualties feared after strong 7.0 magnitude quake strikes Tibet



GETTY IMAGES

A strong 7.0-magnitude earthquake struck Tibet region late on Thursday and casualties have been reported, China's news agency Xinhua said. It did not offer any details about the number or type of casualties. The epicentre was located in a mountainous area about 190 km east-northeast of Nagqu the U.S. Geological Survey said. AFP

LAGOS

As Ebola spreads to Nigeria, WHO official warns of 'complex' outbreak



REUTERS

The World Health Organization's Africa chief warned on Thursday that the continent now faced a "complex" Ebola outbreak after the virus crossed from east Africa to Nigeria, which has reported the first case in west Africa. "Nigeria has confirmed an imported case of Ebola virus disease," Mohamed Janabi told a media briefing. AFP

YANGON

Suu Kyi sounded 'fairly healthy', son says after first call in years



MYANMAR PRESIDENT SPOKESPERSON OFFICE VIA AP

The son of Myanmar's Aung San Suu Kyi has said that she sounded "fairly healthy" after speaking to the detained ex-democratic leader on Thursday for the first time in more than five years. "She was able to say she was in good health, but being 81, things aren't getting any better," said Kim Aris, who lives in the United Kingdom. AFP

Russia says 808 drones downed; pounds Ukraine with missiles

Kyiv endured a noisy night as 21 ballistic missiles came in three waves smashing apartment buildings, energy facilities, a railway station and the city's subway system, says Zelenskyy; attacks began hours after Putin agreed to resume peace talks

Associated Press
KYIV



Ukrainian firefighters work to douse the fire at a shopping centre damaged in a missile strike in Kyiv on Thursday. AFP

Russia bombarded Kyiv with ballistic missiles in an hours-long nighttime barrage, while the Russian military said on Thursday that its air defences intercepted over 800 drones fired by Ukraine at Moscow and other cities.

At least four people were killed in Ukraine and dozens of others were wounded, officials said, in the large-scale attacks that began only hours after Russian President Vladimir Putin agreed "in principle" on Wednesday to resume three-way negotiations between Russia, Ukraine and the U.S. Mr. Putin's consent came in talks in St. Petersburg with U.S. President Donald Trump's envoy, Steve Witkoff, who had spoken of a "new momentum" towards peace after meeting Tuesday with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Norway. No date was set for the tripartite talks.

Representatives of the three countries held rounds of "technical" talks in the UAE and Switzerland in January and February, seeking to lay the groundwork for detailed negotiations. But they reported little progress beyond exchanges of prisoners of war. Russia's aerial attacks hit 12 regions of Ukraine overnight, killing at least four people and wounding scores of others, Mr. Zelenskyy said on social media on Thursday.

The Ukrainian capital endured a noisy night as 21 ballistic missiles came in three waves, Mr. Zelenskyy said, smashing apartment buildings, energy facilities, a railway station and the Kyiv subway system, shopping malls and businesses. One person was killed in Kyiv. Ukrainians are bracing for bitterly cold months ahead as the recent escalation in Russian attacks targets the power grid.

Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said on Thursday that Mr. Putin had received an invitation to attend the G20 summit in Miami in December but has not yet decided whether to go.

Russia's Defence Ministry said air defences overnight downed 808 Ukrainian drones, with two people reported wounded.

Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said 630 of the drones were fired towards the capital between late Wednesday and early Thursday. Moscow airports temporarily restricted air traffic overnight.

French authorities seek to ban or curb new protests

Agence France-Presse
PARIS



Protesters during a demonstration against poor education and school conditions in Paris on Thursday. AP

French authorities on Thursday imposed bans or restrictions on new protests springing up in the wake of demonstrations last weekend that degenerated into the country's worst street violence in years.

President Emmanuel Macron said after chairing a meeting of key ministers and intelligence officials that curfews and other security measures would be imposed, including bans on "groups without legitimacy" holding protests.

"The priority is a return to calm," he said, adding that he would chair a defence council meeting of key ministers on Friday to decide "the next steps" for new nationwide demonstrations called for Saturday and afterwards.

The worst of the violence, Mr. Macron said, "was led by organised ultra-left groups aiming to bring down the republic", that he accused of "sedition".

Officials are still reeling from the clashes, widespread looting and vandalism of public buildings that broke out on October 17, on the margins of mass demonstrations of more than half a million people against the surging cost of living.

Mr. Macron's government has admitted police lost control, and candidates jockeying to succeed him in presidential elections in six months' time argue that authorities are incapable or unwilling to calm the situation.

7 tankers hit in Strait of Hormuz, says Iran

Associated Press
TEL AVIV

Seven oil tankers caught fire or were damaged in the Strait of Hormuz overnight after being hit by Iran or striking naval mines, Tehran said on Thursday, a markedly high number as concerns about a return to all-out war rise.

With days before a close election in Israel in which Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu could lose power, and before next month's U.S. midterm election in which war-linked high prices have sparked anger, there are concerns that U.S.-Israeli attacks on Iran could resume.

Iranian state television reported the claims about the latest attacks on ships, which the AP could not independently confirm. The report cited the Revolutionary Guard Corps navy, which again threatened to strike U.S. military bases in the region if the U.S. keeps helping to guide commercial ships through the strait.

The report didn't mention casualties.

Albanian lawmakers scuffle in parliament as students' week-long protests continue

Agence France-Presse
TIRANA



Protesters wave flags and carry signs as they gather during an anti-government protest in Tirana on Thursday. REUTERS

Albanian lawmakers grappled on the floor of parliament on Thursday, as the opposition accused the government of violently targeting protesters over a week of unrest in Tirana, the capital.

Since last week, student demonstrators have taken to the streets to demand better support for education and to renew months-long calls for Prime Minister Edi Rama's resignation.

Protesters have routinely clashed with police and attacked government buildings, with more than 300 people injured and dozens of protesters detained.

On Thursday, during a scheduled vote, opposition MPs gathered in front of the speaker's podium, calling for the session to be stopped because of the unrest. The group held pictures showing the face and wounds of a protester allegedly injured by officers. Water and documents were lobbed towards the speaker, triggering a scuffle with other parliamentarians.

Dramatic scenes in the Albanian parliament are not unusual, with similar scenes erupting in the past and flares lit in the chamber at least twice.

American detained in Russia arrives in U.S.

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

A retired U.S. teacher freed by President Vladimir Putin after four years' detention in Russia for allegedly fighting on behalf of Ukraine has returned to the United States, his lawyer said on Thursday.

"Yes he has landed back," Stephen Hubbard's lawyer Martin De Luca told AFP, without providing details. U.S. President Donald Trump posted photos on early Thursday showing Mr. Hubbard smiling as he posed with U.S. special envoy Steve Witkoff.

Mr. Trump said Mr. Hubbard was released without the United States having to agree to a prisoner swap. However, the Republican leader lifted some sanctions on Russia ahead of the release and also agreed to purchase Russian diese.

Mr. Witkoff was in Russia on Wednesday to meet with Mr. Putin, who said afterward that Moscow was ready in principle to rejoin talks with Ukraine and the U.S. to end the war.

Sport

It's Sichuan versus Stars; Tigers meet Iris in the other semifinal

BASKETBALL

K. Keerthivasan
BENGALURU



On song: Kasagi, right, top-scored for Iris. K. MURALI KUMAR

The final group games of the FIBA-Women's Basketball League Asia at the Sree Kanteerava Indoor Stadium here on Thursday witnessed hectic action as teams vied to finish in the top two in their respective groups and secure places in the knockouts.

Title contender Sichuan Yuanda Meile (China) outplayed Akari Sparks (Philippines) 94-73 to top Group-A, while Denso Iris (Japan) pulled off a hard-fought 80-65 win over KB Stars (South Korea) to claim the pole position in Group-B.

Sichuan will take on Stars, while Cathay Life Tigers (Taiwan) will meet Iris in the semifinals on Saturday.

Railways will clash with Sparks for the fifth spot.

Friday is a rest day.

The results: Group-A: Sichuan Yuanda Meile 94 (Sara Blicavs 22, Chennedy Carter 21, Song Gao 11, Yingying Su 11) bt Akari Sparks 73 (Saicha Patricia Grant-Allen 22, Stefanie Berberabe 12, Jhazmin Joson 11, Bre'Amber Shakira Scott 10).

Group-B: Denso Iris 80 (Haruna Kasagi 20, Maki Takada 12) bt KB Stars 65 (Yunjeong Na 15, Sara Sakasi 12).

Mysuru gears up for an exciting Invitation Cup Weekend

RACING

Vinayak M. Zodge

The Mysore Race Club on Thursday announced the programme for the 64th Indian Turf Invitation Cup Weekend, to be held on Saturday (Oct. 24) and Sunday (Oct. 25), with the Mysore Derby included in the two-day programme for the first time.

The Invitation Cup Weekend, which returns to Mysuru for the second time, having first been hosted in 2020, was originally scheduled for March but was postponed following an outbreak of glanders that disrupted racing in southern India.

The weekend will feature five Group 1 races, one Group 2 contest and 10 additional Million races, offering total stakes of ₹5.65 crore.

Saturday's programme will be highlighted by the Zavaray Poonawalla Mysore Derby, the Zavaray Poonawalla Sprinters' Cup and the Zavaray Poonawalla Stayers' Cup.

Main attractions

The main attractions on Sunday will be the Zavaray Poonawalla Indian Turf Invitation Cup, carrying stakes of ₹1.50 crore, and the Major P.K. Mehra Memorial Super Mile Cup.

The Suresh Mahindra Multi-Million, a Group 2 race, should add further interest to the programme.

Zavaray Poonawalla has sponsored four of the five Group 1 races.

The club has also acknowledged the support of other sponsors and turf clubs in making the weekend possible.

Contest of skill

A special 'contest of skill' on Sunday, organised in association with Mr. Poonawalla, will offer a Renault Kiger car as the first prize, along with two motorcycles and five smartwatches.

The two-day meeting promises to be a major occasion on the Indian racing calendar, bringing together some of the country's leading horses and professionals in this historic city.

Top TAI honour for Zavaray Poonawalla

Vinayak M. Zodge



Zavaray S. Poonawalla.
FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Zavaray S. Poonawalla, a leading racehorse owner and breeder, is set to receive the 'Legend of Indian Horse Racing Award' from the Turf Authorities of India (TAI) at the Racing Excellence Awards ceremony on October 24.

The ceremony will be held during the Indian Turf Invitation Cup Weekend, of which he is the principal sponsor.

Many roles

Proposed by Mysore Race Club and approved by the TAI chairman, the award recognises his decades-long contribution to Indian racing, whether as a breeder, owner, sponsor or benefactor.

He has helped the sport through difficult financial period, by contributing to the prize money, and has also made representations to the government against the heavy GST burden on racing. More recently, he introduced a shared-sponsorship initiative with the turf clubs.

THE PLAN

We make sure to kill the game in the PowerPlay, says Samson



ANI

You have different approaches when you have a really good start. We phrase it very differently, like PowerPlays are different, middle overs are different and the death (overs) are different. If we get off to a flyer, we make sure to kill the game in the PowerPlay itself — Sanju Samson about his blistering starts with Abhishek Sharma.

MATCH-WINNERS

This is just an example of the openers doing the job: Shreyas



AFP

They (Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma) know exactly what they're doing. Once they get going, it's just about the momentum they carry forward, and today (Thursday) was just an example of that. Once they click, they set up a game for us — India captain Shreyas Iyer lauding the openers.

PHILLIPS' TAKE

'The bounce is a bit more, but the Indian batters adjusted really well'



ANI

We had all our plans on the drawing board, but at the end of the day, you've got to execute them. The pitches are fantastic as well. The bounce is probably a little more than they're used to, and they (Indian batters) adjusted really well — Glenn Phillips, who top-scored for New Zealand with an unbeaten 82.

GAME-CHANGER

It was magnificent to see the way Dhir batted, says Shreyas



AP

He gives us a lot of options, particularly against left-hand batters (with his off-spin), even the right-handers, especially on this ground [Hagley Oval]. Bowling those two-three crucial overs can change the momentum. It was magnificent to see him bat... the way he showed calmness and composure — Shreyas Iyer on Naman Dhir.

Samson's onslaught sets up India's record chase

The opener smashes 67 off 33 balls while skipper Shreyas and Dhir chip in with vital cameos as the visiting side gets over the line with two deliveries to spare; Phillips' fireworks in vain

INDIA IN NZ

Press Trust of India
CHRISTCHURCH

Sanju Samson maintained his remarkable run this calendar year with a sublime 33-ball 67 (8x4, 4x6) as India pulled off its highest chase in T20Is, overcoming a mid-innings stumble for a four-wicket win in the series-opener against New Zealand here on Thursday.

Put in to bat, Finn Allen (45, 24b, 5x4, 2x6) and Glenn Phillips (82 n.o., 40b, 8x4, 3x6) fired New Zealand to a steep 225 for four, highlighting India's struggles with the ball.

However, Samson ensured a flying start for the visitors before a collapse made the game interesting. Eventually, cameos from captain Shreyas Iyer (42, 28b, 1x4, 2x6) and Naman Dhir (42 n.o., 15b, 5x4, 2x6) helped India get over the line with two balls to spare.

The tie looked as good as done with India racing to 94 for one in the PowerPlay.



On the rampage: Samson took the attack to the Kiwi bowlers as India seized control of the chase. AP

However, the Men in Blue faltered against the spin duo of Mitchell Santner and Michael Bracewell in the middle overs, losing three wickets for seven runs to spice up the contest.

From 93 for no loss, India slipped to 122 for four in the 11th over.

The long boundaries here also came into play as the likes of Tilak Varma and Ishan Kishan perished trying to clear the ropes.

The middle-order failed to capitalise on the electric start provided by Samson. It was the 31-year-old's eighth fifty-plus score in 26 innings this year.

Samson mainly targeted the straight boundary and his standout hit was the flick off Lockie Ferguson that went sailing over long-on.

Abhishek Sharma (29, 12b, 2x4, 3x6) was happy to play second fiddle in the 93-run opening stand. He pulled Adam Milne for consecutive sixes in the fourth over. Following the quick wickets, Shreyas took the game deep and also had luck going his way. Finn Allen dropped a tough catch in the 15th over, leaving India to get 55 runs off the last 30 balls with five wickets in hand.

Batting alongside the skipper, Dhir came up with timely strikes to release pressure.

Earlier, the Indian attack looked toothless against a rampaging Allen and Phillips.

It was the joint-highest total against India and also New Zealand's highest on home soil.

SCOREBOARD

NEW ZEALAND
Tim Seifert c Samson b Mayank 24 *(17b, 3x4, 1x6)*, Finn Allen c Tilak b Axar 45 *(24b, 5x4, 2x6)*, Daryl Mitchell c Bhuvneshwar b Arshdeep 28 *(19b, 2x4, 1x6)*, Glenn Phillips (not out) 82 *(40b, 8x4, 3x6)*, Bevon Jacobs run out 31 *(16b, 3x6)*, Michael Bracewell (not out) 7 *(6b)*; Extras (nb-2, w-6): 8; Total (for four wkts. in 20 overs): 225.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-49 (Seifert, 4.6 overs), 2-80 (Allen, 7.4), 3-122 (Mitchell, 12.1), 4-195 (Jacobs, 17.3).

INDIA BOWLING
Bhuvneshwar 4-0-49-0, Arshdeep 4-0-45-1, Mayank 4-0-40-1, Axar 4-0-51-1, Nitish 4-0-40-0.

INDIA
Sanju Samson b Santner 67 *(33b, 8x4, 4x6)*, Abhishek Sharma c Milne b Bracewell 29 *(12b, 2x4, 3x6)*, Tilak Varma c Ferguson b Bracewell 6 *(11b)*, Shreyas Iyer c Santner b Milne 42 *(28b, 1x4, 2x6)*, Ishan Kishan c Allen b Santner 1 *(3b)*, Axar Patel c sub (Conway) b Ferguson 24 *(14b, 3x4, 1x6)*, Naman Dhir (not out) 42 *(15b, 5x4, 2x6)*, Nitish Kumar (not out) 2 *(3b)*; Extras (nb-1, w-16): 17; Total (for six wkts. in 19.4 overs): 230.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-93 (Abhishek, 5.5), 2-115 (Samson, 8.6), 3-117 (Tilak, 9.3), 4-122 (Kishan, 10.3), 5-167 (Axar, 14.3), 6-210 (Shreyas, 18.1).

NEW ZEALAND BOWLING
Henry 3.4-0-57-0, Milne 3-0-43-1, Ferguson 3-0-34-1, Bracewell 4-0-37-2, Santner 4-0-39-2, Smith 2-0-20-0.

Toss: India.
PoM: Samson.
India won by four wickets with two balls remaining to lead five-match series 1-0.
Second T20I: October 24, Christchurch, 12.30 p.m. IST.

Stat Attack

1 Five Indian bowlers conceded 40-plus runs in a T20I innings for the first time. It was the 13th occasion in men's T20Is

1 India registered its highest successful T20I chase, bettering the 209 against Australia (Visakhapatnam, 2023) and New Zealand (Raipur, 2026)

2 It was also the second-highest successful chase by a team against New Zealand in T20Is after the 244 by Australia at Auckland in 2018

3 Three batters (Daryl Mitchell, Bevon Jacobs and Abhishek Sharma) smashed the first ball they faced for a six, the joint-most in a men's T20I. The only other instance (full member teams) came during the New Zealand-England T20I at Hamilton in 2018 (Liam Dawson, Chris Jordan and Colin Munro)

4 India recorded its third highest PowerPlay total (94/1) in T20Is (100/0 vs. Afghanistan, 2026; 95/1 vs. England, 2025; 94/2 vs. New Zealand, 2026). It is also the Men in Blue's best PowerPlay away from home, eclipsing the 82 they scored against Scotland in Dubai in the 2021 T20 World Cup

5 Abhishek and Sanju Samson were involved in their fifth 50-plus opening stand this year, the joint-most for India in a calendar year after K.L. Rahul-Rohit Sharma (2021) and Abhishek-Shubman Gill (2025)

7 New Zealand has lost seven of its last eight home T20Is against India, the other one a tie (DLS method) at Napier in 2022

8 Samson made his eighth 50-plus score in 2026, the joint-third (with Ishan Kishan in 2026) in the list of Indians with most T20I half-centuries in a calendar year. Only Suryakumar Yadav (11 in 2022), Virat Kohli (9 in 2022) and Abhishek (9 in 2026) have more

42 Naman Dhir's unbeaten 15-ball 42 was the highest for India (No. 7 or lower batters) in a successful T20I chase, surpassing Irfan Pathan's unbeaten 16-ball 33 (vs. Sri Lanka, Colombo, 2009)

Compiled by **ANIRUDH VELAMURI**

India starts favourite as focus shifts to ODIs

ZIMBABWE IN INDIA

Lavanya L.
VADODARA

There's little that can dent the momentum of a high-flying Indian team at home, in its favourite format - One Day Internationals - hosting a side ranked 11 places below it: Zimbabwe. More so after a dominant 3-0 sweep of the T20I leg of a historic maiden bilateral engagement.

But one thing can: injuries. Fitness issues in India's seam resources have been a thorn in the side of the reigning 50-over World champion, and its resistance faces a setback with Renuka Singh ruled out courtesy of not building the required bowling volume for 50-over cricket at the BCCI CoE.

The Women's Premier League and changes (however slow) in prioritising pace at the domestic level have pushed a greater raw pool to the doors of the team which means this type of an absence won't sting as much as it would have a few years ago. But with the inaugural Women's Champions Trophy around the corner, India will sweat over Renuka's fitness and bowling rhythm.

The task for the present, however, is to replicate its T20I dominance over the Lady Chevrons in ODIs, too. And India's bulging batting muscle perhaps has that job in the bag com-



Smriti and Nandani... a lot to cheer about. X@BCCIWOMEN

fortably. Jemimah Rodrigues' absence due to injury means the door opens for someone like Yastika Bhatia, Tejal Hasabnis or Harleen Deol.

Josephine Nkomo's side is far from a pushover, and will hope to pose a tough question or two to the ODI behemoth.

The teams (from): India: Smriti Mandhana (Capt.), Deepti Sharma (Vice-capt.), Shafali Verma, Pratika Rawal, Harmanpreet Kaur, Harleen Deol, Tejal Hasabnis, Richa Ghosh (wk), Yastika Bhatia (wk), Vaishnavi Sharma, Nandani Sharma, Shree Charani, Kranti Gaud, Sayali Satghare, Jintimani Kalita.

Zimbabwe: Josephine Nkomo (Capt.), Kelis Ndhlovu, Beloved Biza, Chipo Mugeri-Tiripano, Chiedza Dhururu (wk), Nyasha Gwanzura, Modester Mupachikwa, Sharne Mayers, Loryn Phiri, Francisca Chipare, Kudzai Chigora, Nomvelo Sibanda, Olinder Chare, Michelle Mavunga, Tendai Makusha.

Match starts at 2 p.m.

Proteas level series in style

AUSTRALIA IN SA

Agence France-Presse
GQEBERHA

South Africa wrapped up a brilliant innings and 31-run win over Australia in the second Test at St. George's Park on Thursday, levelling the three-match series.

Despite another session being washed out on the fifth day of a rain-hit game, the Proteas took the remaining six second-innings wickets to bag the victory.

Travis Head's 121 and a 166-ball 40 from night-watchman Scott Boland held up the South African charge, as did persistent rain, but Wiaan Mulder removed both. While Kagiso Rabada finished with a four-wicket haul, Marco Jansen took the final scalp by dismissing Josh Hazlewood as the reigning world Test champion set up a series decider. The tourist was bowled out for 295 in its second innings.

The scores: South Africa 425/9 decl. bt Australia 99 & 295 in 107.1 overs (Head 121, Boland 40, Rabada 4/77). **PoM:** Bavuma.



Rabada. AP



Sensational effort: Liyanage blasted an unbeaten 27-ball 61 to power the Lankans home in a high-scoring thriller. AP

Sri Lanka pulls off second-highest ODI chase after Brook show

ODI TRI-SERIES

ANI
RAWALPINDI

Sri Lanka scripted a remarkable two-wicket win against England in the third match of the ODI tri-series on Thursday, hunting down a massive target of 430 with a ball to spare. Earlier, Harry Brook's record-breaking double century had powered the Englishmen to 429 for four.

Avishka Fernando (97, 83b, 11x4, 2x6), Pavan Rathnayake (130, 106b, 15x4, 3x6), Dasun Shanaka (97, 50b, 6x4, 8x6) and Janith Liyanage (61 n.o., 27b, 7x4, 3x6) were the architects of Sri Lanka's chase.

Brook smashed 202 off 116 balls (21x4, 10x6), eclipsing Shubman Gill's record (117 balls) for the fastest double century in ODIs.

Joe Root made 69 (66b, 8x4), becoming the first Englishman to reach the 8,000-run milestone in the 50-over format.

The highest ODI chase is South Africa's 438 (for nine) while pursuing Australia's 435 in Johannesburg in 2006.

The scores: England 429/4 in 50 overs (Tom Banton 50, Joe Root 69, Harry Brook 202, Will Jacks 66 n.o.) lost to Sri Lanka 430/8 in 49.5 overs (Avishka Fernando 97, Pavan Rathnayake 130, Dasun Shanaka 97, Janith Liyanage 61 n.o.). **PoM:** Rathnayake.



Brook... quickest double ton. AP

Ashmita stuns Yamaguchi to make quarters

FRENCH OPEN

Press Trust of India
PARIS

Ashmita Chaliha stole the show as she stunned World No. 2 and third seed Akane Yamaguchi of Japan to move into the French Open women's quarterfinals here on Thursday. P.V. Sindhu joined her compatriot in the last-eight stage after she beat another Japanese shuttler, Riko Gunji.

Unseeded Ashmita defeated Yamaguchi 21-19, 21-18 in a second-round match that lasted 37 minutes. Sindhu prevailed 21-12, 21-16 over Gunji while Tanvi Sharma bowed out with a 11-21, 14-21 defeat at the hands of World No. 1 and top seed An Se-young of South Korea.

In men's singles, Ayush Shetty forfeited his match against sixth seed Kodai Naraoka of Japan due to an undisclosed injury when trailing 17-21, 6-11.



Ashmita... in disbelief. BADMINTON PHOTO



Top class: Gold winners Toman and Sheetal (compound mixed), Shailesh (high jump) and Dharmaraj (long jump).

Sheetal earns double gold; Indians continue to shine in athletics

PARA ASIAN GAMES

Press Trust of India
NAGOYA

Armless archer Sheetal Devi secured two gold medals in the space of two hours while the track-and-field contingent remained the biggest contributor to India's tally that swelled to 88 at the Asian Para Games here on Thursday.

India has 21 gold, 26 silver and 41 bronze as medals also came from swimming, badminton and table tennis. Sheetal combined with Toman Kumar to defend the mixed team gold against Indonesia's Teodora Audi Ayudia Ferelly and Ken Swagumilang 151-148.

She then overcame a four-point deficit to defeat Singapore's Alim Nur Syahidah 142-139 in a repeat of the 2023 individual final.

Suvarna Raj won women's F54 discus throw with 15.66m, the wheelchair-bound 44-year-old recording four efforts beyond 15m. Shailesh Kumar led the sweep of the men's T63 high jump event. Shailesh, who had bagged long jump bronze on Wednesday, leapt a Games record 1.89m. Varun Bhati took silver with a season's best of 1.84m while Rahul completed the podium with 1.81m.

Sprinters Anjanaben Bumbadiya (59.97s) and Dilip Mahadu Gavit (48.27s) won gold in their respective T47 400m competitions. Jayanti Behera (1:00.65) came second to Anajanaben. Long jumper Dharmaraj Solairaj defended his Games crown with an Asian record of 7.15m in the T44/T62/T64 combined event.

Teenaged swimmer Ravi Budigina (25.89s) completed a hat-trick of medals with a bronze in the men's S13 50m freestyle event.

SNAPSHOTS



Anahat stuns El Sherbini, reaches quarterfinals

World No. 15 Anahat Singh stunned the No. 3-ranked Nour El Sherbini 11-8, 11-8, 11-7 in the second round to storm into the women's quarterfinals of the Silicon Valley Open squash, a $143,500 PSA Gold event, in Redwood City (USA).

Bangalore Winter season to begin on November 1

The Bangalore Winter season will begin on November 1 and the concluding meeting will be on March 13, 2027 in the 24-day race season. The Zavaray S. Poonawalla Bangalore Derby will be held on January 26.

The race dates: November: 1, 8, 13, 20, 27, 28; **December:** 4, 11, 12, 18, 25: **January:** 2, 8, 9, 15, 25, 26; **February:** 5, 12, 13, 19, 27; **March:** 12, 13.

Marathon runner Aga banned for six years

One of the world's leading marathon runners, Ruti Aga, has been banned for six years after track and field's anti-doping investigators found she submitted a fake prescription to explain a failed drug test. The Ethiopian runner had won the Tokyo Marathon in 2019 and reached the podium at the Berlin and New York Marathons. She tested positive for the banned substance methylprednisolone after winning a half-marathon in China in March.

Tour de France will visit three nations

The 2027 Tour de France will visit three nations in the first three days before competitors put in the most time trial kilometers in 15 years. The Tour will start in Scotland capital Edinburgh on July 2. It will then go to England and Wales before moving to France, where it will be held till July 25.

LIVE TELECAST

India Women vs. Zimbabwe Women: First ODI, Star Sports 2 & JioHotstar, 2 p.m.

ISL: Sony LIV app, 5 p.m.



Cracking start: Chiara was rewarded for her positive intent. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chiara's aggressive play hands her the early lead

The Swiss goes all out at the start, earning shots on three of her first four holes; Shannon, the only golfer to go bogey-free in the first round, sits tied-second; Pranavi and Avani joint fifth

INDIAN OPEN GOLF

Uthra Ganesan
GURUGRAM

Shannon Tan preferred consistency over flamboyance, playing a bogey-free opening round in her title defence of the Hero Women's Indian Open here on Thursday for a share of the second spot, even as Chiara Tamburlini rocked the DLF Golf and Country Club with aggressive play to go top of the leaderboard.

Chiara delivered a five-under 67 on a tricky course that has tested the best over the years, racking up seven birdies and dropping shots on the seventh and 15th holes to finish one stroke ahead of Shannon and Argentine Magdalena Simmermacher (tied on 68).

Pranavi Urs and Avani Prashanth led the Indian charge and were part of a five-way tie at fifth spot with two-under 70.

Shannon, playing a cautious game, was the only player to not drop a shot on the day, her four birdies – two each on the front and back nines – helping her stay close to the top.

The Singaporean later said that going "bogey-free" on the sloping, softer greens was good enough for a start.

"I hit it pretty well off the tee and in regulation. I actually missed a few shots out there, like the putts that didn't drop. But overall, I'm bogey-free, and I will take that any day, especially on this course."

The approach was a contrast to Chiara's, the Swiss beginning with a bang to earn shots on three of the first four holes. She added two more on consecutive holes – ninth and 10th – but bogeyed twice. Pranavi, meanwhile, was content with a sedate round that had her struggling at times to keep the ball in play, a bad stomach not helping matters.

Top scores: 67: Chiara Tamburlini (Sui); **68:** Shannon Tan (Sin), Magdalena Simmermacher (Arg); **69:** Sara Kouskova (Cze); **70:** Pranavi Urs, Lois Lau (Fra), Avani Prashanth, Eleanor Givens (Eng).

Important to be backed as a spinner, says Shokeen

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

In recent seasons, Delhi's spin department in the Ranji Trophy has been a revolving door. Many tweakers have been tried and moved on without a semblance of stability.

Off-spinning all-rounder Hrithik Shokeen has had a taste of the environment. He made his First Class debut against Assam in December 2022, but has just played 17 games in five seasons.

That includes one Duleep Trophy outing for India-C against India-D in 2024. In the last two Ranji campaigns, he appeared in two games each.

Having taken his maiden five-for on Wednesday, the 26-year-old will hope for a longer run now. He plugged away for 53 overs in Gujarat's first innings on a turgid track at the Palam 'B' ground and yielded returns of five for 143.



Hrithik Shokeen. R.V. MOORTHY

"It is my first five-for. So, it is very special," he told reporters.

"I have spoken to coach Vijay Dahiya. He did say that our spinners have not been doing well. But he has given me confidence that I can do well. That backing is very important."

> I got injured last season. I have felt that Delhi has backed me. I had a setback because of the injury.

While it appears puzzling that Shokeen has had just 12 appearances across formats since December 2024, he disclosed that a stress fracture in his lower back has also contributed to the sporadic game time.

"I got injured last season. I have felt that Delhi has backed me. I had a setback because of the injury. My physio did say it was unusual for a spinner to have a back injury.

"I have worked on my bowling action as a result. I have improved the follow-through," Shokeen revealed.

Challenging, but a lot of fun: Aussie umpire Treloar embraces Ranji Trophy stint

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

For Australian umpire Ben Treloar, the last week in India has been an enriching experience.

The 44-year-old, as part of an exchange programme for umpires between the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and Cricket Australia, was in the national capital for the Ranji Trophy encounter between Delhi and Gujarat.

Treloar will officiate one more Ranji game, between Mumbai and Haryana next week, before returning home.

"Incredibly challenging to come into a new environment, one that's foreign to me, and umpire this high level of First Class cricket here in India," Treloar said of his first Ranji game.

"It's been challenging, but a lot of fun as well. The great thing about this opportunity is being able to learn, being put under pressure in different conditions, and just learning more about yourself, the game, and umpiring as well."



Treloar. R.V. MOORTHY

Though Treloar has stood in 30 First Class games in Australia, the docile strip at the Palam 'B' ground was very different to what he had encountered back home.

It resulted in a lot of overs on the field in the first innings of both teams, with Delhi piling up a mammoth 648 for six declared in 136.4 overs and Gujarat responding with 479 in 174.1 overs.

"The main difference for me this week has been the type of pitch that we played on. In more recent times, there has been quite a bit of moisture, grass, and significant bounce on the pitches at the big stadiums around Australia," he observed.

"To umpire on a black-soil pitch this week, where it was a little bit slower as the game moved on and didn't break up at all, was a really good challenge. It was the first time I've umpired an innings where a team scored 650 (sic). It might be flat, but that doesn't mean it's easy".

Manvanth's emergence is a breath of fresh air for Karnataka cricket

N. Sudarshan
BENGALURU



On fire: Manvanth says he doesn't wanted to be in a comfort zone and that cricket is the only thing on his mind. SUDHAKARA JAIN

Manvanth Kumar plays cricket with freedom and flair. He rarely tucks his shirt in, is loose-limbed, bowls and fields with frantic energy, and loves the big hits.

Against Saurashtra recently, in only his second First Class match, the 22-year-old conjured up an awe-inspiring 135 (214b, 11x4, 6x6) after coming in at No. 9, with the score at 187 for seven.

Karnataka collected just one point from the match, and has a lowly two from its opening two Ranji Trophy fixtures, but Manvanth's emergence – 223 runs in four innings – has been a breath of fresh air.

Interestingly, Manvanth first made a mark as a fast bowler. With 22 wickets, he was the leading wicket-taker in Hubli Tigers' title-win in the 2023 Maharaja Trophy KSCA T20. In Karnataka's 2023-24 Col. C.K. Nayudu (U-23) Trophy triumph, he took five for 36 in the final against Uttar Pradesh.

In a wonderful co-incidence, R. Vinay Kumar, Karnataka's current head coach, was Manvanth's mentor at Hubli Tigers. R. Smaran, under whom Manvanth made his First Class debut in Andhra ten days ago, captained him during the C.K. Nayudu triumph.

"He's one of few players in the current crop who can make it big," said Vinay. "He is a stroke-maker, and my message to him is clear – express yourself. The kind of strength and reach he has, he can score those big 100s.

"He's a very good bowler too, and can easily touch 135-plus. We don't have that many good fast-bowling all-rounders in India. This guy can be there," the former India pacer added.

Like Vinay, Manvanth too hails from a modest background. He grew up in Mysuru, and his father was a Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTC) bus driver, who now runs a travel agency.

Two years ago, Manvanth shifted to Bengaluru, lock, stock and barrel, having discontinued his studies at Maharaja's College, in pursuit of his cricketing dream.

"I never wanted to be in a comfort zone," Manvanth said. "I always wanted to build a career in Bengaluru. I have no distractions now. Cricket is the only thing on my mind."

Come Monday, he will line up against Tripura at the SDNR Wadiyar Stadium inside the University of Mysore campus.

Debutant Como schools Manchester United

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Manchester United was hammered 4-1 by Como in the Champions League on Wednesday as the pressure increased on beleaguered manager Michael Carrick, while a late Declan Rice equaliser earned Arsenal a 2-2 draw away to Bayern Munich.

Elsewhere, Real Madrid thumped RB Leipzig 4-1 and there were also notable victories for Inter Milan, Aston Villa and Real Betis.

The most remarkable scoreline, though, came in driving rain on the banks of Lake Como, where United suffered its joint-heaviest loss in the Champions League in the last 30 years.

Nico Paz scored twice for Cesc Fabregas's Como, with Tasos Douvikas and Jacobo Ramon getting the other goals. This was a second 4-1 home win in this season's competition for the tournament debutant.

Joshua Zirkzee pulled one back at the death for United, but it is now seven games without a win in all competitions.

Last season's beaten finalist Arsenal has seven from a possible nine after Rice struck in the 82nd minute to earn a draw in Munich.

Bukayo Saka went off injured early on but his replacement Eberechi Eze fired Arsenal into the lead, only for Alphonso Davies to level before the interval.



Impactful: Paz, centre, was the team's heartbeat with two goals and an assist. REUTERS

Harry Kane set up that goal with a magnificent pass and then gave Bayern the lead from a second-half penalty, his 10th strike this season in all competitions.

But Arsenal hit back as Bayern registered a second straight Champions League stalemate.

"We looked dangerous, we got the goal and we had a moment there where we could have killed off the game," Kane told broadcaster DAZN.

"Probably a draw was a fair result overall... There's a lot of games and we've got players with injuries, players missing tonight, so we take the point and move on."

Jose Mourinho's Real is one of five teams with three wins from three in this season's Champions League, as goals either side of half-time from Bernardo Silva and Arda Guler set it on its way at the Bernabeu.

Kylian Mbappe made it 12 goals in 12 games this season for Real before Tidiam Gomis pulled one back, but Yan Diomande completed Real's victory with a spectacular volley against his former club.

Villa also has a perfect record after three games, as it won 3-1 at home to Viking Stavanger with Ross Barkley's opener being followed by Emiliano Buendia's penalty and Henrik Heggheim's own goal.

Peter Christiansen got one back for the Norwegian champion which is still looking for its first win.

Inter had Alessandro Bastoni sent off midway through the second half before Carlos Augusto's late goal secured a 1-0 win at home to Shakhtar Donetsk.

Betis has maximum points as an Isco penalty handed it a 1-0 win over Feyenoord in Seville.

The results: Lille 2 (Diaoune 7, 39) lost to Galatasaray 4 (Akgun 2, Batrakov 44, Bentaleb 52-og, Osimhen 61); Como 4 (Paz 2, 57, Douvikas 49, Ramon 76) bt Manchester United 1 (Zirkzee 90+1).

Bayern Munich 2 (Davies 35, Kane 61-pen) drew with Arsenal 2 (Eze 25, Rice 82).

Real Madrid 4 (Silva 44, Guler 52, Mbappe 83, Diomande 87) bt RB Leipzig 1 (Gomis 85); Inter Milan 1 (Carlos Augusto 77) bt Shakhtar Donetsk 0.

Sporting 2 (Suarez 5-pen, 89) lost to LASK Linz 3 (Lang 15, Kalajdzic 63, Danek 68).

Aston Villa 3 (Barkley 23, Buendia 37-pen, Heggheim 62-og) bt Viking 1 (Christiansen 85); Club Brugge 3 (Vanaken 45+3, Seys 50, Forbs 72) bt Lens 0; Real Betis 1 (Isco 59-pen) bt Feyenoord 0.

Naman Dhir — teeing off in style

Nine international outings hardly constitute a significant or substantial sample size, and it is important not to get carried away and anoint Dhir the next big thing in Indian cricket, as has become a trend if not a habit

What has stood out in his brief foray at the highest level is his composure and calmness under pressure, and his ability to back his strengths and clear boundaries with consummate ease



AP

R. Kaushik

Naman Dhir loves a flourish. He has made only 110 international runs in six innings across the two white-ball formats, but 88 of those – a staggering 80% – have come through boundaries. The powerful right-hander has smashed 10 fours and eight sixes from the 49 deliveries he has faced in One-Day International and Twenty20 International cricket, which has helped him stack up impressive strike-rates of 142.85 and 285.71 respectively.

These are very early days for the 26-year-old from Ambala. Nine international outings hardly constitute a significant or substantial sample size, and it is important not to get carried away and anoint him the next big thing in Indian cricket, as has become a trend if not a habit. He will come up short, maybe even in his next fixture, but what has stood out in his brief foray at the highest level is his composure and calmness under pressure, and his ability to back his strengths and clear boundaries with consummate ease, no matter their length.

No surprise

Given his propensity to make a statement with the bat, it should have come as no surprise that he signalled India's victory in the first T20I against New Zealand in Christchurch with a six. Alright, so it came off a top edge as he tried to pull Matt Henry over mid-wicket and only managed to deposit it over the fine-leg fence, but that slice of luck was no more than he deserved as he played a stellar role in India mounting a record chase after New Zealand had motored away to 225 for four.

It was New Zealand's highest T20I total against India, and their joint sixth-highest overall, once again exposing the lack of bite in the visitors' bowling despite a first bowl in nearly four years for the country for Bhuvneshwar Kumar, the seasoned 36-year-old. There were periods, especially in the first half of the New Zealand innings, when the Indian bowlers kept things under check. But the hosts rattled along at nearly 13 an over in their second half on the back of a blistering unbeaten 82 from Glenn Phillips and a telling final kick from Bevon Jacobs.

For the first time in his fledgling T20I stint, Dhir did not get a bowl. His previous over, against West Indies in Hyderabad just over a week ago, went for 19, and Shreyas Iyer opted not to turn to the off-spinner, instead, using Nitish Kumar's full complement as the fifth bowler. Perhaps, the Indian captain's decision was influenced by the experienced Axar Patel's left-arm spin going for 51 in his four overs, but then again, with Nitish doing a reasonably tidy job - his economy of 10 an over was the joint best for an Indian on the night, alongside the rapid Mayank Yadav - Shreyas had no cause to turn to Dhir.

If he hasn't already, Dhir could soon supplant Washington as the preferred off-spinning all-rounder – Shreyas would be well advised to use his bowling nous too more often

Maybe, Shreyas knew - the benefit of hindsight? - that Dhir had something special to bring to the table on a cold, dewy Thursday night in the South Island. For India to mount a record chase in New Zealand, they needed many things to go their way - for the openers to lay a solid, fiery platform, for the middle-order to weigh in and for someone to take the game by the scruff of the knock and apply the finishing touches that often look so straightforward but are instead fraught with immense pressure and danger, especially after one or two dot balls.

Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma ticked the first box with a breathtaking opening salvo spanning a mere 35 deliveries, largely dominated by the right-hander from Kerala. It's not often that Abhishek gets so extraordinarily overshadowed that his contribution in an alliance of 93 is only 29, though in his favour is the fact that he got to face 23 deliveries fewer than Samson during that period. When the left-hander was dismissed by offie Michael Bracewell off the penultimate delivery of the PowerPlay, he had put India in the driver's seat, having struck two fours and three sixes during his 12-ball blitz.

Samson hammered 67 at better than two runs a ball but when he, Tilak Varma and Ishan Kishan - the two left-handers swapped places with the vice-captain moving up to No. 3 and the diminutive Kishan slotting in at No. 5 - were dismissed within seven runs of each other in the space of 10 deliveries, India were in a spot at 122 for four, needing a further 104 in 57 deliveries. As much as keeping in touch with the required rate was the pressing need to steady the ship and that's precisely what Shreyas and Axar did. Axar provided the impetus too with 24 off 14, exiting the scene to herald the arrival at the batting crease of Dhir.

The key

The consensus at the time, with victory 61 runs away and just 33 deliveries in which to be attained, was that Shreyas held the key, even though India batted deep with Dhir at No. 7 and Nitish at No. 8. Apart from being the captain, Shreyas' credentials are second to none and he has shown time and again that he is immune to the tension that comes with a stiff target ahead of him. But it couldn't be Shreyas alone who did the heavy lifting. India needed to score quickly from both ends with the required rate bordering on 12, which is when Dhir stepped up to deliver the knockout blows.

In domestic T20s, and in the IPL for Mumbai Indians, Dhir has shown himself to be a crisp ball-striker who is unafraid to hit in the air. In the position where he bats, at No. 6 or No. 7 (as was the case on this night), he is seldom required to do anything more than tee off from ball one. When he walked out to carry forward India's spirited chase, he couldn't have asked for a more dramatic script to leave his imprint.

Last Saturday in Bengaluru, in the final T20I against West Indies which eventually met a watery end, Dhir had reiterated the power and timing that nestles in his lithe, wiry frame. In a match reduced to nine overs a side due to inclement weather, India had reached 88 with 17 deliveries remaining when Dhir strode out at No. 6 to link up with Tilak. Over the next nine minutes and six balls, he made a spectacular impact. Nine minutes? Six balls? Spectacular impact? You've got to be kidding.

Ah, but we kid you not. Three of those six deliveries soared over the fence, propelled by strong forearms and impeccable timing. As he eased his left foot down the track and struck the ball over long-off, aesthetics and result grappled for attention. There was a certain nonchalance to his ball-smacking that reminded us - whisper, whisper - of a mirror image from a past era of another debonair batter from Punjab, who answers to the name of Yuvraj Singh. Dhir doesn't have the same swagger as Yuvi - it's unlikely that he, or anyone else, can replicate that - but there was an unmistakable air of authority that was cruelly, rudely washed away by the elements that ended India's innings, and the match, after 7.4 overs.

Dhir was unbeaten on 24, courtesy one four and three sixes, finishing with a strike rate of 400. Coming on the back of his 30 off 21 deliveries in his only bat in ODIs in New Chandigarh, his nominal home ground, last month, it suggested that here was a batter who, at No. 6 or No. 7, provided an additional power-hitting option to go with Shivam Dube and Nitish.

What Dhir did therefore at the Hagley Oval was not miraculous or completely out of the blue. New Zealand knew what he was capable of - several of the Kiwis have done battle with and against him in the IPL - and realised, even after Shreyas' fall with 20 needed off 11, that the game was far from over. Their worst fears came true with Dhir pummelling an unbeaten 42 off just 15 deliveries, propelled by five fours and two sixes.

Unflustered

Nitish's share in the unbroken seventh-wicket stand of 20 was just two, with Dhir contributing 18 in just six deliveries, among them two fours and a six. Unflustered in the middle, refusing to pre-meditate and backing himself not to blink in his first match for the country away from home, Dhir brought up victory with four deliveries to spare, ensuring that the breakneck opening stand didn't go in vain or that the mid-innings collapse did not pull the team down.

If he hasn't already, Dhir could soon supplant Washington Sundar as the preferred off-spinning all-rounder – Shreyas would be well advised to use his bowling nous too more often.

Dhir has five T20I scalps, but beware if you hit him for a six because each of those five wickets has come a ball after the batter has carted him beyond the boundary buntings.

Unless he bowls more often, he won't become more attuned to the challenges of the middle overs, and even though conditions in New Zealand may not encourage too many stints with the ball, Dhir will have his opportunities next month, when Sri Lanka come calling, and beyond.

To many, Dhir was the obvious choice for the Player-of-the-Match award which instead went to Samson for his tone-setting 33-ball 67. But especially at this stage of his career, Dhir is less interested in such 'mundane' things and more invested in setting himself up as a permanent choice. And in any case, team before self has been the mantra of Indian cricket for a while now, so why should Dhir be any different?

THE GIST

- In domestic T20s, and in the IPL for Mumbai Indians, Dhir has shown himself to be a crisp ball-striker who is unafraid to hit in the air
- Dhir's performance at the Hagley Oval on Thursday was not miraculous or completely out of the blue. New Zealand knew what he was capable of — several of the Kiwis have done battle with and against him in the IPL

Is a sugar-rich diet while on antibiotics a threat to the gut microbiome?

Recent research suggests that what we eat while taking antibiotics may determine just how badly our gut microbial ecosystem is disturbed; the emerging challenge for medicine is how to kill harmful bacteria while preserving the microbial communities that help keep the human body healthy

Biju Dharmapalan

Antibiotics are among modern medicine's greatest lifesaving discoveries. They have transformed once-dangerous bacterial infections into treatable conditions and remain indispensable in cancer care, surgery, and infectious disease management. But antibiotics come with side effects – the primary being they do not always distinguish between harmful bacteria and the enormous community of beneficial microorganisms living inside our gut.

Recent research suggests that what we eat while taking antibiotics may determine just how badly this microbial ecosystem is disturbed. In particular, sugar-rich foods may worsen antibiotic-induced damage to the gut microbiome.

A study published in *Nature* examined the relationship between diet, antibiotics, and the gut microbiome in patients undergoing allogeneic haematopoietic cell transplantation. The researchers analysed an unusually detailed dataset – 9,419 meals consumed by 173 patients, alongside more than 1,000 stool samples from 158 patients.

Their findings point to an important question. Could the food we eat while taking antibiotics influence how quickly our microbial ecosystem recovers?



Vibrant system: The human intestine is home to trillions of microorganisms, constituting a vital ecology for digestion, metabolism, and immunological control. GETTY IMAGES

The invisible ecosystem inside us

The human intestine is home to trillions of microorganisms.

The gut microbiota, comprising bacteria and other microorganisms, constitutes a vital ecology for digestion, metabolism, and immunological control. A population of 'good bacteria' alone, however, does not determine a healthy microbiome: other factors such as equilibrium, diversity, and the interrelations among myriad microbial species play a major role as well. When this ecological equilibrium is disrupted, it may result in dysbiosis, a condition characterised by reduced microbial diversity and the proliferation of a few other organisms.

Antibiotics are a major cause of such disruption. This is especially evident in patients undergoing intensive medical treatments such as blood or bone-marrow transplantation, where antibiotics may be combined with chemotherapy, radiation, and other interventions that further stress the intestinal ecosystem. The new study reveals that diet can become an important additional factor.

Studying diet and the microbiome is notoriously difficult. People eat different foods every day, and conventional dietary questionnaires often depend on memory. The researchers overcame some of these limitations by studying patients who were hospitalised for haematopoietic cell transplantation.

Because their meals could be recorded repeatedly and stool samples collected over time, the investigators could examine diet and microbiome changes almost day by day.

They recorded thousands of individual meals and classified foods into groups such as grains, vegetables, fruits, meats, milk, oils, and sweets. They then compared dietary intake with changes in the gut microbiome.

One pattern stood out. When broad-spectrum antibiotics were being used, higher consumption of sweets and sugars was associated with a sharper decline in microbial diversity.

The researchers estimated that for every additional 100 grams of sweets consumed following broad-spectrum antibiotic exposure, mean microbial diversity decreased by about 24% compared with samples without previous antibiotic exposure.

A separate analysis based on macronutrients similarly found an additional decrease of about 20.6% for every 100 grams of sugar. In other words, sugar appeared to act less like an independent villain and more like an amplifier of antibiotic-induced disruption.

The most intriguing finding involved *Enterococcus*, particularly *Enterococcus faecium*. Under normal conditions, the gastrointestinal tract harbours a diverse microbial consortium in which many organisms vie for resources and ecological niches. Many of these competitors can be killed or inhibited by antibiotics, allowing only more resistant or adaptable organisms to survive. *Enterococcus* is one such organism. It can become an important cause of antibiotic-resistant bloodstream infections and has been associated with adverse outcomes in patients undergoing haematopoietic cell transplantation. The study showed that higher sweet intake during antibiotic exposure was associated with increased *E. faecium* abundance.

The researchers also tested their hypothesis in mouse models. When mice were fed sucrose along with an antibiotic, the *Enterococci* population increased 16.3-fold on day three and 33.4-fold on day six, compared with antibiotic treatment without additional sucrose. In cultures with only sucrose, enterococcal levels did not increase. This indicates that sugar alone has no effect without antibiotics; the problem arises when antibiotics disturb the gut ecosystem.

The study also showed that this disturbance did not take place due to low fibre intake.

Should we avoid sugar with antibiotics?

Not really. Though the study signals a warning, it does not provide concrete evidence that everyone taking antibiotics will experience the same effect. The human participants in the study were seriously ill patients undergoing intensive cancer treatment, not healthy adults taking a short course of antibiotics for a routine infection.

The researchers themselves point out several limitations. Almost all patients initially received prophylactic antibiotics, while broader-spectrum antibiotics were introduced when clinically indicated. The need for these antibiotics could itself reflect greater illness severity. Dietary information outside hospital-provided food was also incomplete, and treatment-related symptoms could influence what patients chose to eat.

Therefore, the findings should not be interpreted as a reason to discontinue medically necessary antibiotics – or to impose restrictive diets on vulnerable patients without medical supervision. Instead, they open an intriguing area for further research.

Rethinking antibiotic prescriptions

When doctors prescribe an antibiotic, the prescription traditionally focuses on the drug: which antibiotic, what dose, and for how long. Emerging microbiome science suggests we may eventually need to think more broadly. Perhaps an antibiotic prescription could one day include advice on how to protect the microbial ecosystem during treatment.

The new *Nature* study suggests that temporarily reducing foods rich in simple sugars could be one possible strategy. But prospective clinical trials must demonstrate whether this actually improves patient outcomes. The authors explicitly call for such studies.

The larger lesson extends beyond sugar. Our gut is an ecosystem, not merely a digestive tube. Medicines, food, and microbes constantly interact within it. An antibiotic may be prescribed to eliminate an infection, but it inevitably changes the microbial environment in which thousands of other organisms live.

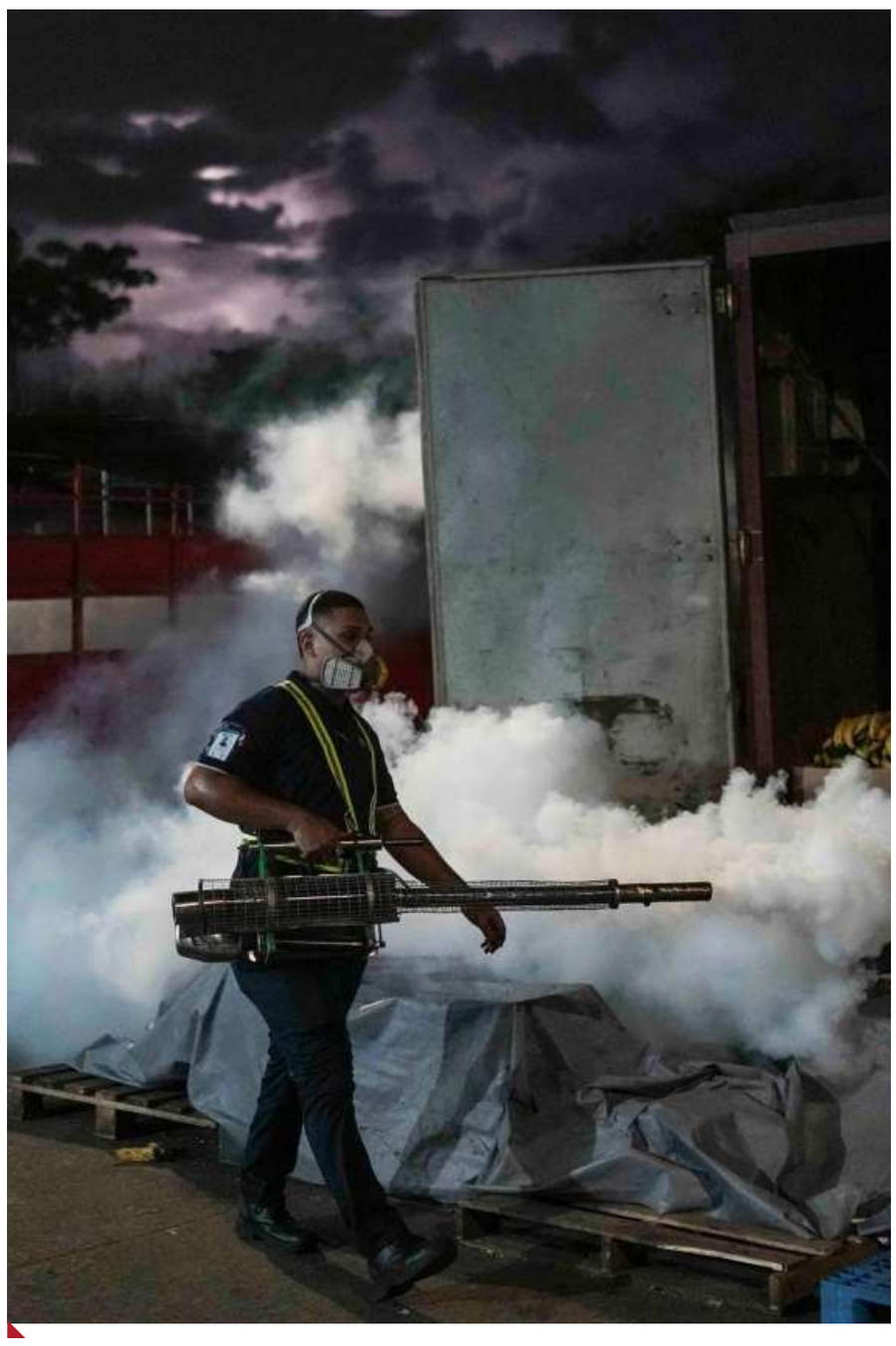
The emerging challenge for medicine is therefore not simply how to kill harmful bacteria**,** but how to do so while preserving the microbial communities that help keep us healthy. And sometimes, the difference may lie not only in the medicine we take – but also in what we put on our plate while taking it.

(Dr.Biju Dharmapalan is an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, IISc campus, Bengaluru, and dean, academic affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru. bijudharmapalan@gmail.com)

THE GIST

- The human intestine is home to trillions of microorganisms constituting a vital ecology
- Several factors such as equilibrium, diversity, and the interrelations among myriad microbial species play a major role in maintaining a healthy microbial ecosystem
- When this ecological equilibrium is disrupted, it may result in dysbiosis, a condition characterised by reduced microbial diversity and the proliferation of a few other organisms
- Antibiotics are a major cause of such disruption: this is especially evident in patients undergoing intensive medical treatments where antibiotics may be combined with other interventions that further stress the intestinal ecosystem

BIG SHOT



Smoking out: A Panamanian health worker fumigates a market to control mosquitoes and prevent the spread of malaria following reports of several cases in Panama City on October 16. AP

Chemical signatures could help detect diseases early, but accuracy and access remain challenges

Athira Elssa Johnson

Why does one person develop memory problems while another experiences seizures or changes in behaviour? And how do doctors find out whether these symptoms are caused by Alzheimer's disease, an immune disorder, or something else?

Sometimes, the answers may lie in tiny changes in the body's chemistry. Diseases can cause certain proteins and other molecules to appear in different amounts or behave differently. By measuring these changes, doctors can find clues as to what is happening inside the body, even when the cause is not immediately obvious.

These clues, called chemical signatures or biomarkers, are being studied to improve the diagnosis of several diseases, particularly those affecting the brain and nervous system.

The challenge is to establish what these changes mean, how reliably they point to a particular disease, and whether patients can access the tests.



Chemical signatures or biomarkers, are being studied to improve diagnosis of several diseases, particularly those affecting the brain and nervous system. GETTY IMAGES

What are chemical signatures?

A chemical signature is a unique pattern of molecules, elements, isotopes, or by-products identified in a sample by analytical instruments such as spectrometers or chromatographs. "Chemical signatures are like the body's fingerprints," says Sreenivas U.M., consultant neurologist, Apollo Speciality Hospitals, Vanagaram, Chennai. When a disease develops, the balance of certain chemicals or proteins may change, providing clues to the problem, he adds.

In Alzheimer's disease, for instance, doctors and researchers look for changes in proteins called amyloid-beta and tau. Certain forms of these proteins can be measured in blood and cerebrospinal fluid, the liquid surrounding the brain and spinal cord. Tests measuring phosphorylated tau, particularly p-tau217, can help identify changes associated with Alzheimer's disease.

Researchers are also studying alpha-synuclein, a protein associated with Parkinson's disease. In another condition, autoimmune encephalitis, tests that detect antibodies directed against particular brain proteins can help identify an immune response affecting the brain.

This condition can cause seizures, memory problems and changes in behaviour.

Detecting symptoms

Finding these changes also does not always mean an individual has, or is going to have a particular disease. The distinction is important: a test may identify changes associated with Alzheimer's disease, but doctors still need to consider the person's symptoms and overall health before deciding what those results mean.

Chemical signatures can also help distinguish conditions that appear similar. Autoimmune encephalitis, for example, may initially be mistaken for a psychiatric illness because it can cause behavioural changes and problems with memory. Identifying specific antibodies can help doctors recognise the condition and begin appropriate treatment. "In neurosurgery, examining the molecular characteristics of a brain tumour can help doctors classify it and decide on treatment," says Aqib M., senior consultant neurosurgeon, Dr. Mehta's Hospitals, Chennai. Selected molecular tests are already used in specialist practice. Researchers are also studying markers such as neurofilament light, a protein that can indicate damage to nerve cells, he adds. However, not every promising test is ready for routine use. Some markers indicate damage that can occur in several diseases rather than identifying one specific condition.

Testing and diagnosis

A chemical signature cannot always give the full picture. Age, kidney function, medication and other illnesses can affect the levels of certain molecules. Doctors consider the patient's symptoms, medical history and examination findings, along with brain scans and other investigations when necessary.

Cost and availability pose further challenges in India. Specialised tests may not be offered at every hospital, and patients may have to travel to larger centres to access them. Differences in laboratory methods can also affect how consistently results are interpreted.

So, for patients, chemical signatures could mean clearer answers and shorter waits for a diagnosis. But their importance lies not just in detecting changes in the body, but in understanding what those changes mean.

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